All We Have Is Yesterday Esa Saily

Chapter 1.1

Cash woke to the sound of rain. In Vancouver, rain was not extreme weather but the price of its greenness. Just like yesterday, drops drummed on the roof, and a gutter clogged with leaves had created what looked like a mini Niagara Falls on the balcony of their corner apartment.

Cash's stiff morning body told him he had probably slept in the wrong position. He remembered Kate had been sleeping on his arm, more than once, and it had gone completely numb, more than twice. He had lifted his hand carefully, like it was a construction crane, and waited for the feeling to return. That worried him often at night. Could an arm one day refuse to return to normal and quit like an overworked employee?

The light of dawn peeked through carelessly arranged curtains, which left small but annoying gaps to see the morning. Blackout curtains, of course, did not work when you left spaces between them, as Cash had sometimes tried to point out politely and as respectfully as he possibly could. Kate had replied by listing things Cash himself did. Kate was absolutely right. When you took out the garbage, it was obviously nicer for the next person if you put a new bag in the bin right away. The sofa and bed pillows were supposed to be arranged in a certain way. That was a logic Cash had never learned, not even in his previous relationships. So he had learned to take a photo of the new order whenever new pillows appeared. Maybe it was its own art form, one that men simply never got the basics of, no matter how hard they tried. Kate had called it a fixed mindset. Cash leaned on it being a trait of a growth mindset.

Cash reached for his phone, which was lying on the floor. Kate believed phones emitted harmful radiation, even though Cash had tried to explain that the phone only gave off heat. Unfortunately, his own evidence-driven searches had led him to a small side note about the possible effects of Bluetooth and Wi-Fi. Even though there was no reliable evidence, Cash had agreed to a compromise and promised to keep his phone under the bed at night.

In Kate's ideal world, phones would have been left completely outside the bedroom. The idea was beautiful, but it felt a little too ascetic. Of course, Cash admired those who had cut themselves off from social media and switched their smartphones back to early 2000s models. He just was not one of them.

The light from the phone was awfully bright, even though the brightness was set to the lowest possible level.

6:30

Cash blinked again. Something was wrong.

Tuesday, April 12.

No, that had already been yesterday. He frowned and locked and unlocked the screen. The date did not change. He had definitely forgotten something. Had daylight savings time started? No, that had happened a month ago. Badminton night had also been yesterday, and it had been on Tuesdays for the past six months. He thought he must still be dreaming and seeing the a strange lucid dream that he could soon tell Kate about. Or had everyone arrived for the games a day too early yesterday, and no one had noticed they were at the sports hall on Monday instead of Tuesday? That would have required far too many variables.

Kate's phone was on the floor next to Cash's identical iPhone. Cash tapped the lock button and noticed the same thing. It was full of notifications.

The deeper he got lost in the world of news, the less everything felt like a hacker's late April Fool's joke. A single hacker could have altered the feeds of individual news sites, or rolled systems back to an earlier state that just happened to be yesterday, but it seemed too big to rewrite all of this shared virtual reality. In the end, even if nothing had changed in the physical world, the wrong date left a strange aftertaste, like salt in popcorn, for those in the UK.

But who would really have had a motive for that? Maybe a superpower that wanted to show, without hurting anyone, that they could control every device in the world if they wanted to. People were too dependent on the digital world. On this topic, Cash agreed with Kate.

"Morning," Kate said as she was opening her eyes, her voice still sleepy. Then she woke up to the silence and saw Cash's furrowed brow.

"What's wrong?" she asked, and Cash turned the phone towards her. Kate stared at the screen just as confused as the rest of the world. She reached under the bed and picked up her own phone.

"Wait." Kate's voice sharpened. "Cash, Reddit is full of this. Look."

She handed him the phone and showed him the science fiction-sounding headlines.

Kate sat up. “That’s creepy.”

“It is,” Cash said. “I don’t understand it either.”

Kate got up and started changing her clothes. “Could this be some kind of software error? A daylight savings bug?”

“Maybe,” Cash said, even though he did not believe it. The consistency was too precise. If this was an attack across all platforms and devices, it had to be something other than a hacker army. It had to be a strike by combined artificial intelligences. A superpower’s orchestrated warning shot of what they have the power to do.

AI saw time differently. It did not measure moments in sequence, but jumped across them like a reader skipping lines. A famous example was Google’s Sycamore, which had solved a calculation in 200 seconds that would have taken a classical supercomputer 10,000 years.

AI might have changed the whole world back to yesterday, or rather, only the parts that were being observed. Maybe the sites no one had visited yet were already living on April 13. That would have saved a significant amount of computing power, with humans themselves acting as the trigger for resetting to yesterday. It would have fit the machine logic perfectly. If no one saw a tree fall, did it ever fall?

The fridge was almost empty, even though Cash had gone grocery shopping just yesterday. That instantly undermined the AI theory, because this could not be limited to the digital world. This was something bigger.

At least the eggs he had used for breakfast a day earlier had miraculously returned. You could not make an omelette without breaking eggs. People liked that saying, even though it was blatantly obvious and often used as an excuse for the damage caused. No one ever asked whether it was possible to make an egg from an omelette.

If everything had returned to its raw state but his mind had not, was he the egg or was he the omelette? The thought was strange enough for him to decide, instead, to take quick oats from the cupboard.

Yesterday’s dinner, from which Cash had packed himself lunch, was of course also gone. That was annoying, but he also justified that he could pick up food from a restaurant for lunch today.

He cooked porridge for the girls and sprinkled frozen berries on top. Seven-year-old Florence immediately saw her porridge as a canvas to make art with her spoon. Four-year-old Arabella hummed a song she had made up, and swung her legs under the table.

Cash's porridge always had a pinch of salt, while Kate's was sweet. Luckily, the girls liked both. Watching the girls, he wondered how time could be broken while his daughters were so whole and perfect.

Kate walked past them, kissed both girls on the forehead, and turned on the television. Cash would have suggested keeping the girls in the dark for now, to protect them from what had happened, but he didn't have time, and he did not remember to talk to Kate about it yet. It was interesting how, in a relationship, one person always took the overly cautious role and the other the "it's fine" approach. There was something Taoist about it, a yin and yang quality that brought opposites into harmony. Maybe humans were evolutionarily meant to move in pairs, so that anxiety always had another perspective beside it.

Some channels were still running yesterday's regular programming, but a few had already interrupted their broadcasts due to technical issues. Meanwhile, the CBC showed a repeating message from a government representative urging people to stay calm and contact authorities if necessary.

"Something is going on," Kate said.

Cash nodded. The media seemed too calm, considering how unique and world-changing the phenomenon they had just witnessed was.

Kate picked up her phone again. "There has to be some explanation." She typed into the search bar: Why does April 12 repeat?

Search engines offered links to speculative discussions, pseudoscientific theories, and more scientific or at least scientific-sounding guesses.

Florence looked up. "Mommy? Why are we not going to school?"

Kate hesitated. "Today is a special day, sweetheart."

Florence smiled. "Like a holiday?"

Kate forced a smile. "Sort of."

The lie was gentle, but believable.

Cash got dressed quickly. He shaved, brushed his teeth, and shook his hair to get the right mix of care and carelessness. Somehow, the routine felt more meaningful now. Every movement, every gesture felt like an echo of something already done. As if he were tracing his own footsteps without knowing why.

Kate appeared in the doorway. “Are you still going to work?” she asked, though it did not sound like a question so much as a statement.

Cash nodded slowly. “If something is happening, I want to be where information comes first.”

Kate did not argue. She just looked at him with focus that Cash fully was not able to read.

Cash left the house and started cycling towards downtown on his creaky single speed. He had oiled the chain just yesterday, but realized that, of course, he should have done it again this morning. Everything seemed to have reset overnight, and he was only beginning to grasp how incomprehensible that all felt.

The more Cash listened to the news, the clearer it became that this was not just a technical glitch. Everything around him had shifted back by one day.

The morning felt absurd but still explainable. He compared it to flying too fast west and being handed an extra day by jet lag. Or as if winter time had been applied twenty-four times faster. But those were only tricks of the clock. This was something else. Something beyond the construct of what people believed time to be. Minutes, hours, and years all sounded very simple, but they were ultimately just agreements. Not many people knew that there had never been a year zero. Our calendar started at year one, and a year before that had simply been a year before Christ. No one had ever lived through a year zero. The first century ran from AD 1 to AD 100, not from zero to ninety-nine. By that logic, even the new millennium had begun on January 1, 2001, not 2000. Time had always been a little less precise than people liked to believe. So maybe people would not make such a big deal about a discrepancy of just one day when they were perfectly comfortable with being an entire year off.

The Prime Minister’s voice came through his headphones, clipped from the morning press conference. There was no declaration of martial law, or even a state of emergency. It was essentially a calm assurance that researchers were “monitoring a global time anomaly” and that the government would hold another briefing in the afternoon.

It was a skill to say only what needed to be said. Cash had never learned it. He often got into trouble for letting the truth slip too freely. He was overly honest, almost painfully lawful. Traits that were not always ideal in a world where truth did not matter until it was spoken aloud. Most people did not want to cause trouble, but they were bound by protocol. When you said something careless like “oh, I did not bring my ID” or volunteered a detail to the authority, you forced their hand. They had to enforce the rules, whether they wanted to or not.

Kate was different. She knew how to cover, adjust, and draw boundaries. Almost every time, Kate’s suggested approach of “let us not tell absolutely everything” had turned out to be better. That had been the case with banks, customs, and real estate deals. Basically, anywhere something had to be reported honestly.

Cash wondered where that came from. Psychologists might have said childhood. Pinocchio had left a mark back then. Cash did not believe that a simple lie would grow a nose or lead to donkey tails and hooves, but on some level, honesty was so deeply part of who he was that if he ever started to lie, it would not change his nose. It would change his entire identity.

Cash heard the Prime Minister on his headphones, but did not listen. He remembered how moments like these press conferences had changed over the course of history. One good example was the fall of the Berlin Wall. East German spokesman Günter Schabowski had been tired and hungover when he held a press conference on November 9, 1989. He had received a stack of papers just before the event and had not had time to read them properly. When asked when the new travel regulations would come into effect, he had answered, “As far as I know, immediately.” Moments later, people began marching to the border crossings, and even though the guards received no instructions, they opened the gates without firing a single shot.

If Cash had been the Prime Minister, he might have accidentally fuelled more panic by answering journalists’ questions with overly dystopian guesses. That was why it was good that, in his job, he asked the questions instead.

He passed a small group of people downtown. One carried a cardboard sign reading "We want answers”. Another had written on a pizza box: #NotMyApril12.

Cash cycled past them with a small snort.

He wondered what kind of person, when faced with something this improbable, first suspected the government. That almost gave the government godlike authority, as if it could press a button and start a time loop. Maybe some minister would have been flattered by the idea.

Still, there was something deeply traditional and noble about protesting. Cash did not look down on it. It was quite the opposite. He felt a mild sense of shame that he himself often only dared to join once a march had grown to be mainstream.

Marching for sexual minorities was no longer radical, while opposing it was. Anti gay movements preached naturality, even though same sex partnerships were common across the animal kingdom. Giraffes and swans did not need Pride parades because no individual among them would challenge something so plainly natural.

Cash wondered whether he would have joined the first Pride, the Stonewall riots, which were not known for rainbows but for stones and Molotov cocktails. He liked to think he would have had the courage to stand up for justice, but the evidence, or rather the lack of it, suggested otherwise.

Cash hoped this day would not lead to riots, tear gas, and arrests. Did he belong to that middle class that supported protests from a safe distance, but disliked it when kicking side mirrors and smashing shop windows was justified by claiming the cause mattered more than the damage?

Confirmation bias lived in everyone. Even in those who accused others of confirmation bias. Kate had said outright that she did not want to read anything that contradicted with what she believed in. That was more honest than most people's defence mechanisms.

Cash knew people who read Harari and laughed smugly as he dismantled myths about nations and other people's gods, but when the book reached their own beliefs, Harari suddenly did not know what he was talking about.

Cash thought of Bertrand Russell, standing in the street at the age of eighty-nine with a sign in his hands, getting arrested at a protest against nuclear weapons. It would have been admirable to be more like Russell, carrying a sign when it was not fashionable or safe. But then again, as a father, it was possibly a better option for one's children to be at home than in a jain cell.

At a red light, he noticed another cyclist stopping beside him, whose helmet had a sticker that read: Truth matters. Cash could not help wondering what it meant to the cyclist. It could, for

example, refer to a flat Earth conspiracy. Either way, the message fit perfectly with the city's atmosphere, where the fireplace was filled not with logs but with a burning need to find answers. Cash remembered Albert Camus' idea that speaking the truth inevitably led to a kind of exile. It was a separation from safety and familiarity that often meant losing friends or work. The person beside him at the traffic lights surely must have had their own history behind that sticker.

When the lights turned green, Cash pedalled forward and left the sticker bearer behind. He worked in media that was generally considered free, but was also labelled a liberal think tank. Cash recalled Camus' thought about how seeking the company of the like-minded distorted one's sense of reality. The idea was not new or radical, but maybe Cash had found it especially meaningful simply because the words had come from Camus. He imagined Michel Foucault pointing this out to him, and in the same breath mocking Cash's long-time favourite quote about free speech. It was the line attributed to Voltaire that every journalist surely knew:

"I disagree with you, but I am willing to die for your right to say it."

It read like a verse from the journalists' holy book. Cash couldn't help wondering what else made the canon, and what got tossed aside as apocrypha. Did their religion have prophets like Johannes Gutenberg and Joseph Pulitzer?

He locked his bike to the usual post by the office door. Repeated parking had claimed it as his own, like a dog staking territory. The thought struck him as absurd. Sometimes it paid to criticize your own mind before anyone else did. That line was probably from Camus' *The Fall*. Fuck off, Foucault.

Chapter 1.2

“Crazy times. But now this is the moment when the people need us. They are waiting for answers, and we have to give them some. For God’s sake, people are already splitting into camps,” Chris Leclerc said to the domestic news team.

Cash leaned back in his rolling chair, already sensing where the world was heading.

“What kind of camps?” Cash asked, breaking a silence that had stretched too long.

Chris did not answer right away. He let his gaze circle the room, clearly enjoying being at the centre of attention in the middle of a crisis. “The government has released a statement saying the situation is under investigation, but that there are no answers yet. That has not stopped people from already deciding what this is all about. Each of you will focus on one group that Janet assigns and present it to me briefly, as if the story had already been finished yesterday.”

A couple of muted laughs rippled through the room, then died instantly when they realized Chris was not joking, despite the very fitting ‘yesterday’ humour. That was probably going to become a whole new genre of comedy, Cash thought.

Janet started listing responsibilities from a printed sheet.

“First, the scientific community. Those who believe there must be a rational explanation for all this. Physicists, engineers. Cash, this one is yours.”

Cash exhaled through his nose. He knew he had drawn the short straw and could not help but wonder why Janet had given him this topic. The next groups would make far more compelling front page stories tomorrow, while few people would be interested in scientific jargon explaining that nothing could yet be said for sure, but, in theory, this could be x and y, influenced by z. The wilder the theory, the more attention it would get. That was just how the psychology of journalism worked.

Janet continued. “Then there are the doomsday prophets quoting holy texts. On social media, strong opinions are circulating that this is the first sign before the Four Horsemen of Revelation. Some have even said the only explanation that makes sense is that we are already in the afterlife.”

Another few laughs went around the room.

“Lucy, that one is yours,” Chris said, as if waiting for Lucy’s reaction. Lucy started to raise her hand to ask for clarification, but Chris pressed it down with the force of his mind like a Jedi knight and waved Janet to continue. He mouthed silently to Lucy that they would talk later. Cash guessed Lucy wanted to know whether she should focus on the horsemen or on explanations involving the afterlife. It sounded hard to cram both into one cohesive article. Lucy’s writing was always sharp and anxiously perfect. And what made her journalistic skills even more annoyingly good was her speed. She did not fit the stereotype of the perfect student who agonized over every word. Who knows, maybe she had been like that before, but then learned writing patterns the way chess players memorized ready-made openings and sequences of moves, which made everything faster. Cash did not know what irritated others so much about it, but at least jealousy would have been an oversimplification.

“The next theory claims that we are reliving the same day over and over until we do everything right, whatever that means. Groundhog Day. Sorry, Bob.”

“No need to apologize. Every word is true.”

Janet frowned and looked at him for a second too long. She looked far too polished for a newsroom. Her clothing choices would have fit better in a law firm than here, where even a collared shirt was on the edge of overdressing. It was possible she genuinely liked her new style, and who was Cash to criticize? At the same time, everyone knew Chris was being lined up for a promotion to senior management, and Janet was the most obvious candidate to take over his current role as head of domestic news. She had already started easing into the role before it was even vacant. Some people in the office joked about her “Margaret Thatcher transformation,” though Cash’s social science-trained brain could not find much connection in the comparison. At its core, the whole idea sounded rather chauvinistic. If a man had started wearing tailored trousers and a blazer in the same situation, would anyone have cared at all? Janet was not their manager yet, even though she was already behaving as if she stood on an invisible platform of authority.

“Simulation theorists,” Janet said, pulling Cash out of his internal monologue. “They believe reality is a simulation whose underlying server crashed, or a new update failed, and we were never meant to notice that the day did not change. Peter.”

Peter's eyes lit up. He immediately pulled out his phone and immersed himself in the topic. Cash's gaze drifted to Peter's tattoos. Two of them looked almost fresh, still not fully healed, their black ink far darker than the older, faded pieces. They had to be very new.

"And finally, the neo saviours. A new anarchist group is spreading the message that you can do anything now without consequences, because they believe everything will reset tomorrow anyway. We have no reason to believe this is true, but the group has decided it is."

Janet said and turned to look at Dev, who nodded. Dev was a well-liked man of Indian background, perhaps a few years younger than Cash.

"That could get ugly," Cash said to Dev as they walked toward their desks, where Peter was already introducing himself to someone on the phone. With Peter, you could never tell whether he was speaking to the Prime Minister or a friend, because his calm, deep voice never gave anything away. It was pleasant to listen to. Peter could have made an audiobook about an ordinary grocery store trip, listing the items in his basket and their prices, and it would have found an audience.

Dev nodded. "I know."

Cash's thoughts drifted to Langley Atwood, whom he had met at an event at Florence's school. Langley had given a talk on quantum mechanics to children who were, politely speaking, completely baffled by the nonsense-sounding lecture. But now that nonsense could be exactly the music Cash was looking for.

Cash found Langley's LinkedIn profile. Strangely, it appeared in the search results before the University of British Columbia's own page. Search engine optimization was one of those topics Cash had meant to learn from YouTube many times, but never had the interest to spend the hours on. Yes, it might have been very important to know, but it felt far too boring.

LinkedIn listed Langley's work and education history, along with positions of responsibility. One of them was the vice chair of Vancouver Mensa. Board positions at Mensa were probably highly competitive, since mentioning board responsibility seemed to be the only socially acceptable way to tell the world about your membership. Otherwise, it felt as boastful as adding your height to your CV.

Cash remembered how the Norwegian Olympic bronze medalist had broken down in tears during a television interview, admitting that he had cheated on his girlfriend three months earlier. What stayed with Cash was not the scandal that followed but the athlete's mention that even though he was a member of Mensa, he still managed to act foolishly sometimes. He should have sugarcoated it with a board position, Cash had thought, as he heard people describing the Mensa drop as arrogant.

Cash opened the university's website. Professor of physics, specializing in quantum mechanics and the nature of time. Langley seemed like the perfect interviewee. He probably would not answer the email right away. There was no phone number in public listings, and a LinkedIn message would likely be just as slow as email. Cash wondered who was having the more meaningful day: the physicist proving the economic value of his theories, or the journalist that knew any story related to the topic would certainly be read?

Then he remembered the parents' WhatsApp group for Florence's class. It had been embarrassingly quiet since it was created. Mostly, it was a forum for lost mittens and homework questions when someone's child had been absent.

Cash scrolled through the contact list, and there it was: Langley's number. He hesitated for a moment, since using Florence as a connection felt wrong, like using someone else's phone to make a call. Exceptional times called for exceptional actions, he thought, already pressing the call icon.

"Hi Langley, this is Cash Haggerty from CBC. Our daughters are in the same class. I'm Florence's dad. But I'm not calling about that. I'm working on a story, and I would like to include someone who can give a scientific perspective on what this is all about."

Langley sighed. "Hi, Cash. Nice surprise, but a straight answer to a straight question. We do not have answers yet."

"Okay, but I'm not only looking for a single explanation that would solve everything, but more like a rational perspective that might balance out some of the crazy stuff that's been getting far too much space and attention online."

Langley chuckled. "Does a theoretical physicist sound less crazy? Well, go ahead. I have five minutes."

“That’s plenty. Let’s start with the basics. One theory online claims something went wrong at CERN. Another suggests a wormhole formed in Earth’s orbit, with yesterday on the other side. If the same thing happens tomorrow, we are stuck in an endless time loop, as Earth falls through the same hole every night back into yesterday.”

Langley answered calmly.

“The CERN theory is nonsense. The collision energies in particle accelerators are negligible compared to what happens naturally all the time. A wormhole, on the other hand, is a hypothetical solution to Einstein’s field equations. Stabilizing one would require exotic matter with negative energy density. Nothing like that has ever been observed. If something like that existed this close, it is extremely unlikely it would not have already been noticed. At least not in a quantity capable of bending an entire planet backward in time.”

“So there is no theory?”

“People believe what they want to believe. But in science, it is not enough that something sounds possible. It has to be measurable and repeatable. No one has yet presented, at least publicly, a model that explains the loop in this way. Take cosmic background radiation, for example. Its existence was predicted by theory and later measured precisely. That is why science could accept it. Science cannot support a theory that cannot be tested or falsified. That is the difference between science and science fiction.”

“Okay, thank you. Maybe I should not have started with other people’s speculation. If I can ask one more thing, what do you think is the most likely explanation?”

“I have nothing I can support with data,” Langley said. “Time loops belong to fiction. In reality, the direction of entropy cannot be reversed, so time must always move forward. But now? This seems to violate every law of physics.”

Cash filed it away in his mind as a perfect quote. But it was not comforting.

“Does not sound like news yet,” he said half-jokingly.

“It is the best answer I can give right now.”

Langley clearly thought for a moment before continuing.

“We have to accept that we do not yet have the tools to understand this. That does not mean we will never have them. What matters now is not jumping to conclusions too quickly.”

After the call, Cash stood still for a moment. He appreciated Langley's perspective. There was something deeply upright about it. The way Langley described science reminded Cash why he had wanted to become a journalist in the first place. They shared a curious but honest pursuit of truth.

Cash could not stand it when things with clear research evidence behind them were undermined by anecdotes or comments like "this worked for me." That kind of discussion created a false opposition between experience and research.

He remembered how shared interests used to create instant synergy and friendships when he was younger. Realizing that both people had read the biographies of Slash and Axl Rose had created a feeling of being understood.

But after turning thirty, that was no longer enough. Shared interests alone did not carry relationships if values did not align. It started to matter more what someone thought about vaccines, politics, and parenting. Maintaining friendships required time and energy, and those were no longer given lightly. The filter was stricter than during student years.

Chris was not convinced by Cash's idea. A physics professor admitting that the world was now operating outside the laws of physics.

"Instead of answers, you found someone who does not have any. Brilliant." He barely lifted his eyes from his computer screen. "Help Dev with the neo saviours story. That's where the real journalism is."

When Cash got home, he realized that the most reasonable explanation was that he had lost his mind, or that he was trapped in a lucid dream that, for some reason, kept going even though he already knew it was a dream. His greatest fear in life had always been losing the people he loved, but a close second was going crazy. What made that fear terrifying was the possibility that it might happen without him ever noticing. The human mind was good at solving puzzles even when the pieces were incoherent or entirely made up. We had evolved to be storytellers.

If this was some psychotic episode, and all of this had never happened anywhere except inside his own mind, how could he even test that? If you asked a robot how it knew it was real, its answers would be analysed for self-awareness. But if a human mind was living inside its own psychosis, would those same answers suddenly become proof of madness rather than awareness?

There was also narsiscitic connotation in believing that witnessed events did not exist outside someone's own mind. It reminded Cash of solipsism which he had always seen as an extremely naive philosophy.

No, he would not bet his money on it all being his imagination. Everything felt too real. There had to be an explanation somewhere, even if it lay beyond science, as Langley had suggested.

If Earth had flown through a wormhole, maybe it had already happened before. Without clocks or calendars, repetition might have gone unnoticed, and documented history would be little more than a drop in the ocean. He wondered how dinosaurs would have reacted to a time loop. The thought sounded bizarre, but perhaps it was chronocentric to assume our era would be the one most affected.

Cash remembered Leibniz's claim that we lived in the best of all possible worlds. Despite all the bad that happened in the world, Cash had believed it. It had been comforting, knowing that it could have way worse, in infinite ways.

The problem was that if parallel universes really were true, then there had to be timelines where time had never stopped. In other worlds people woke up on April thirteenth, children went to school, and yesterday allowed to remain as the thing of the past.

Kate was lying on the couch, the blue light of her phone illuminating her face. Cash did not need to ask whether she was scrolling through theories and Reddit threads. Cash had learned what her expression symbolized. Nonverbally, it said a mother lost in the digital jungle.

In the girls' room, Florence and Arabella were playing. Cash heard their laughter. For them, nothing had changed yet. Today had simply been a fun day without school.

Chapter 1.3

Cash woke to the sound of rain tapping like a marching snare. He envisioned the drum played by a drummer in an orchestra line. A chill ran down his spine when he realized the drummer was playing the same rhythm as yesterday. The world was stuck in a time loop. The first time, the phenomenon had felt fascinating, almost amusing, like a tragicomic populist presidential campaign that still seemed like a farce before the final votes were counted. Now the humour was gone. The loop was no longer a curiousity that future history books would mention. Instead, this might have been the last day of history.

The idea that everything with a beginning must have had an end was deeply human. What if the time loop was like a medieval oubliette, a pit-like dungeon with an opening in the ceiling and no door at all. Prisoners were dropped in from above and then simply forgotten. It was too dark a thought. Somewhere, there had to be a door that created hope.

Cash did not belong to this time, which felt both less meaningful and perhaps the most meaningful moment of all existence. He belonged to a time that moved forward.

Kate was still asleep, unaware of the third identical awakening. The phone confirmed the date, and Cash carefully placed it back on the floor. If everything stayed identical up to the moment of waking, Kate would wake in about four minutes.

Cash scrolled through the news feed with the phone on the floor, his left hand hanging over the edge of the bed, thumb steering through the offerings of different outlets. His own employer had already published two articles:

G7 leaders meet today to discuss the time loop phenomenon

BREAKING: The world wakes up to the same day again, experts baffled

Cash received a message from Chris:

“Too bad this didn’t happen on a weekend lol. See you at work.”

Cash stared at the screen for a moment.

Even in a time loop, Chris still sounded very much like Chris. Although Cash suddenly wondered if Chris was even Chris, or actually Christopher. He had never asked.

That reminded him of something that had surprised him more than ten years earlier. Kate had always been Kate to him. Then, months into dating, they booked a trip to Mexico. Cash filled in the reservation details and typed her name exactly the way he knew it, as Kate.

Kate leaned over his shoulder and laughed.

“You do know that my government name is Katherine. I don’t think any Kate is actually Kate.”

Cash had stared at the screen as if the airline website had revealed some kind of secret identity. After that, he started noticing it everywhere. All Bills were Williams, Dicks were Richards, Bobs did not exist, as they were all Roberts, and somehow Peggys were Margarets.

It was strange how the names people used every day could sit so far from the ones written on passports and birth certificates. Almost as far apart as Cleopatra and the pyramids of Giza. Cleopatra was actually closer to our time. Well, that was a terrible example.

Cash locked the phone and placed it back on the floor.

A self-identifying name was important. It was a big part of someone’s identity. It was not someone else’s place to use pronouns or names that better fit their own mouth, even if they were sometimes difficult to remember. Chris was Chris because he told others so. If Cash had ever said Katherine to Kate, she would probably have been terrified that something was wrong and Cash was trying to darken the message with extra seriousness. She might have asked:

“Why are you calling me by my government name?”

But anyway, how did Chris react so casually to what was happening? Maybe it was his way of saying overtime was approved, and they would figure out how to compensate for it.

Yesterday’s work clothes were once again neatly hanging in the wardrobe, but Cash chose a black buttoned shirt instead of the black and white checked one. Change was important, literally and figuratively.

Cash never wore the same clothes two days in a row, even though his work wardrobe held no more than five dress shirts and three pairs of trousers. That made fifteen possible outfits. In roughly two weeks, he had worn every combination. It never felt repetitive, but he understood those who, like Kate, saw repetition as a friend of boredom.

Kate woke up at exactly the expected minute.

“Still the twelfth,” Cash said, forcing as much hope into his voice as he could.

“That cannot be true.” Kate jumped up as quickly as someone playing the floor is lava.

“What if this goes on forever?” Kate whispered, as if saying something forbidden while the universe was listening. In Kate’s worldview, the universe was a conscious being, which often sounded to Cash rather sensitive, bitter, and quick to anger.

“There will be an explanation soon,” Cash tried to comfort her.

“Do not tell me you are going to work.”

Kate sighed, knowing exactly what the silence meant. They had two children at home, but not going to work wasn’t in Cash’s nature. It wasn’t even an option.

Vancouver’s nature felt the same today as yesterday. If nature had agency, it chose not to break the repetition. Cash listened to its orchestra. It was a melody called Yesterday, which was not from the Beatles, but flawlessly repeated by Earth, Wind, and Fire. He felt it like a synesthete tasting sounds or hearing colours.

Cash could not blame nature. He had done the same. He had the freedom to break routine and stay home, but he had chosen repetition. His morning barely differed from the day before, but he was not the only one. On the park bench, the same man sat reading a book at the same time as always. Routines offered comfort.

Cash parked his bike and locked it to the post beside the office entrance. A block away, police cars were beginning to gather in front of the library. At that moment, his phone vibrated in his pocket. Dev was calling and said he was already inside. “Get over here, it’s a full-on party,” he said.

When Cash arrived, a young neo-saviour woman hugged him, welcoming him to reality. The building occupation resembled humanities students occupying university facilities, with occupiers who looked more like a scout troop.

The occupiers were not troublemakers but rather academics who had not yet grown out of the absurdity of constant celebration. Cash remembered university friends who bragged about never having worked a paid job for a single day. He saw this group as their equivalent. Smart and creative students who could not imagine a reality where the everyday celebration turned into a life of waking at six thirty, repeating routine days from eight to four or nine to five, and doing that same five-day work week again the following week.

Dev was already interviewing a woman dressed in white overalls that anyone could paint on. The suit was covered in phone numbers, compliments, and abstract artworks. If the neo saviours had resembled the followers of the original saviour in any way, maybe something related to their beliefs or message would have been included too. Instead, the movement seemed to be a socially acceptable justification for partying in new places during a time crisis.

Dev had a remarkable talent for turning dull details into engaging stories. He told Cash he planned to work as a journalist until he could invest in a large greenhouse to grow tomatoes. The way Dev described it made Cash wonder how Kate would react if he suddenly started a vegetable garden of his own. Potatoes, carrots, zucchini. She wouldn't have believed it at all, and might even have worried, thinking first she lost forward-moving time and now her husband. At least his parents would have been proud, since Cash had been born into a passionate gardening family. Too bad that no practical knowledge had remained from those childhood years spent staring at the soil. Instead, Cash had grown to be an unintentional grim reaper to any plant or flower that they tried to keep alive at home.

Cash tried to joke with Dev about how lucky he was to have gotten a haircut just before the loop. "If the world cannot handle me like this, that is its problem," Dev answered with no emotion. Dev's own hair grew in every direction, seemingly defying the laws of physics.

Cash wasn't sure if Dev had misunderstood his intentions about the comment. It had not referred to Dev at all, but had been more of a funny observation about himself. Still, he did not think it important enough to clarify what he had or had not meant.

Inside the library, the atmosphere was calm but defiant. The protest seemed aimed at the entire world, not any single institution. Cash wondered where the rebellion that had lived in them back in university had gone. Back then, it was enough for a professor to use the wrong terminology in a lecture. Had they lost the desire to change things after realizing the world was more complex than it seemed in their early 20s?

The world looked different when viewed as a fully participating, taxpaying member of society. Things now appeared as uncertain shades of grey, whereas during university, he was so sure of himself that he dared to publicly challenge professors supposedly experts in their fields. It had

been a significant shift in identity and role when Cash jumped from academic freedom into a hamster wheel of nine-to-five.

Dev held a notebook that looked like an Indian handicraft, one where the maker had likely been paid fairly.

“How do you write a story that disappears again tomorrow?” Dev asked.

“You can ask Snapchat’s millions of users,” Cash replied. “Content permanence is probably not a value in itself. How many people even read yesterday’s news anymore?”

Dev nodded in approval and disappeared into the dancing crowd to continue his work. There was a Stoic ataraxia in the neo-saviours’ behaviour. An active acceptance of the unchangeable. But Cash could not understand why that acceptance manifested as criminal partying. If they really had accepted it, they could have also celebrated in permitted spaces and avoided media and police attention. Was the lack of their message itself the message?

Humans were too meaning-seeking to accept that something could be done without deeper intent. If someone threw tomato sauce onto Picasso’s Guernica and claimed there was no reason, the human mind would still supply one. Mental health struggles. Heartbreak. A diagnosis. Political ideology. Meaning would be imposed, whether it existed or not.

And what if, in the end, the day really was repeating without reason.

Josef K in Kafka’s *The Trial* was condemned without guilt and without ever learning why he had been arrested. That kind of randomness was almost impossible to comprehend. It was far easier to blame God or the Universe, to imagine punishment for ancient sins, like the old story of a flood that spared only one family and a handful of animals.

Our ancestors had already left a trail of disappearance behind them. Most large animals were driven to extinction. Neanderthals in Europe and the Middle East, Denisovans in Asia, vanished soon after Homo sapiens migrated out of East Africa and into their territories.

Or take the climate crisis. Many still questioned human responsibility, calling it part of a natural cycle. Dose was a difficult concept for some, whether discussing vaccines or trace substances in food. The same blindness applied to speed. A few degrees of average temperature increase felt insignificant, even though in two hundred years the planet had warmed as much as it normally did in twelve thousand, with a sharp acceleration in the twentieth century. That was not how

natural climate change behaved. If anything, the graphs suggested we should have been entering a cooler period by now, not a warmer one.

Our ancestors had made the world what it was, but we could decide what it became. That idea had once felt inspiring. It had aged poorly if time itself had stalled, but it had still mattered.

Like the old Greek proverb about planting trees whose shade you will never sit in. Optimism mattered. Most innovators had been optimists, even if they never used the word. Science itself required optimism. Why else would anyone keep trying to prove something, again and again.

People often confused optimism with blind optimism. The blind version meant sitting still and trusting things would work out on their own. Real optimism meant believing there were actions that could make a difference. It meant avoiding the complacency trap.

Cash was no longer sure which kind he was. Maybe he was still a blind optimist, convinced that the repeating day was a one-time anomaly and that time would move forward again tomorrow, or at least soon. Maybe Kate was right when she pointed at him and accused him of optimism without hope that required work.

What bothered him most was not the doomsayers, and not the deniers either. Both camps froze the future in place. One insisted everything was already lost. The other insisted nothing was wrong.

Maybe the movement was trying to shake the quiet liberal middle class that always stayed on good terms with the opposing side, simply because they did not want to upset anyone.

Kate had mentioned this often. She did not understand how Cash could remain friendly with people who shared extreme conservative and populist content on social media, directly attacking certain groups of people. Kate saw such behaviour as a silent acceptance of injustice.

Cash, on the other hand, belonged to those who preferred to avoid value-based topics in social situations. He was guided by a Canadian norm of politeness that avoided spoiling the general mood. Americans, by contrast, sometimes leaned toward uncomfortable confrontation and often saw Canadian diplomacy as passive-aggressive.

Cash never supported radical views, but he did not actively avoid people who held them. At social events, he stayed civil, talking about sports, work, and everyday life. For many, that was

the problem. Silence on the big issues was not neutrality. It was seen as support for whatever radical beliefs the other person held.

A good example was Martin Luther King Jr.'s frustration with moderate white people of his time. King did not fear open racists who were honest about their hatred. He was frustrated by those who claimed to support equality but appealed to "bad timing" or criticized the form of protest as too provocative. From Birmingham Jail, he wrote: "The white moderate who says wait is a greater stumbling block to freedom than the Ku Klux Klan."

Was Cash the kind of person King had in mind? He wasn't sure. He wanted to believe that someone who dehumanized others might step back from extreme thinking when they found common ground, like a shared hobby or a favourite team.

But then he thought of Bertrand Russell, who had been invited to debate the fascist leader Sir Oswald Mosley. Russell refused because he did not want to present a man like Mosley as an equal conversational partner. In his view, there were ideas that should not be elevated into public debate because doing so gave them too much legitimacy.

Cash wondered whether Russell would have favoured Kate's approach of keeping people with extreme views out of her life when such views meant denying basic human rights. Based on the Mosley example, it seemed likely. Kate's thinking resembled the French expression cordon sanitaire, which referred to hygiene rules that kept contaminated ideas out of one's immediate environment.

When Cash defended his preference for talking with everyone, because those people never even brought up the provocative ideas they posted about on social media, Kate shot back that conversations never moved into sensitive topics because those people assumed Cash already belonged to the same club, or even cared about the issue, since he never mentioned it.

The Neo-Saviours Took Over the Central Library

Vancouver's New Movement Declares Freedom Without Consequences

Dev Patel and Cash Haggerty | CBC | April 12

At ten o'clock in the morning, Vancouver's central library looked more like a concert hall. Loud punk music blasted from speakers as dozens of people danced between the bookshelves.

The squatters were part of a group calling themselves the Neo Saviours, one branch of a broader movement that has spread globally through social media. Members say everyone has the right to express themselves without the limits of the legal system.

The movement has been described as a form of youth rebellion or anarchy at a time when others seek stability and direction. The Neo Saviours have occupied public spaces, hosted parties in unpermitted places, and challenged norms they state no longer apply, at least until April thirteenth.

"We are living fully in this moment," said Elliot Kim, a law student at the scene. "Every day is a blank canvas, so why not turn it into a masterpiece?"

Maya Thompson, a sociology student, said the movement offers a way to reclaim a sense of agency in a world where the future feels uncertain.

"We're not hurting anyone," she said. "If the universe decided to abandon us and leave us here like trash, I show it my middle finger and say, we don't need you."

Police say they prepare for potential disruptions linked to the movement.

"They know there is no preventive legislation," said Constable Ray Jameson. "We can make arrests, but the next morning it's as if nothing happened."

Chapter 1.4

Schools continued to operate. Not because a solution to the time loop had been found, but because life had to continue despite it. Throughout history, humans had shown an extraordinary ability to adapt to almost anything. Gradually, things began to feel normal again, as if people had stepped into a parallel universe that no longer followed the same physical laws as the original one.

Parents took their children to school and picked them up at the end of the day. Lessons followed the timetable, and teachers followed their term plans, ensuring the learning outcomes of the curriculum were still met. The experience of remote teaching during the pandemic had prepared educators to function in almost any circumstance.

Cash could only tip his hat to elementary school teachers. Managing their own lives while carrying responsibility for twenty-five children in the middle of an entirely new phenomenon could not have been easy.

More and more businesses had reopened their doors, turned on their lights, and returned from their so-called leave. People understood that whenever time began to move forward again, wages would likely be paid for no more than a single workday. Money, however, was not the main reason people returned to work. Keeping everyday routines alive gave meaning to chaos. For most people in Vancouver, reality looked much the same as it had before the time loop. That sounded paradoxical, almost like a self-fulfilling prophecy where people chose their loop within the loop. They went to work and greeted their colleagues.

“Morning. How are you?”

“Good. You?”

“Good. Nice that the rain has already stopped.”

“Oh, it’s amazing.”

In a podcast Cash listened to, an expert claimed that people’s continued strong work ethic reflected a natural human tendency toward capitalism. Cash found the idea absurd. It ignored other eras and cultures entirely. As hunter-gatherers, humans may have followed regular rhythms of labour and rest, but they did not build corporations on the savannah or study market

economies by the fire. What persisted was not capitalism, but habit. People clung to what was familiar, not to what served an economic system.

Although daily life had largely resumed, the moment was ideal for conspiracy theories. One common theory claimed that governments of major countries had created the time loop to monitor their citizens more closely. Slightly more scientific explanations suggested that a superpower or terrorists had triggered a weapon similar to an electromagnetic pulse, destroying the molecules that allowed time to remain linear. Cash knew this was nonsense, even though he remembered reading popular science books that described time as something that reacted differently to speed and mass.

Explanations were endless, but to Cash, they all felt recycled. People were borrowing fragments from old authorities, holy texts, half-remembered sciences, and outright pseudoscience, trying to force the new reality into familiar frames. It must have been exhausting to stretch ancient language to fit something so fundamentally strange.

If this really were a divine event, surely someone would have written about it in the past. A time loop was incomprehensible on a scale that dwarfed the biblical plagues, frogs, and hail. An ancient prophet would not have missed something this large.

It was therefore no surprise that some religious communities had begun to describe the loop as purgatory. Nearly half of North Americans still believed in hell, even though it was a relatively late addition to Christian theology. In Northern Europe, fewer than one in ten people believed in it anymore. Fear had been preserved far more carefully on this side of the Atlantic. It had always been an effective tool for governing large populations. That crossed the line into spiritual violence, forcing individuals to carry guilt for who they loved or who they were when they did not fit church doctrine.

Cash thought about how horrified Plato would have been to see what was happening to people. In *The Republic*, reason was meant to rule, guiding both the soul and the city. Now, power had shifted to emotions and desires.

South of Canada's border, there was a long history of defeating political opponents by using emotion in politics. Ideology-based liberal campaigning did not move people in the same way. People longed for strong leaders, and populists were always quick to step forward.

At CBC, the nature of journalism had changed. Every story, whether it was diet, politics, or sports, somehow revolved around the time loop. Even articles that should have been just about cooking were now explaining how people found ingredients during the loop or why this dish mattered specifically right now, when the day was repeating.

At home, Kate grew increasingly worried about the girls. One sleepless night, Cash turned on the television, which was showing a rerun of today's talk show.

"We are living through the greatest crisis in human history," one panelist insisted.

Another shook their head. "You are thinking about this the wrong way. This is a gift. Hunger, ageing, suffering. They are all gone. We have been given a moment outside of time."

The first speaker interrupted. "That is pure neoliberal fantasy. Believe me, people are suffering. Just because the date does not change does not mean pain and distress disappear. That is why Canada should provide financial and emotional support to those who need it."

What would that mean in practice, Cash wondered, but the panelist offered no concrete solutions. The idea was noble, but still just an idea. The discussion gave people nothing new, only confirmation of views they already held.

Cash turned off the television. Talk shows never advanced past yesterday. What a perfect metaphor for the time loop. Maybe they did something right in the end.

Most people didn't want to think for themselves. They preferred to be handed readymade opinions, even when those opinions no longer matched the reality around them. Immanuel Kant called it self-imposed immaturity. Perhaps he could have stated that the whole time loop was just a cosmic timeout to grow up and start using your own amazing brain. No, he would not have. Kant was a very rational man.

Cash had, anyway, become less and less interested in the why and more and more interested in the how, which was a more active and future-facing approach: How can we end this?

The loop stole a lot of headspace, but ultimately, Cash was waiting for someone else to come in and fix it. Who knows, maybe Oscar Wilde would have insulted Cash by classifying him among those who existed, and that is all. Well, perhaps it was not even something one man could have done. Thinking otherwise would have been not only narcissistic and delusional but also megalomaniacal. Sure, maybe some teenager who earned a physics PhD at fifteen could entertain

the fantasy of singlehandedly cracking the essence of time, but that was not an accurate description of Cash.

But people were also too hard on themselves. History's moral trailblazers were almost always stained by tomorrow's standards. Martin Luther King Jr. thought homosexuality could be cured with therapy, and early feminist icons endorsed racial segregation. Yet every imperfect will to do good moved the world forward, because the world was the sum of its parts. Humans were good at overestimating their importance in the universe and underestimating their impact on Earth.

One morning, Florence asked,

"Dad, when is my birthday?"

Cash froze mid-sip of his coffee.

"It is in September. September tenth."

Florence frowned, the same thoughtful look Kate often said she had inherited from Cash's side of the family.

"Jack already had his birthday."

Cash blinked. "What?"

Florence did not look up. She carefully arranged her cereal.

"Jack from my class," she said. "He brought candy yesterday. The teacher asked if it was his birthday. Jack said yes. And we all sang."

She paused. When she finally looked at her father, her gaze grew even more thoughtful, as if she had read the worry on his face.

"But it is still April."

In the kitchen, Kate stopped wiping the table. She did not turn around, but Cash knew she was listening.

Jack's family had decided to move forward. Cash could imagine their morning conversation, the parents agreeing that if time was not moving, they could simply declare their son had turned eight. And who could argue with that? Viktor Frankl wrote that humans did not need comfort, but meaning. Perhaps Jack's parents probably understood that better than he did.

Florence stared at her father.

"How can Jack have a birthday if it is still April?"

Cash sighed and set his mug down.

“Well,” he began, searching for a possible angle, “not everyone follows the same calendar.”

Florence tilted her head. “What does that mean?”

Cash leaned closer.

“Most of us follow the Gregorian calendar. That is the one where today is April twelfth. But there are many other calendars in the world. In some countries, birthdays and holidays are celebrated on different days.”

Florence’s eyes lit up with curiosity. “Like what?”

“For example, the Julian calendar was used before the current one. In Russia, the New Year is celebrated according to it. That is why Orthodox Christmas is on January seventh, not December twenty-fifth.”

Florence nodded and clearly thought about the words she had heard.

“And then there is the Chinese calendar. It follows the moon, not the sun. Chinese New Year is never on January first, but sometime in January or February.”

Florence giggled. “That’s funny.”

“It is,” Cash smiled. “In Ethiopia, the calendar has thirteen months. They are living in a completely different year than we are.”

Florence opened her mouth wide open like in a cartoon. “So do they have different birthdays, too?”

“In a way. If you had been born in Ethiopia, your birthday might fall on a completely different day in our calendar.”

Florence’s face brightened as she understood.

“So Jack’s family could have a different calendar?”

“Or maybe Jack’s family just chose a day to celebrate Jack, because celebrating as a ritual can be more important than the date itself. Hard to say,” Cash said.

Florence thought for a long time.

“Do we have our own calendar?”

Cash hesitated. “No, we still follow the Gregorian calendar.”

Florence looked straight at him.

“But our calendar doesn’t have birthdays anymore. Or does it?”

Cash felt Kate listening closely from the other side of the kitchen. He did not know how to answer. Parenting often felt like improvisational theatre to him. You stepped on stage without a script, and the audience kept throwing out new topics. Now someone had shouted time loop. No one knew how the show would end, and much of the story depended on reactions. He and Kate had shared parenting rules, which they applied to unexpected situations, much like air traffic controllers guiding planes.

Jack’s family had chosen a day to celebrate a birthday. It was a brave decision. At the same time, Michael Sandel had argued that some things, like celebration, were not private choices, but their meaning only existed when they were shared with others. Jack’s birthday must have been exactly like that. A single family could declare today is our son’s celebration, but it was when the class sang together that gave it legitimacy.

“Yes, we do,” he finally said.

Florence continued arranging her cereal, but something had shifted in her. She did not seem sad, just confused.

Kate cleared her throat softly. “Florence, what if we made our own calendar?”

Florence’s face lit up. “Can I?”

“Of course,” Kate said. “You can decide what holidays go in it. Celebrities, historical women, animals, anything you want.”

“What about my birthday?”

Kate smiled and nodded.

Florence grinned and began listing which days she would add to her calendar, how many days each month would have, and how many months there would be in a year.

Cash liked the idea. “That is a really good plan.”

Kate met Cash’s gaze, and for a moment, she looked relieved. They had won more time.

Florence had accepted the explanation, but Cash knew it would not last forever.

Because no matter how many calendars existed in the world, or how well people pretended time was moving forward, it was still April twelfth.

Later, Kate turned to him, her eyes red.

“How long until they realise September is never coming?”

Cash did not answer right away. He wanted to say something comforting, but the words felt too inauthentic to release them.

“I don’t know,” he admitted. “But it will come.”

Kate sighed and looked away. She rubbed her temples as if consciously pushing the catastrophizing what-ifs out of her head.

When Tomorrow Never Comes (Unpublished Draft)

What Two Boys Who Went Fishing Can Teach a World Stuck in April 12

Cash Haggerty | CBC | April 12

At Sudbury Valley School in Massachusetts decades ago, two boys did not attend classes like their peers. They did not sit at desks or memorize lessons. Every day, they walked to a nearby pond with fishing rods in hand, spending hours casting lines and watching the water. Learning, as the school's founders believed, would come when it was needed. According to legend, they were the only students in the school's history who never learned to read during their youth.

The boys' fishing trips are more than a curious story from educational history. They are a lesson in human choice. When the future disappears, what matters most is deciding how to spend the day. For the boys, it was the pond. For most people today, it is work, reconnecting with old friends, or simply finding small ways to make the day meaningful. Each person must answer the same question: what is worth living for today?

Across Vancouver, schools face a different but equally unusual challenge. With the calendar stuck on April 12, children are asking questions adults cannot always answer: "When is my birthday now?"

"I told her we have to celebrate it and sing," said a teacher at Kingston Elementary, describing the day a child declared it was their birthday to the whole class.

Teachers and parents are discovering that children are remarkably flexible about time. Unlike adults, who cling to schedules and deadlines, kids adapt to the repeating day with curiousity and play. They create their own markers, invent holidays, and decide when to celebrate, often in ways adults cannot immediately comprehend.

Chapter 1.5

Cash was at the gym with his old high school friend Nick. They were the kind of friends who barely met anymore but who once saw each other almost every day. The same pickup games, the same weekend plans, almost everything for many years. That kind of history stayed even when the rest drifted apart.

Nick leaned against the rack between sets, breathing hard but talking like he always did.

“Think about it for a second. Newton’s third law. For every force there’s an equal and opposite force. If some event pushes the day into motion, the universe pushes back just as hard. That’s how the time loop happens. The day moves forward, but then something pulls it back to the beginning. It’s basic mechanics, bro.”

Cash did not even remember what Newton’s third law was, so he was not the person to debunk the claim, even though it sounded overly simplistic for something so complex.

Nick kept going.

“If the effect is equal in the opposite direction, why couldn’t it cancel out everything that happened during the day?”

“I understand what you mean, like Aikido,” Cash said.

Nick pointed at him with a grin.

“Exactly. You use the other person’s force. I knew you would get it, bro,” Nick said, clearly liking the analogy.

“Right. Someone charges at you with all their momentum, and instead of stopping it, you redirect it. You turn their push into the thing that throws them off balance,” Cash added, like a rhythm guitarist keeping the beat.

“So that’s what’s happening. When the day pushes forward and with the same force, something is pushing it back because of very basic laws of physics, someone needs to figure out how to redirect the energy, like in Aikido. Then the time will move forward.” Nick said and tapped the side of his head.

Cash smiled but said nothing. Nick was convincing, but many times Cash had fact-checked him later, and it had been far from the truth.

Cash noticed something he had felt before but never named. At the gym, his confidence always seemed to drop. He didn't trust his own opinions as firmly. Nick had once said music concerts were a waste of time and money, and Cash had stayed quiet, even though he wholeheartedly disagreed. In the end, Cash had a degree in music, and going to concerts had been one of the best things he did with Kate.

It was strange how questionable theories sounded convincing when coming from someone who clearly knew what he was doing with a barbell. Authority came easily in that environment. A guy with thick forearms could explain almost anything, and it might sound like nonsense anywhere else. Maybe it applied only to men, Cash thought.

The same phenomenon probably occurred elsewhere. A doctor could speak confidently in a clinic, even on topics outside their expertise, like education.

Cash played badminton twice a week and had done well in regional tournaments. On that court, he wondered if people sometimes looked at him the same way. If he spoke about something unrelated to badminton, would the lower-level players just listen, assuming he knew what he was talking about? The environment decided that. He had never thought of himself as an authority there.

Nick moved under the bar for another set.

"Physics is about balance. Stress and recovery," he continued after racking the weight.

For Nick, the gym was a system that someone could hack if they paid enough attention.

"It's the same idea with muscle growth. You apply force to the body, and the body applies force back." He said and flexed his right bicep. Cash guessed it was part of the lecture.

"You stress the muscle fibres. Tiny tears. Your body hates instability, so it fixes the damage and adds a little extra there. That little adaptation is called the growth." Nick explained.

"Spoken like a true scientist." Cash laughed and grabbed his water bottle.

"Bro, the body is physics," Nick said. "You just have to listen to it."

They packed their bags and walked toward the exit.

"We should meet again sometime," Cash said. "Come by our place one day."

"Yeah, I'll come." Nick nodded.

Cash thought about something else.

“One of the guys I play badminton with was travelling in Egypt right before all this started,” he said. “Imagine if the timing had landed like that. Waking up every day on the other side of the world. Away from your kids.”

Nick thought about it for a moment and shrugged.

“Might not be the worst thing at first,” he said.

Cash looked at him.

“Some alone time is nice, right?” Nick prompted, clearly wanting him to agree.

Cash said nothing.

“Honestly, a little distance might feel good for a while, right?”

“Yeah, maybe,” he admitted, feeling almost forced to lie.

“And we have video calls now anyway,” Nick said. “People used to travel for months without that. Imagine flying back and forth to Canada all the time. That would be insane.”

He said it so calmly that it felt almost cold.

“You get used to anything,” Nick said.

Later that evening, Cash kept thinking about the conversation. Nick had talked about Newton’s third law as if it explained a time loop. How every motion was met by an equal counter motion, the day moved forward while the universe pushed back according to the laws of nature. Cash was not sure it made sense. It had sounded more convincing at the gym.

But maybe there was something in it. Maybe people worked a little like that, too. When he looked at others, something in him pushed outward, and the world seemed to push something back.

The more he liked someone, the more he noticed something familiar in them. The same worked the other way. The traits that annoyed him in Nick had begun to feel strangely familiar. Nick’s constant need to be right, the habit of explaining things just a little too far, even without any real educational background in the subject. Perhaps it was a reflection of himself.

Chapter 1.6

At first, the idea of working in pairs felt almost absurd. Journalism had always been an individual sport, where everyone was responsible for their own story, which should have been finished yesterday. Assigning two people to the same topic initially felt like CBC was throwing money into a burning fireplace simply because the fireplace existed.

The motivation, however, was fundamentally about mental health. It all began with a psychology study that showed the importance of collaboration in increasing well-being and commitment during the time crisis.

Inspired by this, all CBC employees were required to join a video call where the HR Manager presented the study's findings and encouraged managers to pay attention to workload by allowing tasks to be shared. Starting the next day, Janet listed two reporters on every story.

Chris kept repeating how important it was to take care of oneself, because journalists were needed now just as much as healthcare workers had been during the pandemic. Cash was not sure he fully bought the comparison, but he understood the point. It was their responsibility to keep people informed and also give them something to think about other than the time loop.

Even if the calendar stood still, history moved forward. Every day was new, even when it was not.

So Cash sat next to Peter at his desk, both with laptops open and notes spread out. They had done their background work and interviewed people who had died and come back.

Peter leaned back and rubbed his eyes.

"Have you ever stopped to think how strange all this is?"

"What about it?" Cash laughed.

Peter gestured at their notes.

"All of this. People who consciously take the risk of dying just to see what happens next." He shook his head. "Sounds like a B movie."

Cash sighed.

"Yeah. I wouldn't take the risk. What if the next day suddenly comes? And it sounds selfish and sad when you think about everyone else who witnesses you dying. Geez."

Peter twirled his pen between his fingers like a drummer.

“Same. What do you think, if you didn’t have kids or if you were single? How different would your life be right now?”

“I don’t think I would be doing very well,” Cash admitted quickly and chuckled.

Peter grinned.

“Same. I would probably quit my job and spend all my money on whatever every single day.”

Cash had read about it. People emptied their bank accounts and maxed out their credit cards to fly first class and buy sports cars for a single day. He did not know whether this new kind of consumer culture already deserved a new academic term or whether reckless consumption covered it well enough.

“Still, they are looking for something,” Cash said. “They push everything to the limit, but then what? Does it make them happy, or does it just give them something to do?”

“You and me. We’re just boring,” Peter said, which felt strange coming from a man who still had a half-healed tattoo of a skateboarding cat creature on his arm. He was far from conventional. The last time Peter had talked about his relationship life, he had said he lived in a polyamorous relationship. Cash had later asked Kate what that meant and learned it was not the same as an open relationship.

They continued going through their notes. Remember that what we now have was once something we only hoped for, Cash had written. It was a quote from Epicurus. That was easier said than done. Who would not want more time with their loved ones, while also having more money, more time for hobbies, friends, and just for themselves? It was a cycle of desire that had always driven humanity forward.

“That BASE jumper,” Peter said, bringing them back. “Two deaths. Do you think there will be a third?”

“Hopefully not,” Cash replied. “If this goes on long enough, one of these people will not wake up when the day finally changes.”

Peter thought about it.

“At this point, is it not already more likely that the day will never change than that it will?” He said.

Cash had not given it time to really consider it. Of course, the day would change eventually, even if not tomorrow or the day after. The people who wanted to die just to experience it trusted, like Peter, that April thirteenth was nowhere near.

That was the danger. People imagined the rules had changed in their favour. Death was now treated as a trick or a kind of drug with a built-in reset. The loop promised nothing. There was no reason to believe it could not end suddenly, leaving yesterday's fatal consequences behind.

Some people described death as a light at the end of a tunnel, a floating feeling, and complete peace. Others, like the man whose heart stopped every day, saw something much more frightening. It was nothing.

"The loop is hell for him, but at the same time, he fears it ending," Cash said. "Because he knows what awaits him when his heart stops beating."

"Brutal," Peter whistled. "You should have been there when I interviewed those simulation theory believers last week. They think the system will reboot soon, and none of us will remember any of this."

"Do you believe that?" Cash asked as respectfully as he possibly could.

"Nah. But can you prove it wrong either?"

Cash let the question hang. He did not want to crawl into that rabbit hole, but sometimes it was hard not to fall deeper and deeper. Sartre had written that people became anxious when they understood their own mortality in a reality where life itself had no inherent meaning. That sounded like nihilism, but it was quite the contrary. Life had to have meaning, but it was not something that was handed to you. You had to dig it from the rabbit hole yourself.

Cash was cautious about how easily people grasped at simplified promises. Cash had witnessed how his friends had become tired of traditional religions that no longer fit their liberal values, and New Age beliefs had replaced the void for spirituality. Peter, who had the sacred Hindu om symbol tattooed on his index finger, had once mentioned shamanism as his own hobby when Cash had talked about badminton. Cash was not sure how well it aligned with Hinduism, but at the same the whole thought process made him feel like he was an old dusty desktop computer next to Peter. Peter was the latest model, or maybe the 30-year-old Nokia that had become cool again, as new models were so last season. Whenever the topic turned to something spiritual,

Cash had noticed himself echoing what Kate would say. People liked the way Kate saw the world, and maybe Kate would have been flattered to hear that sometimes Cash borrowed it.
Peter leaned back in his chair and said calmly, “Sometimes something flows through us like the same power line. Telepathy has been proven to be real. One person thinks of another, and the other somehow thinks of them at the exact same time. It feels like we’re all part of the same energy network.”
Cash nodded carefully. He knew Peter believed what he was saying with all his heart. “I understand what you mean. It often feels that way.” He paused, feeling a strange adrenaline as he felt an urge to challenge Peter’s beliefs and see how open he himself would be to alternative views.
“But from a slightly more materialistic point of view, maybe they both just heard the same song on the radio that was playing the last time they met.”
Peter laughed. “That could be. But that sounds much vaguer than telepathy, which actually has successful studies done in laboratory conditions. Have you heard of quantum entanglement?”
Cash shook his head. “I have to admit I didn’t pay much attention in physics class. I was more interested in social sciences and anything related to people.”
“Well, this might interest you more than what teachers tried to teach. According to it, two particles are connected even if they are light-years apart,” Peter explained. “When the other changes, the other reacts instantly, too. It is like an invisible bond.”
“That sounds romantic,” Cash replied. “I know nothing about it, but I just wonder, could there be a risk that the word quantum allows making more meaning into something that’s actually quite boring and explainable? I thought physics was just mathematical formulas.”
“I get it sounds like hippie talk, but this is a really puzzling, real phenomenon. And it shows science has just confirmed what different cultures have already known for a long time. That we are more than this,” Peter said, pointing at his head.
“Yes, I understand what you mean. I’m sure you know a lot about Hinduism, where they believe that the individual soul, atman, merges with the world soul, brahman. This kind of enlightenment is a powerful and beautiful idea, like the thought that all the energy in the world has always existed and always will. But I’m not sure if that means I was in any way conscious in those

millions of particles before I existed as me or if my energy will remain conscious when I one day break into atoms."

"Is it not fascinating if science and ancient wisdom can meet and not be opposites like people often think?" Peter asked.

"It's definitely tempting," Cash said. "But the track record for religions isn't very flattering when they have gone into a boxing match with scientific scrutiny. According to the Bible, the world is only a few thousand years old, but science shows it's over thirteen billion. Human history is known so precisely that religions have started to call their creation stories symbolic. I doubt that most physicists would see anything spiritual in quantum physics."

Peter smiled, feeling empathy towards those physicists. "Maybe that's why they can't see the world as objectively as they think. They can't be open to anything that doesn't match their own materialistic worldview. Think about how electricity was once seen as magic. Is it not hubris to think the physical world is the only truth, when we have clear evidence that scientists have always been very wrong about some things they have felt certain about?"

"Fair point. And maybe I'm also limited in my thinking, too. I know my wife is much more open to changing her views about reality. She heard yesterday that on the first day of the month, you should blow cinnamon into your home to bring good luck, and got worried we hadn't done it before. In the end, she made me blow cinnamon through our door."

Peter laughed. He clearly knew the tradition and possibly appreciated that Cash had kept his mind open to new ideas. But in reality, Cash had sincerely hoped that no neighbour would have seen him in the hallway as a magician's assistant. He was not sure why it was so important, even though they barely knew their neighbours. Of course, after all that, he had wanted to know why he was doing what he was doing. Not to debunk the tradition. What good would that do? Nothing at all. He was just sincerely interested in its origin, similar to why he was interested in learning more about world religions. Not to convert but to understand.

An internet search showed cinnamon was associated with attracting wealth and abundance. The tradition seemed to be a mix of old folk beliefs and New Age spirituality. Some sources mentioned Romans burning cinnamon as incense for the gods of abundance, while in other cultures in the Caribbean and South America, it was linked to protecting the home.

The power of rituals did not lie in belief in truth, but in repetition. Humans were herd animals, and when someone had already skied the track long enough, it was acceptable to trust it would curve downhill where it should, and not unexpectedly into a ditch.

Was Cash's mind limited like a chess knight, only able to move in the shape of L? Even traditional games sometimes received rule updates that forced players to think differently. The same had happened in hockey, where passing forward was once forbidden, and in basketball, which had no three-point line before the 1970s. Not too long ago, horoscopes had received an update, one that most believers chose not to believe in. The new sign called Ophiuchus did not make any sense to them, and neither did the change of one's own horoscope, after believing their whole lives that they matched perfectly with their original one.

Although Cash did not believe in horoscopes beyond them having a self-fulfilling prophecy, he liked the update because it reflected how the star map looked now, and not how it had looked in Babylonian times, which was the basis for 12 horoscopes. Ophiuchus was added when it was noticed that the connection between constellations and zodiac signs had shifted over centuries. People rejected the new sign because the old felt familiar and the new seemed absurd. Pluto could be rationally removed retrospectively from the list of planets in a single day, but horoscopes did not seem to bend to the same rational treatment.

The whole phenomenon reminded him of the modern DISC personality test, where people were divided into red, yellow, green, and blue. No one would believe it applied precisely thousands of years into the future, yet horoscopes were given different weight because their old age was enough to strengthen their authority. What sounded scientific was prone to new science. Beliefs that were based on old traditions were more like Teflon pans. They were easy to maintain.

Humans were skilled at placing their own belief systems above others. Christians could look down on newer religions and laugh at young people paying almost a hundred dollars for Tarot readings. Cash wanted to respect all religions that built the common good, but even he knew how to climb onto an invisible pedestal.

On a friend's trip to Los Angeles, they had gone to the Scientology centre on Sunset Strip because it seemed like a funny idea in a cheerful buzz that a few beers had helped achieve. The experience turned out surprisingly anticlimactic. Only things suitable for a psychology textbook

were shown to the general public. Secret teachings, expensive levels, and glossy photos of Hollywood stars were all very absent. No one even tried to convert him. After visiting the centre, they had gone to Hooters, something Cash had not done since his early twenties. Cash had looked into his friends' faces, wondering why the Scientologist had used more effort to teach them than him, even though he was the only one who had even studied religions. His friend had said too quickly for Cash's comfort that his materialistic worldview was very easy to read on his face. He did not know whether to take that as a compliment or just a comment on his sceptical resting expression.

"Maybe that is exactly why you don't fall for easy explanations," Peter said, as if he had heard Cash's thoughts. "Scepticism is its own kind of religion too, but at least it protects you from online scams." He continued.

"When do you think people will lose faith in life, if tomorrow never seems to come?" Cash asked, bringing them back to the actual topic of their article.

"Depends on what you have to lose," Peter replied.

Cash looked at the framed photo of Kate and the girls on his desk, his only personal item in the entire office. Not everyone had the same reason to be careful, and some could take life-threatening risks when life itself seemed to weigh less in time.

Some people no longer feared death because they had experienced it. Others feared it more for that same reason. Cash and Peter did not know what to conclude from that, so they contacted religious leaders, for whom the topic was surely theologically challenging, but whose work was to find meaning and hope where others could not yet see it.

CBC Interviews People Who Have Died Repeatedly

Spiritual Leaders Comment on Worrisome Death for Curiousity Trend

Cash Haggerty and Peter Black | CBC | April 12

For most people, death is the great unknown. But in a world where the same day repeats itself, some have crossed that boundary more than once and woken up the next morning as if nothing happened. Their experiences force us to reconsider our ideas about mortality and what, if anything, comes after it.

CBC spoke with people who have died and returned to life. Each of them had a unique story. Liam, a 29-year-old BASE jumper, has died twice since the loop began. “The first time I panicked. I knew immediately that this was it,” he says. “Then I woke up in my bed and felt more relieved than I ever have in my life.” The phenomenon has led some extreme sports enthusiasts to take increasingly greater risks, while others strongly warn against this way of thinking. Jack Yu, a skydiver from a Vancouver Island Club, stresses that safety rules exist for a reason. “These reckless people ruin the reputation of the entire sport and put both themselves and others in danger. In our club, you can’t jump with a BASE parachute until you have completed 500 successful jumps. We all know someone who has died doing this. BASE jumping is a safety-focused sport, and there is zero tolerance for stupidity.”

For some, death has become a daily nightmare. Frank, 54, experiences his heart stopping every single day of the loop, just as it did the first time on April 12. He plans his days so that help is always nearby. “I have only seen darkness, emptiness, nothing,” he says fearfully. “Maybe the loop can eventually save me from having April 12 engraved on my gravestone.”

Others, like 19-year-old Hannah, have taken their own lives to experience what happens after death. Her case is part of a broader social media phenomenon in which young people share their experiences of moments after death. “I loved it. An angel held my hand, I felt peace, and I knew that everything I had been taught about heaven was true. When I woke up, I wanted to go back there again.” Hannah now receives mental health support and has promised her parents that she will never do it again. She emphasizes that she no longer fears death, so she simultaneously does not regret her actions.

Religious leaders have been forced to reflect on how the loop fits within theological teachings. Bishop Oscar Herrera of the Catholic Diocese of Vancouver does not see a contradiction. “When a person dies, the soul leaves the body but remains on earth for three days. When the same day begins again, the soul always finds its way back to its place. Everything has a purpose. These souls do not yet belong in heaven,” he says. “Only God knows when the repetition will end. Until then, we must live our lives with respect, because life is sacred.”

According to Imam Ahmed Rahman, in Islam, the soul moves at the moment of death into a state called barzakh. “The loop does not negate death. The soul moves to the place appointed by Allah to await resurrection,” he says.

Rahman does not see the loop as conflicting with Islam, but he warns against using it as an excuse for reckless living. “This is a test. Each day of the loop is a new opportunity, but also a new responsibility. Even if you wake up again every time, your actions are not erased. Allah knows what is in our hearts, and every moment carries weight.” He emphasizes that repeated death does not remove its seriousness.

Rabbi Levi Cohen views the phenomenon among young people with deep concern but also understanding. “In Judaism, life is sacred. It is the greatest gift God has given humanity, and it is not ours to decide when it ends. The fact that a young person is willing to give up their life to experience death speaks of deep confusion and perhaps a longing that has not yet found words.”

Cohen emphasizes that in Judaism, the afterlife remains God’s secret. “The Talmud says that just as we do not know where we come from, we do not know where we are going. We do not live to experience death, but to make this world more holy.” He acknowledges that the unique nature of the loop may tempt people to seek answers through death or even to escape pain. “But that does not make it right. Each day, even if identical, is a new opportunity to do good. Returning to the right path is always open.”

Cohen also appeals to communities and families. “Everyone needs someone who reminds them that their life has intrinsic value.”

Science offers its own explanations. Dr. Maddy Lin, a neuroscientist at the University of British Columbia, suggests that experiences after death are most likely related to brain activity.

“Feelings of peace, dreamlike images, and other sensations may result from the release of DMT in the brain. Our brains continue to function within the loop in the same way they always have.” Some see returning to life after death as permission to live without fear of dying. Others remind us that death should still not be taken lightly. Recreational dying is not only a spiritual risk but also a very concrete one when the world eventually sees the date April 13.

Chapter 1.7

Cash had always been close to his family. The long distance had only increased how much they stayed in touch. His parents lived in Toronto, his sister in Montreal, and his brother in Halifax. A flight from Vancouver to the East Coast took over five hours, not counting airport procedures and transfers. During the loop, all trips were essentially day trips.

So they had found a compromise. Winnipeg. None of them had ever been there. In a world where novelty had become a valuable currency, that alone was reason enough to travel to the capital of Manitoba.

Cash's employer still respected weekends, even though no law required it. Officially, it was always April twelfth, but people still talked about Fridays and Sunday dinners.

On the plane, he tried to think of what he actually knew about the city. Its airport code came first. YWG. He had seen it before, and it felt natural, as all major Canadian airports started with Y and were followed by something that resembled the city's name. Vancouver was YVR, Calgary was YYC, and Edmonton was YEG, he thought as he looked at the map on the monitor. They all made sense. Except that the letter Y was a detail that belonged in a pub quiz. It was not useful to remember in any practical sense, but it was still interesting because it just meant yes. Yes, the original airport had a weather or radio station.

In most countries, airport codes were the first three letters of the city, but in Canada, no one seemed to want to change something that had once served a purpose. There was something admirable about that. History came before user experience.

Then he saw Toronto. YYZ. That made even less sense. He could hear the question the flight attendant could have asked if planes had trivia similar to organized bus trips. What does the Z in YYZ stand for, a voice could have asked through the speaker. The village of Milton, he answered in his head, while agreeing that it was bizarre.

It was strange how on a bus everyone was expected to participate, but on a plane their role was to disappear. On a plane, it just felt wrong and tacky.

Cash also knew that Winnipeg had a human rights museum and that the city's NHL team, the Jets, happened to be playing the Colorado Avalanche on the day of their visit. The idea of the

game sounded good to everyone, even though Cash was the only one who followed hockey. They did not need an activity. Being together would have been enough. Still, choosing something unfamiliar helped draw a clear line between these days and the rest of their lives.

Because of logistics, the NHL had begun playing only division games, so this was a rare chance for Cash to see teams other than those in the Pacific Division.

Florence and Arabella did not focus much on the game itself, which was understandable. Florence spent most of the time wondering why hockey players were so violent, while Arabella mainly waited for the Zamboni to come onto the ice.

There was something time-loop-like about hockey. Season after season, shift after shift, the game moved forward in a familiar rhythm. Attack followed defence, defence followed attack. The lines changed in order, first, second, third, fourth, and back to the first. The penalty box filled and emptied, the buzzer sounded, and an intermission came.

Cash's sister took the girls to meet the home team's moose mascot. His brother filmed the game, even though the footage would disappear into space-time the following night. Cash's father had clearly read the afternoon papers before the game, as he talked about player dramas, addictions, and bankruptcies. His mother, on the other hand, lived every moment of the game with pure excitement.

For the first time in a long while, Cash allowed himself to simply enjoy the moment, even though he knew it would soon vanish. But had it not always been that way? Moments, of course, were temporary as well before the loop.

Nietzsche had said that the future should not merely be accepted, but loved. Amor fati. What a beautifully optimistic idea.

As they were leaving the arena, they encountered a group of Groundhoggers handing out flyers near the exit. Cash had read Bob's article about them on the day the world changed, but seeing them now, he felt the same emotion someone might feel when they finally meet a person they have heard a lot about.

It was not helping their credibility that their large roll-up banner featured who else but Phil Connors. The character played by Bill Murray stared ahead with a silly speech bubble beside his head, saying:

WE MUST BE WORTHY OF TOMORROW.

Cash was fascinated by how some people could be completely certain about things without the slightest evidence. They had seen a movie and decided it applied to this reality, simply because the phenomenon looked similar.

“We have to fix things before time can move forward,” one of them preached to everyone passing by. “You, you, you. Everyone has to find their direction and the mission meant for them.”

“And then?” Cash asked, stopping as the others kept walking forward, until they stopped to see what Cash now had in mind.

“Then time continues. But with this many people, months will not be enough, since this applies to every one of us. Phil Connors was a prophet who gave us the tools to solve this.”

Cash tried to hide a grin. The answer was appropriate to every possible outcome. If the loop continued, it proved humanity still had at least some way to go, and if it ended, the theory had been correct.

“You feel it too,” the man continued in a lower voice. “That feeling that we are meant to do something. To become better.”

It was vague enough to hook you and bold enough to spark curiousity. But words always came at a price. Morality turned into moralizing, moralizing into the use of power, and the use of power into prophetic preaching. True morality was instinctive and did not depend on pamphlet distributors.

Cash pulled his phone from his pocket. “Would you be willing to answer a few questions for a CBC article?”

The man hesitated. “Only if you genuinely believe in the message. We don’t want to be portrayed as a joke.”

Cash blinked. He had not expected that. He had approached them the way he once had charity scammers near the Eiffel Tower in Paris, people pretending to be deaf and pushing donation forms at tourists. Back then, he had written THIS IS A SCAM in the name field and zero as the amount. The scammer had torn up the paper and pulled out a new one.

But this was not the same. The Groundhoggers were not asking for money. They were not trying to deceive anyone. They believed. And for a moment, Cash felt ashamed of his approach.

“Sorry,” he said.

The man nodded slowly, as if he understood exactly what had just happened in Cash’s mind.

“You can take a flyer, if you want.”

Cash did.

That evening, after the girls had fallen asleep, Cash sat in the hotel lobby with his family, drinking overpriced beer. His mother praised what a good idea Winnipeg had been, and suggested that next time they could choose another Canadian city, or maybe even somewhere farther south in the United States.

“Yeah, maybe,” Cash replied.

The truth was that he and Kate were quietly boycotting their southern neighbour. A new trade war was brewing, and President Hogan’s rhetoric had once again turned threatening toward Canada. He had never forgiven Canadians for how his policies had been treated before the election. In Hogan’s view, Canada was a passive-aggressive and ungrateful nation.

Winnipeg’s time zone meant that the reset moment of the loop happened slightly later than in Vancouver. The small differences in when it tended to happen for his parents and siblings compared to Cash and other Vancouverites led to an interesting conversation.

It was bizarre that commercial flights were still flying at the moment of the reset. Perhaps, flying was something that people genuinely enjoyed, and for Cash, a plane was just a tool to get from point A to point B. But did the reset happen differently at ten kilometres above the ground? Did pilots feel a brief sense of weightlessness if their loop began and ended during a flight, but at a different altitude? These were interesting questions.

The next morning, Cash woke up at home. It felt as if he had been taken apart into atoms and put back together. A teleport.

Chapter 1.8

Cash could not get the Groundhoggers out of his mind. Their absolute message felt like an answer that was too easy for such an absurd reality. Camus would have called it philosophical suicide. It meant escaping the absurdity by clinging to promises of final order and meaning, which could be comforting but also deceptive.

The Groundhoggers' worldview reminded Cash of Camus, who argued that the most fundamental question of philosophy was whether life was worth living. If the world offered no inherent purpose, what justified continuing to live? Camus did not suggest giving up, but rebellion. A rebellion in which a person faced the absurdity of life without comforting illusions.

His thoughts drifted to utilitarianism, the idea of producing the greatest good for the greatest number of people. On the surface, it seemed sensible and practical. But history had shown that the good of the majority was not always just, since the greatest good could be achieved by limiting the rights of minorities.

John Rawls had imagined a different kind of world. It was one in which no one knew in advance the position where they would be born. Behind a veil of ignorance, people would be forced to agree on the fairest possible rules, knowing they themselves might end up among the weakest. The thought experiment was so compelling, but how many truly idealistic societies had ever succeeded? Humans were capable of deeply moving altruism, but also of ugly selfishness, where principles of equality collapsed the moment they demanded real discomfort. The problem was not the values. The problem was how fragile people's commitment to them became when those values had a cost.

Society developed quickly, but humans did not. We could be taught to think ethically, but we were still running old source code. It could be modified, yes, but the operating system came from a time when survival required a very different kind of logic. Empathy and cooperation were optional add-ons to our basic settings, but since they were not updated automatically, they had to be deliberately reinstalled year after year and generation after generation.

Then there was the question of whose morality the Groundhoggers were actually promoting. There were countless cultures and even more perspectives. Was there even such a thing as universal morality?

Many would have pointed to the Ten Commandments, often without realizing that their original context also accepted slavery. The Golden Rule offered a stronger starting point, since versions of it appeared across cultures and centuries. The UN's Universal Declaration of Human Rights might have been better and more modern benchmark for the kind of global morality the Groundhoggers expected from humanity. Yet it had failed to inspire people to become morally better, so maybe they needed an improved version of that, something that would compress justice into something simple elegantly like E equals mc squared in physics.

The Groundhoggers wanted to start with a clean slate, just as Rawls had imagined. The problem was that people were not blank slates. They carried their histories, fears, and prejudices with them. Did they really believe all of that could simply be wiped away?

"Cash? Do you want an omelette?" Kate's voice pulled him back to the moment.

"Yeah, thanks," he replied, reaching for his coffee. He took a sip without paying attention to the taste.

Taste mattered less to him with coffee than with beer, which had to be a certain way. Morning coffee was, above all, a ritual.

Coffee. The word was Turkish, even though the drink's roots reached deeper into the highlands of Yemen and Ethiopia. From there, it spread with Sufi mystics, who believed caffeine helped them stay awake during night prayers. It was ironic that today, coffee in the West was used to stay alert through long workdays. Hardly anyone used it as a tool for religious practice anymore. What had once been a spiritual discipline had become a production tool of the market economy.

On the other side of the table, the children were arguing about something.

"Florence, Arabella, what if we got a pet?" Kate asked.

Florence's eyes lit up. "Can we get a pig?"

Arabella frowned. "No, a turtle."

Kate gave Cash an apologetic look for opening yet another topic the girls could argue about. Cash felt a twinge of guilt for not even knowing what the earlier argument had been about. He

had heard it, but had not necessarily listened. It was like he had a song stuck in his head that would not end until he heard it all the way through.

Cash stepped away from the table for a moment and went to the bathroom, pulling out his phone. His family deserved his presence, not a non-player character acting out the role of father and husband.

The Groundhoggers were, at their core, trying to explain a chaotic world, much like journalists. The difference was where they began. Journalists started with questions, Groundhoggers with answers. Of course, newspapers often fell into the same trap, because endless shades of grey rarely sold.

There were exceptions. Uncertainty in sports coverage made the whole thing interesting. It was not interesting if, halfway through the season, one team would have been declared the winner. No, what was interesting were the complicated scenarios of how your favourite team could still make the playoffs. Advancement depended on other teams losing and cross-played matchups. People liked to joke about who even had the energy to write these scenarios, yet they kept reading. More than once, a team that had been written off caught fire, went on a winning streak, and made it into the playoffs.

Cash finally found the Groundhoggers' email address. It was strange to think that someone must have registered it before the loop began. Or maybe someone created it every morning before someone else could claim it as a joke. Perhaps the movement had existed even before April twelfth, and the time loop was a celebratory event for them, like the Second Coming of Jesus for those who quoted the Book of Revelation. If the movement existed before the loop, what exactly had they been predicting? That time would stop in the future, not just for one person but for everyone. That humanity would align on a moral frequency that allowed time to continue. Time itself seemed to have a contractual condition in a reality where humanity imagined itself so important that the universe kept track of whether its terms were being met.

The earliest writings Cash found about the Groundhoggers before the loop were stories about people who claimed to have lived in time loops and the methods they used to escape them. It was interesting how Cash dismissed all those stories as complete nonsense, even though he was now living in a loop himself.

Starting a movement was never easy. During the loop, coordination was surely even harder. Still, gaining attention only required that every morning led to the same day. It was like a perfect pass right onto the stick of the Groundhoggers in front of an open net, each morning, another puck ready to be shot.

Writing the email was difficult because he wanted a reply. The tone could not be dismissive, but it could not support their message either, or he would not be honest with himself or with them. Cash had grown up with many freedoms, but telling the truth was a value that was never compromised. He tried to teach the same to his daughters, even though harmless white lies were also an important part of social intelligence.

From: cash.haggerty@cbc.ca

To: groundhoggers@gmail.com

Subject: Interview request / CBC

Hello,

I am contacting you on behalf of CBC to better understand the message of your movement. I met members of your group yesterday in Winnipeg and received a flyer stating: “Humanity must prove itself worthy of time continuing.”

I would like to better understand what this means in practice.

How do you define the moral standard you are aiming for?

How is its fulfilment measured?

Are there historical examples of societies that reflect your vision?

Would you be open to an interview or to answering these questions by email?

Kind regards,

Cash Haggerty

Domestic Affairs Reporter, CBC

He hesitated for a moment before pressing send. The topic had not been officially assigned to him, and CBC might already be working on another piece about the movement. The problem might be that the message sounded as if he had the authority to turn the response into a news article. It was one thing to reply to a simply curious stranger, and another to answer a journalist who could bring their message a bigger platform. But a journalist had to stay alert to what was happening around him, Cash thought, as he walked back to the dining room.

“Pigs are way smarter,” Florence declared.

“Turtles,” Arabella argued back. “They live longer and don’t make a mess.”

“Pigs are clean animals. Their skin just dries out easily. We have a shower and a bath. Dad, tell her!”

“Dogs are a human’s best friend,” Cash said.

Florence and Arabella immediately forgot their argument and turned to him, eyes shining.

“Really? Can we get a puppy?”

Kate looked at him. Her expression silently reminded him that promises were expected to be kept. Cash nodded at her.

The girls immediately began arguing about breeds. Family life with children included days that required the negotiation skills of a Middle East peace mediator. Watching them, Cash began to wonder what getting a dog would actually mean in a time loop. He realized he had planted the seed of disappointment by speaking too quickly.

The puppy would have to be picked up from a shelter every day. It would never grow during the loop, though it might start to recognize them and learn the rhythm of its new life. One could get used to the daily logistics, and the dog would grow attached to them. Still, it sounded like a very strange arrangement.

Later that evening, after the girls had fallen asleep, Cash and Kate sat on the couch watching television.

Kate scrolled on her phone. “I saw a post today. People are starting to celebrate loop anniversaries.”

Cash turned his gaze fully to her, and Kate flinched slightly. She had often said she only needed seventy percent of Cash’s attention. Any more than that felt too intense, she had explained.

During the loop, Cash had not once heard Kate say he was giving her too much attention. A sudden wave of regret hit him as he realized how often his focus had drifted elsewhere, even though his family mattered most.

“They mark the first, second, and third month in the loop. They celebrate. Buy cakes,” Kate continued.

Cash shook his head. “That’s crazy.”

“Is it?” Kate replied. “We celebrate New Year’s too, even though it’s just one day like any other. Maybe this is the same.”

Cash thought for a moment. People needed milestones, illusions of progress, even when nothing truly changed in repetition.

Kate set her phone down. “The school board sent an email.”

Cash waited.

“Grade ones become grade twos, twos become threes,” Kate said. “They think education needs to continue as normally as possible, even if time does not move.”

Cash sighed. He was not sure it made sense. If children’s neurological development stayed in place, how far could they really advance? After how many months or years would they hit a limit where the material no longer fit the abilities of second graders?

Kate read his silence.

“We have to keep going, Cash,” she said. “We have to believe everything will turn out fine. For the kids.”

Her voice was steady, but her eyes told a different story.

Kate was not trying to convince Cash. She was trying to convince herself.

Cash swallowed. “I know.”

But before he could stop himself, the words slipped out.

“But what if they never grow into adults?”

Kate stiffened.

“Don’t,” she said.

“That sounds like giving up. And we can’t. Not for them.”

A heavy silence settled over the room, dense enough to feel almost solid. Kate stood up and moved away with the firmness of an army official, as if to crystallize the point. Cash stared at the television. He wished he could rewind and reset the conversation they had just had, but the loop did not exactly work that way.

Chapter 1.9

Cash had always loved reading. Lately, though, he had found himself holding physics books, perhaps because of the interview with Langley or the conversations about quantum mechanics he had had with Peter. The more physics took space in his thoughts, the more often it seemed to appear everywhere around him. It was a textbook case of confirmation bias.

During his university years, Cash had considered massive telescopes a waste of taxpayers' money, given how rarely they were actually used for scientific publications. He recalled hearing that, when all acquisition and maintenance costs were factored in, a single scientific paper could end up costing a million dollars. It did not help that the construction of CERN's LHC particle accelerator had cost 10 billion dollars and, so far, had produced only one new particle. It was named after someone who had predicted its existence already back in the 1960s. Was it really worth it?

In his Master's program, Cash had been a typical humanities student who was mostly interested in the social sciences, psychology, and philosophy. Physics, however, seemed the most appropriate source of information for answering what the loop actually was. Psychology and philosophy taught how one should respond to the loop, but for its origin, it was either physics or religion.

As long as Cash could remember, reading had been his way of absorbing knowledge in a form that was difficult to put into words. What he read did not remain on the page but transformed into something tangible, much like colours do for a synaesthete. That was why he remembered what he read so well. He did not have a photographic memory, but when he immersed himself in material, he felt like he had travelled inside it. Lived experience was easier to remember.

He felt a strange guilt about not having paid more attention to physics earlier in life. Why had he believed he needed to fit into a single intellectual identity? Nothing had ever prevented him from being more. The loop had shattered many of his assumptions. Why would this one be any different?

Chris had agreed to Cash's idea of doing another interview with Langley. Langley was gaining recognition in his field and had been invited to speak about the physics of the loop at several

universities abroad. Beyond professional reasons, Cash's interest was personal. Over the past months, he had been studying physics like someone trying to make up for years of indifference toward an entire discipline. He had absorbed Hawking, Rovelli, and Sagan like a sponge. They were fascinating, but none of them had quite filled the gap that represented a true understanding of the time loop.

Cash was probably still in a Dunning-Kruger phase, thinking he understood far more than he actually did. Would Langley notice how he was keeping up better with the conversation? Hopefully not. At least, it could not show outwardly. If someone told Cash he looked like a person interested in physics, he would probably have been offended. It was a weird stereotype. Why did Cash feel it was somehow better to be assumed capable of playing the guitar than to be someone who understood physics?

Now he sat across from Langley and heard himself say, "What about quantum mechanics? You said earlier that strange things can happen on the microscopic level."

Langley looked up from his papers. He was tall and lean, with sharp, almost aristocratic features. He adjusted his glasses on the bridge of his nose and nodded.

"Exactly. Particles can exist in multiple states at the same time, and time behaves differently on very small scales. But those phenomena do not apply at the macroscopic level. The loop does not behave like quantum superposition or time dilation. It is something else entirely."

Cash stared at the papers on Langley's desk, filled with calculations that were as incomprehensible to him as a foreign language. He was still not interested in equations or the mathematical side of physics. His reading had been selective, focused mainly on the nature of time.

This time, however, he did not just nod along. He leaned forward.

"Because of decoherence, we don't see quantum effects in everyday life. Superposition collapses when a system interacts with its environment, which is why Schrödinger's cat is either dead or alive when the box is opened."

Langley looked surprised.

"Yes. Exactly."

“And time dilation happens, but we just can’t recognize it. Astronauts on the International Space Station age more slowly than we do on Earth, and GPS satellites have to account for time distortions.”

Langley leaned back in his chair, an amused expression on his face.

“You are clearly well read on the subject.”

Cash felt embarrassed, a faint sense of shame creeping in as he realized he had spoken about something that was kindergarten-level physics to Langley.

“I thought I needed to understand, at least on a theoretical level, how this could be explained scientifically.” Cash said.

Langley laughed.

“All right, fair enough. Based on your research, what do you think the loop actually is?”

The question sounded sincere, so Cash began his answer slowly, like a train leaving a station.

“I agree that quantum superposition doesn’t make sense here. As you said, we don’t exist in two places at once. But maybe, contrary to what you said earlier, we don’t operate outside the laws of physics. Maybe the loop is built into them. It could have something to do with closed timelike curves. Or perhaps a macroscopic observer effect explains it. Each day is more like a reobservation rather than a hard reset. Does that sound crazy?”

Langley adjusted his glasses and leaned forward.

“Let us unpack that. Yes, closed timelike curves allow paths in spacetime that loop back onto themselves, like an ouroboros that eats its own tail. But if the loop worked that way, we would be having this exact conversation over and over again. It would be impossible to prove or disprove. Have you heard of Novikov’s self-consistency principle?”

Cash shook his head.

“Time loops must be internally consistent. They cannot contain paradoxes. But our loop does not merely preserve consistency. It actively resets events and erases changes. Closed timelike curves do not work like that. If we were in one, changes would follow causal laws. What we are seeing behaves more like a system that restores itself to a previous state.”

Cash was silent for a moment.

“Like a checkpoint in a video game.”

Langley nodded.

“Exactly. But physics does not describe time that way. It is not a file that gets reloaded. That brings us to the other theory you mentioned, the observer effect.”

“Why could it not apply here?” Cash asked, trying to keep up.

Langley chose his words carefully.

“In quantum mechanics, the observer effect refers to measurement collapsing a superposition into a defined state. What you are describing would require an observation that rewrites reality on a macroscopic level. That is not how quantum mechanics works. But if the observer effect truly influences the loop, then who or what is doing the observing?”

Cash thought for a moment.

“So who’s running the simulation?”

Langley hesitated before answering.

“Yes. It would imply that there is an external observer that collapses reality into the same state again and again.”

Something twisted ominously in Cash’s stomach.

“So we might be like characters in a video game. Simulation theorists would love this.”

“And perhaps it leaves room for believing that consciousness is observing us, something people often call God,” Langley said mysteriously.

Cash was not sure whether divinity belonged in a scientific article. Still, if he did mention a simulation checkpoint as a possible explanation for the loop, then God as the conductor of everything was just as defensible. And what would prevent the two from being connected, and our universe was merely one of God’s computer games?

The meeting with Langley sent Cash back to his own bookshelf. He had shamelessly taken advantage of the loop by using bookstores like libraries. Cash looked at their bookshelf and realized the answer might not lie in physics, philosophy, or religion alone, but in all of them together. Or was he trying to make physics again more interesting than it really was?

He thought about how fortunate he was that the philosophers he admired were not among the worst. Was there a version of him whose favourite book was *Mein Kampf*? He shook the thought away and hoped such a version did not exist, even if, in theory, all possible parallel realities did.

Kate was asleep. Cash lay beside her, reading the original French version of *The Myth of Sisyphus*. He had been to France several times, most recently just a few weeks before the loop began. It had been a family trip to Paris. He could still hear Florence's excitement when she recognized Marie Curie's name engraved on the Eiffel Tower. It was a later addition. Originally, only seventy-two men had earned their place there.

There was something Camusian about the whole thing. It was just a monument. He could have googled it later and found a better photograph, sharper and taken in better light. It would have been different if someone from their group had stood beside it, proof of having been there. People seemed to take ownership of whatever they photographed, even when the image would remain unpublished and possibly forgotten. They became shareholders.

It was not the same thing to find someone else's photo and save it. It would not even have been the same thing if Cash had stayed at the apartment and later seen the monument in his dad's camera roll. Ownership meant choice. You had decided to take the picture in a world that did not care whether you did or not.

Camus would not have recommended rejecting meaning altogether, nor replacing it with illusion, but living with the knowledge that meaning was self-made. Much like Cash deciding to use memory space on things that mattered to him, even if they looked irrational from the outside. Like Sisyphus pushing the rock, the photo did not change the world. It changed you.

Cash closed the book and stared at the ceiling.

"Push the stone again and again, and find joy in the effort."

Yes, there was something almost Zen Buddhist in that. Do what was needed in this moment. Active acceptance. Cash liked the idea that no action was more valuable than another, only more present or less. A burned pot was not a failure. It was what was in front of him. Reframing it like that helped. Scrubbing the pot became like playing badminton or tennis. You responded to what came at you and returned it.

The next morning, Cash decided to listen to the Camus of his imagination and took the girls to the park. As Florence and Arabella climbed the play structure, their laughter filled his heart. That was when he got the idea for his first tattoo. Working with Peter may have influenced him. He wanted permanent ink on his skin, an audio waveform of Florence's and Arabella's laughter.

During the loop, he could try different tattoo artists. After the loop, he would choose the one that worked best. Someone might call the idea crazy or overly cautious for something so simple, depending perhaps on whether the speaker had tattoos themselves. Tattooed people were a club one might never truly understand before letting ink touch skin.

He wondered whether people now got more impulse tattoos and whether that opened the door to the club in the same way, knowing the tattoos would disappear. If permanence was not part of the package, was it even a tattoo? Would a henna tattoo not serve the same purpose? Then again, laser removal and cover-ups had always existed.

Part of what made a tattoo meaningful was its relationship with time. A tattoo was an attempt to anchor a specific moment. Perhaps that symbolism applied most strongly to the first tattoo, which often represented something deeply personal. Once someone was already a member of the club, they could walk into a studio, flip through an artist's folder, and choose a design simply because it looked the best.

Chapter 1.10

Cash could not pinpoint when Chris had started calling the team a family, but it bothered him more each time he heard it. Maybe it was meant to sound innocent and harmless, the kind of thing a well-meaning leader would say. In reality, the idea carried a quiet contradiction. No one could ever do too much for their family.

No, CBC was far too large to be called a family. It was not even small enough to compare to a hunter-gatherer band, thirty, maybe fifty people at most. This was an institution, one that could, at any moment, cut half its so-called family and call it strategy.

Because almost everything about Chris irritated him today, Cash had planned to avoid him altogether. Chris had the gaze of a man who seemed to be constantly evaluating others, placing himself just above them.

Maybe Cash had woken up on the wrong side of the bed, or with the wrong foot, as they said in parts of Europe. There were bigger problems in the world. Getting annoyed about a family metaphor was a neatly packaged first-world problem. Still, he knew he could find research to back his instinct if anyone claimed it was not a real concern.

Adrenaline surged through Cash.

“They are not a cult,” he said, the tension in his voice impossible to hide. “What’s next? Neo-saviours are terrorists, see photos?”

“Not a bad headline. I don’t appreciate the tone, though.” Chris grinned and pointed at him.

Cash exhaled through his nose and looked down at the printout. Nothing he said would change how Chris approached his work.

“When the loop ends,” he said, feeling his heartbeat pick up, “we have to live with what we’ve done. If we start pushing false narratives, the damage to our credibility doesn’t just disappear.”

Chris studied him for a moment, like a researcher observing a slow test subject.

“So you still believe the loop will end?”

Cash did not answer.

Chris lifted his can of sparkling water and took a slow sip.

“What if this is the end, Cash? Even if it is, it doesn’t change how I do my job, and should not change how you do yours.”

The casualness of it, that everyday nihilism, made Cash’s stomach twist. He thought of a line he had heard once from Simon Sinek, how you do one thing is how you do everything.

Cash had always believed the purpose of journalism was to reveal the truth. Chris believed its purpose was to build a narrative.

Would a good journalist really do that? Cash asked himself. The same question returned in other forms. What kind of husband did he want to be? Would a good father act this way? A good friend? A good son?

People did not act morally only to avoid punishment or consequences. They acted because their choices shaped who they became. That was William James, almost. Honesty was not just a way to avoid being caught. It was a decision to be someone who could be seen as honest.

Some must have thought there was no point in holding back, no reason to stop speeding or to keep trying to be good when time itself had stopped. Cash felt the opposite. If anything, it mattered more now than ever, because today was superscripted.

As he cycled to pick up the girls, he smelled the familiar smell of wet asphalt. For a brief moment, everything felt almost normal.

Florence had many questions as they walked. Arabella, at least so far, had lived her life without major questions about the surrounding reality. Her young age might have protected her. She had accepted the new reality without much resistance. Florence was different.

“Daddy,” Florence asked as Cash walked his bike, “how do we know this is not a dream?”

Arabella, walking beside her, pinched Florence and giggled.

“There. Now you know it’s not.”

Florence was not in a playful mood.

“Ouch. That’s violence.”

“This is not a dream,” Cash said, “but it is my dream to have two girls as amazing as you.”

He could see Florence still thinking about it. It showed on her face in the same way it did on his, or at least that was what Kate always pointed out as she rubbed the crease between his eyebrows,

the one that appeared when he tried to fit scattered pieces together.

Soon they saw a stream of runners passing in steady waves. Volunteers clapped and shouted encouragement. It must have been much easier to run in a supportive country than in one where people did not show emotion, because even expressing good things was seen as childish or inappropriate. Cash did not know whether this was a marathon or a shorter distance race. It was definitely admirable that someone had organized it. It must have required some organizational skills to get thousands of runners to show up running today. Cash had not been kept in that loop, pun intended.

Arabella let go of his hand.

"They run so fast," she said, and took off without warning, legs pumping with great seriousness for a few metres before she stumbled into laughter. Florence followed, copying the runners with exaggerated arm swings.

Cash watched them and smiled. It was great that the girls were able to picture themselves as marathon runners.

It had not always been like that. In 1967, Katherine Switzer entered the Boston Marathon by exploiting a loophole in the rules. There was no explicit ban on women. There was only the assumption that, naturally, only men would enter, since the full distance was believed to be too dangerous for a woman's anatomy. At the time, women were permitted to compete only in races of up to 1.5 kilometres.

Switzer registered using her initials. On race day, she wore a hoodie at first, blending in among the men around her. At some point, the hoodie came off. Journalists began shouting that there was a woman running, demanding to know what she was trying to prove.

A race official named Jock Semple, who had been following the press bus, charged toward her. He tried to force her off the course, grabbing at her race number as if tearing it away would restore order. The legendary photograph from the race showed how Switzer's boyfriend, who had been running nearby, pushed Semple away, as she continued forward.

What happened next was even more amazing. Other runners had closed in around her. Without discussion or instruction, they formed a moving circle, a wall of bodies. They kept running like that until the very end of the race. Moving, literally.

“Did you see me, Daddy?” Florence asked.

“I did,” he said. “Maybe one day you’ll win this race.”

She nodded, believing every word.

Cash wondered how many rules existed only because no one had bothered to test them yet. How many limits were held in place by nothing more than repetition and confidence? The world had not changed because someone waited patiently for permission. It had changed because someone kept moving when others told them to stop.

The history of change was interesting. According to Yuval Noah Harari, that was all history was. But what did history look like in a time loop where nothing would change by tomorrow? Was the end of history already behind them? That sounded depressing for someone who enjoyed studying it.

Small changes mattered. That is why Kate took the girls to stay overnight at her parents’ place. They all needed a break from routine, as the days had started to feel too predictable. The return from Winnipeg had been so effortless that they had promised themselves to keep bringing something new into everyday life. Next weekend would be Kate’s spa day, and Cash reminded her to book it early in a consumer society where money no longer had lasting value.

Cash had the apartment to himself, so out of a rare, nostalgic impulse, he went to buy a selection of beers from a local microbrewery. The fact that they were Vancouver craft beers was reason enough to buy several.

Unlike in his youth, when an empty apartment had meant immediately inviting friends over, he now felt he deserved the space all to himself. Maybe the years had turned him into an introvert.

Cash opened the violin case and lifted the instrument out. He had not touched it in over half a year. Playing came in phases. In his youth, he played every day. Now it happened in bursts, a few intense weeks of practice followed by months of complete neglect.

Cash knew the act of starting again would spark the healthy addiction of playing again. Sometimes it felt good to remind the neighbours of both his and the violin’s existence. He was considerate, though. He never played too early or too late, and he chose pieces people might actually want to hear rather than practicing scales.

He picked up the bow, rested the violin on his left shoulder, and began Pachelbel's *Canon in D*. He did not need the sheet music. It was usually one of the first pieces that beginner orchestras learned. The sixteenth notes were tricky after such a long break and a few stronger beers.

Canon in D was written for a quartet. Three violins played in canon. When the second entered, it repeated what the first had just played, while the first moved on to a new variation that would soon be echoed again. Then the third violin joined, reinforcing what the first two had introduced. Finally, the cellist entered with the bass line, which was then repeated twenty-seven more times without variation. Too bad if you were the cellist, Cash smiled.

The song described the time loop surprisingly accurately because the world played its own canon. One day followed another, each repeating what came before, slightly altered but fundamentally the same. Cash wondered whether Pachelbel could ever have imagined the kind of reality in which his music was played.

Midway through, he heard banging from below, as if someone had hit their ceiling with a broom or a hockey stick. Or perhaps it was the neighbour next door. He could not tell. But anyway, it was extremely annoying. He had only just started, and the time was not even eight yet.

Maybe it was not the volume but the choice of music. *Canon in D,* in the end, was probably the most overplayed piece of classical music. It was the classical equivalent of playing *Stairway to Heaven* in a guitar store. Technically allowed but socially very forbidden.

That reminded him of a more demanding, rock version of *Canon in D*, arranged by a Korean guitarist called JerryC. It was called *Canon Rock* that had become an absolute internet phenomenon in the mid 2000s. Cash stopped playing and took out his phone.

He dropped onto the couch to find the original YouTube video and wanted to find sheet music for that particular piece.

Out of habit, though, he drifted to his social media feeds. It was the kind of reflex he claimed to resist. Cash knew what screens did to the mind. He had explained it to others in neat arguments about attention, dopamine, and the disappearance of silence.

But sometimes people felt a justification to reward them for surviving something that they had orchestrated themselves. A led to B, and they still demanded sympathy. Like a hangover that was self-inflicted but made it perfectly reasonable to sleep in and eat the worst possible food.

His thumb moved in small, automatic arcs. He scanned what the world had produced that day. Some friends had turned into motivational speakers who lifted weights with captions about discipline and destiny. Between them came ads, selfies, sports highlights, more ads, cover songs, athlete interviews, and then, inevitably, more ads.

Then the algorithm showed something older. Someone had shared an old video that featured the old Champions League backdrop. It was Eric Cantona who stood at the microphone. He talked about cells and how science would one day fix ageing. The audience laughed nervously, waiting for Cantona to declare that it was all a joke.

Cash remembered the legendary next lines: Soon we will become eternal. Only accidents, crimes, and wars will kill us.

Was that what they were now? They were archived and preserved like email addresses or social media accounts that outlived the people who had made them.

Cash opened his own profile. He scrolled back to a version of himself that no longer existed. So alive in the flat blue light of the screen. Was that a form of immortality, too?

If science could freeze cells, the internet had already frozen moments. Nobody disappeared anymore. Instead, the algorithm sent birthday reminders even for the dead. They were smart systems with not a drop of common sense. Surely they could have connected the funeral photos on friends' pages, the condolence posts on the deceased's own wall, and the sudden silence that followed. Or maybe they already knew, but asking "Is this person dead?" would have felt too cruel, and the profile helped people remember. An evil social media company could have even asked for money to save it as a memorial page or threatened the page with digital death. Cash did not want to give them any ideas, and he was not completely sure how much they were surveilling him. At least his thoughts were private, he hoped.

Cash thought about Cantona's speech again. As flies to wanton boys, we are for the gods. They kill us for their sport.

It was Shakespeare's *King Lear*. He had presented it in front of an awkwardly large audience in a play that was unfortunately far from boosting the actors' street credibility, but instead made even the popular athletes acting in the play look like lower social hierarchy geeks.

Social media gods did not want to kill people. It was quite the opposite. When their diet was data, they were always hungry for more.

Or who knows, maybe all people had become gods themselves. Not omnipotent or all-knowing, but immortal enough to outlast their own bodies.

The Greek gods were not perfect. They were immortal, but also jealous, petty, and overly dramatic. Not actually too different from what God had been in early Judaism. Why else would God have been so against worshipping other gods, like His ex-wife Asherah, or trying to see if Abraham would kill his son if He told him to? But Greek gods' stories were filled with more scandals, affairs, and whatever fit the eternal soap opera staged on Mount Olympus.

Cash looked at the comments under the video. Thousands of strangers are arguing about what Cantona meant. They called him an absolute genius. They wrote he was mental. Turning a three-minute speech into tribal warfare. That was Mount Olympus with WiFi.

The old clip ended the way it always did. Cantona smiled slightly, as if he had set a small fire and was satisfied to watch it burn.

I love football. Thank you.

Cash felt very mortal. His heart beat, and his breath moved. Who knows, what if the gods were not those who lived forever but those who were able to disappear?

At some point, he stumbled upon a live broadcast interviewing Dr. Rohan Mehta, who seemed to be a theoretical physicist at Harvard University.

Cash lost track of time listening to Mehta's calm voice.

"These requests come in constantly," Mehta said, looking straight into the camera and fully breaking the fourth wall. "I give interviews every day. Or, well, every today."

The audience laughed.

"People want a scientific explanation. Some want to believe this is all a dream. Others think something divine is behind it. What about you? Is there a rational explanation?" the interviewer asked.

Mehta's smile remained.

"There is always an answer. The real question is whether we are ready to hear it."

“What is your best guess right now?”

“I hypothesize that we are inside some kind of spacetime rupture that creates a local causal loop. Or then some other theory is true. It may also be that we are just fooling ourselves that we can ever find certainty in this. Physics can offer a theory, but it is up to everyone individually to decide whether they believe in equations, even when the calculations are mathematically correct.”

Cash began recording a voice memo.

“If time doesn’t move forward, what am I even? If I never age, if nothing changes, am I still real or something else?”

He started a new recording, fully aware it would not exist on his phone in the morning. Instead of disappearing into digital space, it would vanish into something even more empty.

“I used to believe in progress. I studied politics because I believed in the movement. I believed that societies would develop, people would grow, but if time doesn’t move forward, does the progress stop, too?”

His slightly drunken mind awakened what Buddhists call the monkey mind, the restless inner voice jumping from one thought to another. It had always been there, but now, inside the loop, he could see the monkey within himself.

He started another recording:

“The universe before its birth was supercooled. Like how for every conscious thought we have, there are a hundred thousand unconscious ones. The universe was all those ninety-nine thousand nine hundred and ninety-nine could-have-beens. Then something changed them into would-be. Programmers would call the change a glitch, religious people God, Langley a phase transition. I call it the moment reality decided to be something other than what it had been.

And the more you think about it, the less it feels like a single moment. What if existence itself is a series of phase transitions? Not one grand story, but a constant slide from one state to another, like how ice turns into water, and water into steam.

Fourteen billion years sounds like a large number when you say it like this, but next to eternity, well then, it’s just a blink. The kind of moment when your eyes close and open again. And if eternity has trillions upon trillions of years, why would the universe settle for only one great

change? Why would it stop there? Why would it not transform again and again? What if we're in the middle of some big transition and don't even notice it because we're like ice that doesn't know it's melting."

Cash realized how drunken recordings were no longer as funny or respectable as they had been twenty years earlier. Back in his student days, voice messages sent by friends on their way home had been the best entertainment. But now Cash had perhaps become serious. He deleted every recording, even though he knew perfectly well they would soon disappear anyway.

Dreams. Florence had earlier asked how they knew this was not a dream. He had answered quickly, even though the question was excellent.

Dreams did not vanish when waking up. They lingered, like a scent. In some dreams, you could pinch yourself and still believe you were awake. Pain, then, was not solid proof that you were not dreaming. So why did we feel so certain that we were not dreaming right now, when in dreams we invented the rules and the plot ourselves?

If the human brain could be fooled into experiencing a rubber hand as part of the body instead of one's own arm, what else was the brain capable of misleading us about? Perhaps this was all just a sleep paralysis.

Chapter 1.11

If the loop was a controlled phenomenon, there had to be some kind of agent behind it. But who would benefit from a time loop becoming reality? Or had someone just been too curious to see what would happen?

Kind of like how many Albertans had voted yes for their independence from Canada, the tyranny of Ottawa, as Cash had heard them say. Or the Brexit vote in the United Kingdom, where the urge to witness the consequences outweighed rationality.

The dating app Tinder was a good metaphor. Cash had watched solid relationships break just because one partner had gotten the fear of missing out on possibilities while simultaneously being happy with their current relationship. It was weird.

Who knows, maybe politics worked the same way. Referendums and protest votes were not always born from suffering but from boredom. Kind of like how the best poker players were not the ones bluffing aggressively every hand, or chess players rushing to trade pieces to escape the tension of the mid-game. People wanted action. There was a misbelief that if nothing dramatic was happening, nothing meaningful was either. An entire generation had trained itself to crave fast cuts, cliffhangers, and the ability to skip forward ten seconds at a time. Societies might have been healthier if they had learned to enjoy shows about nothing, like Seinfeld, that deliberately celebrated the ordinary. What was the deal with simulation theorists, anyway?

It was ironic that the simulation theorists whom Cash had dismissed as delusional basement prophets now sounded as one of the most sober groups.

Cash stopped his bike in front of a church. He had not planned to go inside, but something about the building pulled him in. He was not a religious person. Faith had slowly eroded from him over the years, like old paint peeling off a wall. Still, something had brought him here.

Inside the church, he felt like someone who had shown up to the wrong event but was too embarrassed to immediately leave. Yes, it had happened, too.

Cash wondered whether people needed faith during the loop more than before because the reality without a story would have felt even more unstable. They needed to believe that everything

would ultimately unfold like a Disney movie, starting with tragedy but ending in “and they lived their lives happily ever after.”

At the altar stood a priest.

“Our faith is being tested. We are being measured by God, who has stopped time so that we can find Him again.”

There was certainty in the man’s voice. It carried conviction that did not feel rehearsed or tied to a professional script, more like something lived in rather than merely spoken.

Cash noticed a tattoo peeking out from beneath the priest’s clerical clothing that made him doubt the man held strictly fundamentalist views, since a literal reading of scripture would rule tattoos out entirely. He felt a sudden desire to accept a complete, ready-made answer. No one could prove that the loop was not an act of God. Why could it not be? Our species had caused countless extinctions, poisoned the oceans, and accelerated climate change. God might have pressed the emergency stop button on the remote control. Or perhaps He had traveled through parallel realities and decided to abandon this version of us, like a successful serial entrepreneur who decided to move on. Or would there have been parallel Gods too? That was a question that would have made his head hurt if he had given it any more attention.

“The Kingdom of God is near,” the priest continued. “But those who have not used this time wisely, who have not repented and turned toward Him, will not be saved.”

There it was, the promise of salvation, marketed with fear as its fuel.

Cash had seen how crises sharpened belief. That did not invalidate religion. No, no, Christianity, like many other religions, had done a lot of good in the world. It had shaped art, ethics, hospitals, and revolutionized what we thought about compassion. Would we ever have cared about what happened on the other side of the world if not for the ethical frameworks that people carried, even if they were nonreligious?

Jesus began as an advocate of peaceful resistance. That was not how he sounded from the mouths of certain fundamentalists, who used him to stand against gays, trans athletes, and immigrants. The man who spoke of loving one’s neighbour had somehow become a mascot for exclusion.

Like the majority in Canada, Cash had been raised in a Christian home. But somewhere along the way, he began to wonder whose dogma he had actually been taught. Was it the religion of Jesus

or the religion of Paul? Was it the wandering radical who preached love and mercy, or the theologian who built a system around his death without ever meeting him during his life? To be fair, no line of scripture was written by an eyewitness in the modern sense. Cash did not think that made the holy book any less meaningful. It was just sometimes interesting how those who believed the most had no idea how the Bible was actually constructed. Memories in the ancient world were more trained, and there were professions devoted to preserving words until they could be written down, but it did not change the fact that at least forty years had passed between the death of Jesus and the writing of the oldest gospel.

The priest reached for a small, white wafer and held it between his fingers.

"This is my body," he said.

Cash thought it should have been, This is the body of Jesus Christ. Quoting Jesus directly sounded confusing because it was certainly not the priest's body.

He knew not all Christians understood the words the same way. In some churches, it was purely symbolic. The bread had not literally transformed. Yet others believed the transformation had happened. It fascinated him how a single object and a single sentence could create such different realities.

Next, the priest lifted the cup.

"This is my blood," he said.

No, it's the blood of Jesus, Cash thought, realizing he was mentally mansplaining liturgy. The priest surely knew the right words.

He respected the fact that the transformation was not required to demonstrate with gimmicks. The wine still tasted like wine, even for those who believed it had become blood. It tasted like wine you could buy at a liquor store, no magic required.

Cash had always admired great magicians, except Uri Geller and other psychic charlatans who claimed to contact the dead without ever admitting they were performing tricks.

But if Cash was completely honest, a part of him longed for something that could not be explained by logic. Something that would survive scientific scrutiny and would have earned James Randi's unclaimed million-dollar prize by proving itself as real magic under controlled conditions.

Perhaps that was why he might have called himself at least somewhat spiritual, rather than a stone-cold materialist, even if others would have boxed him as such on paper. Most people imagined crystals, energy healing, or occult rituals when they heard the word spiritual. For him, it meant something else entirely. It was noticing coincidences that lined up a little too neatly. Moments so pivotal that his life would have looked entirely different without them. Some called it God's subtle guidance, while others described it as pure random luck.

Cash had learned to trust serendipity. Perhaps it was just human psychology at work. When someone chose to be open to the world and others, people noticed it, and perhaps were unintentionally rewarded for it. If they smiled at a cashier, they likely got a warmer response and a better customer experience than if they appeared annoyed and closed off.

Cash had always been open to the world, and he wanted to throw that door wide, to see and understand everything it had to offer. He remembered how, as a child, he had wished to uncover something groundbreaking. He had never thought about it before, but that must have been why he wanted to become a journalist. That little boy still lived in him. That little boy, who had downloaded illegal torrent files labelled top secret in the hope of finding something. Cash smiled at the memory.

What had he expected? Government conspiracies? Alien autopsies? In retrospect, if he had stumbled across something genuinely explosive, something like the Epstein files, he would not have known what to do. The top secret label existed for a reason. As a boy, he had seen enough films to imagine the consequences. He would have known that their family computer's IP address had likely already been traced, and it was only a matter of time before the door was kicked in.

Now, as a journalist, Cash thought about the hypothetical scenario again. If that little boy believed he could not safely hold dangerous information, would he have scattered it across every medium before the hitman arrived, or simply just closed the file, deleted it, and acted as if nothing had ever happened? He was relieved that what he had encountered over the years had been the usual conspiracy videos with enough truth to seduce and enough error to be dismissed as nonsense. The plural of anecdote had never been data, no matter how loudly or how long it was repeated.

As Cash saw it, many turned to religion because eternity sounded far more comforting than being a single data point in history. He had heard plenty of people state how bleak it was to think that a human life was just one life, and he understood why. In the scale of eternity, a human life was not even a drop in the ocean. Not even an atom. Perhaps a quark at most.

But to Cash, meaning without a heavenly warranty felt even more urgent and important. If this really was his only life in existence, he needed to treat it with the once-in-a-lifetime respect it deserved. There was something almost unbearably beautiful in its uniqueness. The loop had complicated that, of course. It had completely redefined the word temporary.

That was how Cash's mind moved. At times, he resembled a caricature of a philosopher, the sort who might debate whether a chair qualified as furniture. But Cash just refused to believe the skin of the orange was the whole fruit and preferred to peel it and eat it piece by piece.

That reminded him of the time Kate had told him it was a privilege to have space for such big but unimportant questions.

They had been walking as a family when he wondered aloud whether a pineapple was technically a fruit or a berry. Florence's eyes had widened when he explained that botanical categories did not always align with grocery store labels. It had delighted Florence, but Kate had not been as amused.

"Do you realize you get to think about things like that?" she had asked later, not angrily, but with surgical calm. "About pineapples."

Her mind was crowded with contingencies. Fire season. School policies. Air quality indexes. Microplastics. Society had quietly assigned this vigilance to women, while men were praised as profound and analytical.

Cash had noticed how quickly Florence's curiousity ignited. He admired it and hoped society's expectations would never smother it.

A less perceptive husband might have pointed out that in a world trapped in a time loop, the cure for forest fire season had already been found, since it had never even begun. How much worse would it have been if time had frozen in the height of summer, when the air felt like the inside of a barbecue? But Cash said nothing. He was a work in progress who had learned to know better.

His bike was still leaning against the rack where he had left it outside the church. As he

straightened from opening the lock, someone approached the entrance from the opposite direction.

Cash thought he recognized the man, or at least that he should have. Sometimes recognition arrived before the face did. It was like remembering a melody without a single lyric, a title, or even the artist.

They made eye contact at the exact distance people always did when deciding whether to acknowledge each other.

“Hey,” Cash said. “How is it going?”

The man’s expression carried the same mild confusion. It was a shared awareness of knowing from somewhere, but not remembering the context.

“Good. Really good. Kids are alright. Just going to meet the Maker,” he said, followed by an awkward laugh. “You?”

Cash hesitated but then lied, kind of.

“Just did that too,” he replied. “And my daughters are great. I’m heading to pick them up from school.”

“Sounds good, man. That’s a nice bike. See you.”

“See you.”

They kept the exchange strategically vague with no specifics that would require memorization. As the man disappeared through the doors, Cash felt amused about how often he had these interactions that were mostly performative. They were changed just in case, like a mutual insurance policy against awkwardness.

Over the course of a life, how many people did one briefly intersect with? There were school years, hobbies, colleagues, other parents at birthday parties, and neighbours who moved away without goodbye. He must have spoken to at least a hundred thousand people by now. Probably more. It was not as though you added each one to social media after a passing introduction. Most of them dissolved into anonymity.

He mounted the bike by swinging his right leg over and pushing off with his left. As the wheel rotated, Cash heard the bike’s faint metallic complaint when the chain caught its teeth. It

reminded him that he had not applied dry lube that morning. He should have treated it like brushing his teeth, like a daily habit.

Some biked to work, and some did not. It was not a habit one drifted into after months of neglect. No one declared, casually, that today they would reinvent themselves as cyclists. It was a commuter category. There were walkers who lived close but still arrived late to work, drivers who forgot to pay for parking almost every day, public transit regulars who kept everyone updated on fare increases, and then there were the bikers, with their weird sense of superiority just because they had exercised before work. For some reason, Cash felt pride in being part of the last group. He fit the stereotype.

This all made him wonder how often people's actions felt scripted. Perhaps it was the brain's way of compressing complexity into patterns. But if this whole reality had become a movie, and everyone was reduced to character profiles, who would he be?

He imagined reading his own description in a production bible. Reading about his flaws and quirks would have probably insulted him, especially if it had come with a true ringtone. The thought stayed with him as he reached the school and locked his bike to the same fence post he always used.

Cash was someone who distrusted easy answers but kept searching for them. Someone who questioned systems without ever fully stepping outside them. Someone who believed meaning was constructed, not discovered, and yet still caught himself waiting for it to arrive intact.

It would take a remarkable actor to play him if his life were a movie. Rami Malek, Oscar Wilde, or Benedict Cumberbatch, perhaps.

Sometimes, simulation theory did not feel entirely lunatic. It explained the question of free will, something neuroscientists and physicists claimed we did not even have, since our bodies were proven to act before our minds had made conscious decisions. It was possible that this world was like a SIMS computer game from his childhood, and the real world somewhere was the original that this was a replica of. That kind of possibility threatened the self-esteem of all reality and every one and zero within it.

But it was weird how sometimes thoughts and ideas came almost too easily. When he really got into the flow while writing, he might see his fingers typing and text appearing before his

conscious mind had even decided what to write.

The key was that it did not really matter if it was all a simulation, just as it was better to believe that everyone had free will. Even if they were characters, running unconsciously through loops with implanted memories, like Arnold Schwarzenegger's character in The Last Action Hero, the setting itself changed very little.

People already lived like this. No one knew what came before the Big Bang, and yet they were able to live and find meaning in their lives. Choices carried weight.

If the framework of existence was somehow simulated or predetermined, it did not erase the experience of deciding.

Maybe free will was not about independence from causality, but about ownership within it. The ability to recognize a thought, hesitate, and still stand behind what followed.

That was why it mattered to believe in free will and believe that we did not live in a simulation. Even simulated characters had to feel accountable for the role they played. Whether in base reality or a replica, he still had to write himself into the story. Jin Carrey's Truman had not escaped by proving the world was fake. He had escaped by acting as if his choices mattered before he knew the truth.

He adjusted the strap of his backpack over his shoulder and stepped toward the school entrance. A sense of agency might not mean rewriting the whole plot, but simply delaying the moment he became predictable. He was not sure he had succeeded in that at all today.

Chapter 1.12

Florence and Arabella stayed overnight at Kate's parents' place, and Cash went with Kate to Kitsilano for a party at her friend's home. They celebrated, jokingly or seriously, the fourth month of the loop.

Normally, Cash enjoyed these gatherings. Kate's friends were warm-hearted and easy to be around. But today, something felt off.

Not the party itself, but how everyone related to things far too normally.

The living room buzzed with conversation, glasses clinked, and the food was beautifully laid out. There was an abundance of it, even though everyone knew that nothing could be saved as leftovers for tomorrow, because quite literally, the food would not exist anymore then. That was probably why there was so much of it. It was no wonder that excess had become the norm because you did not have to feel bad about it going to waste. Also, no one wanted to be known as the host whose party ran out of food.

Cash drifted toward the kitchen where the music was slightly louder and the conversations slightly looser. A man stood near the counter holding a glass of red wine, speaking with Kate and one of her friends.

Cash recognized him immediately. The face had appeared in many music magazines. He was the guitarist of an indie rock band that Cash had listened to years ago.

Kate's friend introduced them. "This is Daniel. He just moved here."

Cash nodded. "I think I recognize you. You play the guitar in Northern Haze, right?"

Daniel's face brightened slightly. "That I have done."

"Great band," Cash said.

Daniel gave a polite smile but quickly turned back toward Kate, as if the compliment had already served its purpose.

A Sarah McLachlan song was playing softly through the speakers.

Daniel tilted his head toward the speaker. "Oh wow. I like this song."

"Me too. That whole album is amazing." Kate said with excitement.

"I don't think I know this one," Cash said. "The only song I know is Angel."

Daniel looked at him with exaggerated surprise.

“What? You don’t know Adia?” he said. “Seriously?”

Daniel shook his head like Cash had said something completely terrible.

“Man, what kind of barrel did you grow up in if you don’t know this song?”

Kate gave a small, uncomfortable laugh.

Cash could not tell if Daniel was joking. Part of him assumed he must be. Sarah McLachlan was the kind of music people their parents had listened to. But Cash, Kate, and Daniel were all in their thirties. Daniel did not sound entirely playful either. It felt more like he was in it to bully or start a fight.

Cash felt a brief temptation to argue, since there were probably hundreds of things Daniel did not know either. Entire worlds of music, literature, and history that meant nothing to him. But Cash did not feel like turning a kitchen conversation into a debate about cultural literacy.

Instead, he nodded lightly.

“Maybe I did grow up in a barrel,” he said.

The comment seemed to satisfy Daniel. The conversation moved on.

Cash did not mention that he played music too. He had learned early that revealing things about himself rarely improved situations like this. Daniel had placed himself on an invisible pedestal the moment Cash recognized him. Daniel had no idea who Cash was. It probably would not have changed anything anyway. Perhaps the whole interaction was a performance for some other purpose.

Daniel was short and thin, while Cash stood at least a head taller. Perhaps Daniel felt the need to shrink him a little in front of Kate.

It did not take a rocket scientist to guess that Cash and Kate were married, yet Daniel still leaned slightly toward her while speaking, as if he did not quite believe they were actually together. The way he carried himself suggested he saw their relationship as something temporary or negotiable.

What an asshole, Cash thought, and made a promise to himself that he would never listen to Northern Haze again. Which was a shame, as they had annoyingly good songs.

Cash leaned against the counter and listened to the music drifting through the room. It struck him how easily people turned their own knowledge into a measure of everyone else’s worth.

He had done the same thing himself many times. When someone did not know who Fidel Castro was, Led Zeppelin, or what a Pulitzer Prize meant. It was easy to step on Daniel's famous pedestal.

But who decided what an adult was supposed to know?

Cash remembered writing down a line from one of Gabor Maté's books months earlier. About normality being a myth.

People still behaved as if there was a shared checklist somewhere. Songs everyone should know. Books everyone should have read. Opinions everyone should hold by a certain age.

Fail the list and you were somehow unfinished as a person.

It was the same with taste. People assumed they knew what good food tasted like because they were used to their own palate. Someone raised on simple home cooking might say Indian food was terrible because everything tasted overcooked and full of spices. Someone else might declare Indian cuisine the best in the world but then sit helplessly in front of a plate from another culinary tradition, unsure what to make of it.

Music worked the same way. Most people believed they listened to good music. What they really meant was that they listened to music that sounded familiar.

Professional competence was one thing. A surgeon needed to understand anatomy. A pilot needed to understand aerodynamics.

But cultural knowledge was something else entirely. Everyone carried a different map of the world in their head. Different landmarks, different reference points.

And yet people defended their own maps as if they were the only correct version of the terrain.

Across the room, someone laughed loudly, and glasses clinked together. The party carried on as if nothing unusual had ever happened to the world at all.

For a moment, Cash wondered if that was the real function of nights like this. Everyone performing normal life so convincingly that even they could start to believe it still existed.

Next Cash found himself in the middle of a conversation where people laughed about some workplace drama. He had heard the same story at least twice before. Kate's circle of friends surely had many more times, but no one pointed it out. Stories were not told because they were new, but because people treated them like songs, and hit songs could be played on the radio

again and again. People also rewatched the same stand up shows, even though they already knew the jokes and the rhythm.

Cash was different. He did not like telling the same stories if he knew someone in the room had already heard them. He avoided watching movies a second time unless they were exceptional and years had passed since the last viewing. He was drawn to first-time experiences, which did not fit this new reality at all.

Kate's friend Samantha glanced at the television and sighed with relief.

"It's unbelievable how I don't even notice a difference when I watch TV."

Kate nodded with a smile. "Exactly. New shows keep coming out."

People around them nodded happily. Cash looked at the screen. A reality TV show about a celebrity family in Los Angeles was playing. What was strange was that each episode was filmed in the morning, edited, and released the same day. Kate had started watching it daily, and a few times Cash had noticed Kate taking her laptop even into the bathroom, the sound of the show audible through the door.

Watching it now at the party, Cash had to admit how impressive the production was. How on earth had they managed to adapt to the limits of time and still produce something this professional, practically every day in just a few hours? Cash did not know how long producing the show had taken before the loop, but he assumed episodes must have taken at least weeks to plan, film, and edit.

Everything had to be scripted to some degree. Improvisation would have created its own chain of bottlenecks, so every scene and edit had to be planned in the previous episode or episodes. That way, the actors and editors knew exactly what to do as soon as the morning began. There was probably no shortage of skilled writers now that the loop had completely silenced Hollywood's film industry. It would not have been surprising if well-known screenwriters and novelists were now competing to write plot twists for reality TV.

Samantha was right. TV felt just as seamless as before. It created a false sense of continuity. The illusion of a series moving forward was perfect, even though reruns of previous episodes were never shown.

The conversation drifted back to lighter topics, and Cash took another sip of his beer. The fact that he was so impressed by the TV show made him uneasy. Had he started giving in, too?

No, Cash thought, as he said aloud, “Florence said something this morning. Her classmate Brian has been sick for four months.”

The words left his mouth before he could stop them. They immediately hung in the air, changing the mood of the party. No one dared to keep laughing or switch the subject, out of respect for a child who had been ill for so long.

Kate felt obligated to break the awkward silence. “But he has still been able to participate in school.”

Cash nodded. “Yes, but only through an iPad. The teacher streams the lessons to him. There is a stand in his place with Brian on live video.”

The silence stretched again. It was easy to forget the loop when you could pretend time was moving forward. But not everyone had that option. Some were frozen in place more than others.

Kate’s friends expressed sympathy.

“That’s awful.”

“I cannot even imagine.”

But no one wanted to be the first to lighten the mood. Except, once again, Kate.

“What is actually quite amazing,” she said carefully, “is that despite everything, he can still be part of the class. That he has not been left out.”

The atmosphere softened instantly.

“That really is amazing.”

“Teachers are heroes. Our Jack was part of so many group projects when hybrid teaching was organised during the pandemic.”

It was not toxic positivity, but social intelligence. In Cash’s view, it was a skill women often mastered better than men, for better and for worse. Cash knew that the same intelligence could also be used for harm, for far more creative and manipulative bullying. Fortunately, Florence and Arabella were not yet at an age where many conversations about that were needed.

Cash let the partygoers continue their hypocritical celebration of carefreeness about something that was anything but a celebration. It was more like a funeral for the fourth month. A toast to all the fourth-month tomorrows that never came.

After the party, when Kate had fallen asleep, Cash quietly walked into his home office. It felt almost rebellious, like staying out too late at a military base when you were supposed to be back in the barracks. Cash himself did not have many such experiences, but his friends' escape stories had become legendary.

His thoughts kept returning to the party, to Brian's empty place in Florence's classroom, and to the look Kate had given him when he had deflated the mood with his words. Strangely, Kate had not brought it up yet.

There had been tension between them for some time about how much time he spent researching the loop. Kate had sharply observed that Cash had taken on Kate's obsession, and she had hinted that some things simply had to be accepted. But nights offered too tempting an opportunity to study the phenomenon in peace, to stay up late, and still wake up refreshed in the morning, as always.

Suddenly, he heard footsteps before he saw Kate standing in the doorway. She stood with her arms crossed, her face showing a fatigue that did not come from being woken from sleep.

"You're playing detective again."

Cash knew logic was not the right response now. Kate did not care that he woke up refreshed. She cared that she had woken up alone.

"You think this is something that needs to be solved. But what if this is just our life now?" She sighed and shook her head. "You can keep searching for the truth, Cash. But I have to raise two children in the middle of all this. Think about what really matters."

Then she turned and disappeared into the dark.

Cash stared at his notes and wondered whether he had been desperately trying to understand something that was never meant to be understood. He thought of the Buddhist teaching of the two arrows. The first was pain. The second was the one a person fired into themselves, the suffering caused by resisting the first pain.

The loop was the first arrow. But was his obsessive investigation the second?

Chapter 1.13

Bob leaned back in his chair and balanced on its two legs. He told a story about a taxi ride he had taken, something about the driver not understanding directions or English, and how they were probably deliberately trying to scam customers.

Cash did not believe it. What was even the point of scams when there was no long-lasting financial benefit? Well, perhaps even before the loop, the motive was not always money but the thrill of it.

Anyway, Cash did not appreciate Bob's tone, and he was lucky no one from HR was present in the staff room.

Lucy sat next to Cash and did not even look up from her screen. If Bob was testing their boundaries, Lucy refused to participate in the test. Silence gave consent too, Kate had often mentioned.

Bob explained how these taxi drivers did not have the nose to choose decent fragrances. Or perhaps some scents just smelled different on different ethnicities, as they were designed for European skin, Bob thought out loud.

That already sounded very racist. And what was European skin in the end? Did he mean Caucasian? All people shared 99.9% of the same DNA. Less than a hundredth of a percent of our DNA decided skin colour, eye colour, and hair texture, and affected how people lived their entire lives. Hate and discrimination for what? Just a different pigment. It made no sense.

To be honest, Cash did not even like to use the term Caucasian. North America was obsessed with the term race. Europe had gone through that a hundred years ago and had gone further with pseudoscientific classifications, but had then moved on. Social scientists in North America explained that it was important to keep using the term because people believed different races still existed, despite there being only one human race.

But when had that ever worked like that? Had people ever made things better by reinforcing beliefs just because people already believed them? It was as if schools started teaching flat-Earth geography because some not-so-informed people believed the Earth was flat. That was what it sounded like, a risky compromise.

Of course, there were differences between ethnic groups, and in some contexts, such as medicine, it mattered to be aware of them because certain conditions appeared more frequently in some populations than others.

In some animals, populations split, adapted, and became visibly and genetically distinct over time. Humans never followed that path. Our differences formed gradients, not separate branches. The problem began when people treated those gradual differences as if they defined separate kinds of humans.

Human variation did not fall into neat categories. It overlapped and resisted clear lines. The idea that it could be cleanly divided into distinct races said more about the need to classify than about reality itself.

“Some people just don’t get how things work here. And I think Canada should,” Bob said, smiling.

“I got it, Bob. Thanks,” Cash said.

Bob looked at Cash, likely thinking about how sensitive people with liberal views were.

Cash looked at Lucy. Still nothing. She kept typing without any reaction to what was happening around her. It did not mean she agreed, but like most people at work, she also was not the one to have an open confrontation. It was better to remain civil. Everybody within the team already knew what Bob thought, and Bob knew how everybody else thought.

Some people thought they could say anything, as long as they wrapped it in humour. Perhaps Bob was testing the limits of what was acceptable. Any emotional response could be dismissed as oversensitivity and proof that liberals again let feelings get in the way, while those at the centre claimed to see things clearly. Cash thought of himself as part of the centre and doubted Bob would have shared the same locker room. Wearing the jersey did not mean he played for the team.

Later, when the conversation drifted to evening plans, Cash mentioned that he was going to be at home with the children, as Kate had plans.

Bob let out a short laugh.

“Ah, playing babysitter?”

Cash did not respond right away. Lucy looked up at Cash. It carried a nonverbal hang in there, buddy.

“They’re my kids too,” Cash responded with no emotion.

“Yeah, yeah,” Bob waved his hand. “You know what I mean.”

It was not the first time Cash had heard this, but it was the first time at CBC, which typically attracted more progressive talent.

There was an idea that being a dad who practised being a dad was somehow optional. The idea that a man’s life continued unchanged, and children were just something that happened around him, but not to him.

Fatherhood where the dad was involved in his children’s daily lives was treated as a modern invention rather than a basic expectation. Even though in reality, decades earlier, John Irving had already written widely read novels in which fathers showed up for their children.

As traditional gender roles shifted toward equality, the internet manosphere wanted to return to the past. The alpha male did not take parental leave or do stroller walks. Maybe Bob liked that development.

Ninety-nine point nine percent the same, but that point one seemed very big between Cash and Bob when it came to ideas.

When Bob left for the staff room to get a coffee, Lucy closed her laptop.

“Do you always let him talk like that?” she asked.

Cash frowned. “Do you always pretend not to hear it?”

Lucy met his look. “I hear it. I just don’t think he’s the conversation worth having. You’re good at keeping things going. Sometimes that helps, but sometimes you shouldn’t do that.”

She packed her things.

“We should get out of here. Change of scenery.”

“For the article?”

Lucy nodded. “I think better when I write in different places. It forces you to see things from more than one angle.” She glanced around the office. “This place only gives you one.”

They left the office. Rain had paused, and based on lived experience, Cash knew the asphalt would soon get another 30-minute-long drink. For a moment, he thought about how strange it

was to imagine the streets as thirsty, and how lucky he was that no one could see inside his head. Who thought of asphalt as something alive? Then again, the public garbage bin standing next to him would never have been on the streets of Tokyo, where people believed spirits lived in them. Despite that, he had heard Japan's streets were almost impossibly clean. That was admirable, he thought, and noticed more and more trash left on his own city's sidewalks. It had gotten worse during the time loop, as if people believed it did not matter because the Universe would clean up after them soon enough.

Honda Civic parked at the curb. At least all the cars in Vancouver looked clean, rinsed by nature's own car wash. The taxi smelled faintly of old cigarette smoke. The driver introduced himself as Amir and almost immediately asked if they knew where Iran was on the map.

Cash and Lucy both said they did know, and that it would have been bad not to in their profession as journalists.

"You should write an article about me," Amir said, smiling.

He explained that many people in North America knew very little about Iran beyond what they saw in the news. Amir said he had lived in Canada for ten years and all three of his children had been born here during that time. Cash did a quick mental count that Amir must have become a father later in life. It was easy math.

Cash asked whether he spoke Farsi with his kids. Amir nodded and said he spoke Persian, although they usually replied in English. Still, he sometimes overheard them speaking Persian to each other, and they spoke it well. It made him proud. Cash was not entirely sure what the difference between Farsi and Persian was, but assumed they were essentially the same.

Cash asked when he had last visited Iran. Amir said it had been over ten years, and added that most Iranians did not support the totalitarian government. He was one of them. He explained that the media focused too much on religious leaders and failed to show the real lives and opinions of ordinary people.

"You journalists have responsibility in that," Amir said.

Lucy spoke for the first time, saying she remembered seeing videos of large protests following the death of a young woman who had not been wearing a hijab.

"Yes, Mahsa Amini, bless her soul," Amir said.

He spoke about the bravery of young people, unafraid and determined to push for a different future. Older generations, he explained, had seen what the government could do to those who opposed it, and were more cautious. The younger generation was different. They spoke English, were highly educated, and consumed Western media. He believed the future of Iran would change because of them.

In the late seventies, he said, Iran had been among the most developed and liberal countries in the region, but everything changed when religion took over after the revolution.

“Religion is never good when in power,” he added, before noting that young people today were more informed, with access to social media and the internet. They understood that country borders were man-made constructs.

“A good example is Africa,” Cash said, “with straight lines drawn across the continent.”

Amir laughed. “Exactly. There is nothing like that in the Middle East.”

As the conversation continued, Amir described how the revolution had unfolded. The United States had played a role, he said, refusing to accept a democratically elected left-wing government and instead supporting the Shah’s return to power. He also shared that he had fought in the war with Iraq during the seventies and eighties.

Cash asked what ideology they had been fighting for. Amir compared it to the differences between Catholics and Orthodox Christians.

“So, Shia and Sunni Muslims,” Cash clarified.

“Yes. And I’m telling you, those who meditate cannot kill another person,” Amir said.

He spoke about being present, about focusing entirely on the moment. When he talked to someone, he said, he gave them his full attention. Cash hoped that it also included the road.

Amir brought up Persian poet Rumi and quoted, “The distance between you and God is the name of God.” He found it amusing that Western leaders now quoted Rumi on social media, while people travelled to India in search of peace.

Amir said he hoped that future generations would be wiser, leading to a world without war.

Cash mentioned climate change and wondered if it could become a common enemy that might unite countries.

Amir said it could, but quickly pointed out that the Earth had existed for fourteen billion years, and that temperature cycles were normal, not to humans, but to the planet.

“We are small in history,” he said.

Cash chose not to remind how the current changes were happening much faster than the natural cycle. Finding common ground with strangers felt more valuable than debating them.

“And I can teach you this,” Amir said, “and you might be thinking, ‘What is this old man talking about?’ But after working in many high-paying jobs, I can promise you that money cannot buy happiness.” He shifted the conversation to a more common philosophical track.

Cash mentioned a quote by Yuval Noah Harari, about how humans would not even want to remain permanently happy, because we would have gone extinct as starving but content individuals.

Amir’s eyes lit up. “Yes, Harari is very good, but my favourite is James Allen. Do you know him? I read him years ago, and he changed how I see everything. It’s all about controlling your thoughts and what you let grow in your mind.”

“I don’t think I know him,” Cash said. “But it sounds kind of like that quote: be careful what you think, you might listen.”

“Exactly like that. Promise me you’ll read James Allen,” Amir replied.

He went on to describe personal experiences with manifestation, insisting he had no reason to lie. These were simply things that had happened to him, including during the war.

They had sometimes traded items like cigarettes and lighters with their enemies. As Amir spoke, Cash wondered what that really meant. Did they trade with living enemies, or did the trading mean something else entirely? He could not imagine how such exchanges could happen without violence.

Perhaps it was something like the story from the First World War, when soldiers had stopped fighting on Christmas Day in 1914 and instead sang carols and played sports together. Cash hoped it was like that.

Amir recalled once receiving a lighter from an Iraqi soldier, a small Canadian flag printed on it. The other soldiers had joked, chanting, “You’re going to Canada, you’re going to Canada.”

“And I yelled, ‘Oh yes, I’m going to Canada,’” Amir said, smiling. “But I never really thought I would.”

Now, here he was, driving them through Vancouver toward Liberty Cafe.

Cash thanked the driver and reached forward to shake his hand.

Outside the car, Cash reached out to his phone and the ride application lit up. It asked him to leave a tip.

The question felt misplaced, almost intrusive. What had passed between them did not feel like a service to be priced. Reducing it to a few extra dollars seemed to flatten it. It could not be measured that way.

Cash was certain Amir had not shared his story in the hope of earning a little extra. Some experiences resisted conversion, and trying to assign them a value only made them feel smaller. Still, Amir would probably not have understood the lack of a tip as a compliment, but quite the opposite, no matter how much they had understood each other. So he pressed 20%.

Cash and Lucy found a table near the window. For a moment, neither of them said anything. They heard the low hum of conversation and the scratching of chalk against walls.

Cash glanced around the space. It was the kind of place that would have annoyed Bob. That alone made it feel like the right choice.

They had already reached out to politicians and economists about the Liberal Party’s new proposal, a temporary fifty-dollar basic income for every citizen and permanent resident.

In Parliament, the proposal had predictably sparked a shouting match that felt like a copy of the British House of Commons, just without the speaker’s wooden gavel. Conservatives argued that it would destroy the work ethic. Liberals defended it as a tool for social stability and crime prevention. According to them, it was not about rewarding unwillingness to work, but about providing basic security in a situation where markets no longer worked as they once had.

Cash thought about Amir and how easily he had spoken about systems, belief, and change, without turning it into a fight.

Lucy finally broke the silence.

“We could start with how people have stopped caring about money.”

Her tone was measured, but softer than it had been in the office. Less guarded.

Cash nodded. “Or how they’ve stopped trusting it.”

Lucy glanced at him, as if acknowledging the adjustment.

The café had been among the first to adapt to the new reality defined by the loop. The owner had understood that, since profits reset at the end of every day, economic sense now lay in building loyalty rather than chasing short-term gains.

The walls were covered in paper where customers could draw and write using coloured chalk left on every table. Instead of paying with money, people contributed to what the owner called the guestbook.

Cash picked up a piece of red chalk and, almost absentmindedly, began sketching Lucy’s face.

Lucy noticed it, rolled her eyes, and smiled.

“Before the loop,” she said, “the economy ran on trust, debt, and speculation built on the future. Banks existed because people believed in tomorrow.”

“And now there is no tomorrow,” Cash said.

At the start of the loop, people had hoarded cash, precious metals, and, of course, toilet paper. Some maxed out their credit cards, others traded services for food. Black markets were no longer hidden. They had become the new normal.

“A good haircut now costs a bottle of whisky,” Cash said. “Or a music lesson.”

“Conservatives call it illegal. Liberals accept it, but want to regulate it.”

“But is it illegal for a business to refuse Canadian dollars?” Cash asked.

“Not really,” Lucy replied. “Businesses can choose their payment methods as long as they make it clear. The law protects contracts, not currency.”

Cash smiled slightly. “So I could open an ice cream stand and accept only poems as payment?”

Lucy returned a small smile. “In theory, yes. But I would not recommend it as a business model.”

That landed better than it would have earlier. Something between them had shifted, just enough to make space.

Cash looked down at the drawing. It was better than he expected. He turned the paper slightly toward her.

Lucy leaned in.

“That’s not bad actually,” she said.

“Dissonance,” Cash replied. “Sometimes it works.”

Lucy let out a quiet laugh and gestured back to her notes.

“Does the state step in to restore the old order,” she said, “or does it let a new one emerge?”

Cash did not answer immediately. His mind moved between Lucy’s structured notes and Amir’s voice, still echoing somewhere in the background. Systems, beliefs, constructs.

In the late nineteen seventies, the Conservative Party had shut down the basic income experiment in Dauphin, Manitoba, just as it began to show positive results. Now the same party was trying to stop the reform by appealing to an old world, even though reality itself had changed with the loop. Cash did not know which party Lucy would have voted for, and he did not dare ask.

“Maybe the question isn’t which system replaces the old one,” Cash said. “Maybe it’s whether people still believe in systems at all.”

Lucy considered that and underlined a sentence in her notes.

“Fifty dollars is the new zero.”

Cash read it. Cash looked at Lucy’s notes that were full of straight lines. If Lucy’s way of working resembled Mondrian’s geometry, his own was closer to Jackson Pollock’s chaos. From that combination, what would their collaborative article look like, Cash thought.

“Or zero just means something else now.”

The idea was not new. If everyone received a basic income, businesses would raise prices because people had more spending power. But inflation was not automatic. It depended on many factors. In the loop, some prices had risen while others had fallen. Maybe the question was not whether fifty dollars was the new zero, but whether the concept of zero itself had changed.

Cash remembered reading about hyperinflation in the Weimar Republic, how German workers were paid twice a day so they could buy food before prices rose again. A basket of bread cost one mark in the morning and twenty by afternoon. But it was not just about money. It was about a collapse of collective trust, when people stopped believing that the system could carry them.

Later in history, states had often tried to restore trust by stabilizing currency, tying it to gold or to the independence of central banks. But in the loop, there was no future to anchor to. No interest rate policy, no expectations of tomorrow’s demand. Barter felt more real.

Lucy continued, as if reading his thoughts. “According to Friedman, inflation is always a

monetary phenomenon. According to Keynes, public spending is the key to stability. But in this world, neither applies."

"So whose theory works?" Cash asked.

Lucy was silent for a moment. "No one's."

Cash wrote it down. It had to go into the article.

"Drugs are a good example," Lucy continued. "Addictions have been observed to persist, even though the body biologically resets to the start of the loop."

Cash nodded. "People return to coping mechanisms. Not because of physiology, but because of remembered feeling. More like psychological dependence."

Even though stocks were now tied to real goods and felt more concrete, the forces driving the economy were still the same as before. Desire, scarcity, and the fear of missing out.

Lucy closed her notebook. "Shall we start writing?"

Cash nodded and took the last sip of his coffee.

"But one rule," he said.

Lucy raised an eyebrow.

"The first draft goes on the wall. With chalk."

Lucy smiled. "Is black okay?"

Lucy was meticulous, logical, almost engineer-like in her precision. Cash tended to write more instinctively. The editorial desk rarely edited Lucy's texts, while Cash's drafts rarely survived unchanged. He had learned not to take it personally. Still, something about this collaboration worked.

"I couldn't help overhearing," a stranger said, slurring slightly as he stood up. "But you journalists have no idea what you're talking about. You can't understand money unless you've been an economist or worked in a bank. You just can't. All these theories you throw around sound stupid."

Seemingly satisfied, the middle-aged man turned to leave.

"Well, what did we get so wrong?" Cash asked, addressing him as he paused a few steps away.

“Everything. But it doesn’t matter,” the man said. “I listened long enough to know you two don’t know what you’re talking about.” With that, he started toward the door, as if he had already delivered an argument that could not be answered.

Cash stood and followed him outside. They stopped on the sidewalk. The man was noticeably smaller than Cash and now seemed uneasy, which Cash did not understand.

“I don’t respect the tone,” Cash said, “but give us one example.”

“Two hundred becomes the new zero,” the man replied. “That’s how it works. Why would a hotel room still cost one hundred and fifty if people can now pay three hundred and fifty?”

“We did cover that,” Cash said. “I don’t know how closely you listened, or whether you had already decided who journalists are and what we must believe.”

Lucy stepped outside and joined them.

“Trust me,” the man said, looking from one to the other. “I have more experience with your kind than you do. And it’s not flattering. Journalists are the scum of the world. Don’t take this so personally. These are just facts.”

“If you’re such an expert simply because you’ve worked in a bank, tell me, what about people with degrees in economics who teach those who will become bankers?” Cash asked.

“Imposters,” the man said without hesitation. “You can’t understand how money works unless you’ve worked in a bank.”

“So when risk models failed in 2008,” Cash pressed, “who misunderstood money. The bankers using them, or the economists warning about them?”

The man did not answer.

“I think you don’t understand how journalism works. A journalist doesn’t put everything they know into a single article.” Cash explained.

“Cash, it’s fine,” Lucy said.

“Yes, listen to her,” the man agreed quickly.

“So you haven’t changed your mind at all,” Cash said. “That you don’t have to be a banker to understand money. Because for me, that sounds very black and white.”

“No, but thanks anyway for not beating me up.” The man answered.

“What. I would never,” Cash said, offering his hand. “We disagree, but we can still shake on that.”

The man shook his hand and walked away.

Cash felt misjudged. The conversation had been heated and frustrating, but it had never come close to violence.

“I wasn’t sure about that either,” Lucy said.

That stung more than the man’s insults.

What kind of picture did Lucy have of him? Liking hockey did not mean he supported violence.

“Women learn when not to risk their safety,” Lucy explained. “You probably don’t even notice that privilege when you don’t have to think about where a confrontation with a drunk stranger can lead.”

Cash knew she was right, but he still felt the sting of how something once good now carried a bitter taste. Words carried responsibility. Using them carelessly was not harmless, especially when people assumed they could say anything without consequence, protected by the fear of what others might do in response. That was a misuse of power.

Cash asked for accountability. Freedom of speech came with responsibilities. It was something people were quick to forget.

Their ride arrived quickly.

The driver, Ali, had a Pakistani flag hung from the rearview mirror.

Cash leaned forward.

“Congratulations on the gold medal,” he said. “In javelin.”

Ali looked at him through the mirror and laughed.

“Thank you, but it wasn’t me,” he laughed. “But we are all proud. Pakistan has suddenly become very good in many sports.”

He explained that while cricket was still the most popular sport in Pakistan, the national sport was actually field hockey.

“It’s kind of like in Canada,” Cash said. “Lacrosse is the national sport, but internationally, most people would guess it’s ice hockey.”

Ali laughed. “Yes. You are the opposite of us.”

Cash asked what language Ali spoke at home, and then remembered how someone might see the question as a microaggression.

“Urdu,” Ali said. “It’s the national language. But it’s very similar to Hindi. Almost the same. Like a dialect difference.”

He went on to explain how Urdu and Hindi shared roots, shaped by a broader region that included Pakistan, India, Bangladesh, and Nepal. Cash had heard the term Greater India before, and it seemed to fit the way Ali described it.

Cash asked what people in Pakistan called India, recalling the government’s attempt to rename itself.

“There are a few names,” Ali said. “India, Hindustan, and maybe you are asking this, because now also Bharat.”

He explained that the name India came from the Indus River during British rule, while Bharat had older, local origins. There had been recent discussions about officially using Bharat instead, but internationally, the name had not really changed.

“It’s interesting,” Ali said, “how quickly the world forgets things like that.”

He compared it to Turkey, which had rebranded itself as Türkiye, while India’s attempt had not worked as successfully.

“Türkiye had leverage,” he said. “Politics. NATO. India is so big, but it still doesn’t have that kind of pressure to use.”

He said that some people in Pakistan had even suggested reclaiming the name India if India itself moved fully to Bharat.

Cash saw Lucy smile at that.

Ali spoke about the British Empire, and how, in his view, it had destroyed more than it had built. Manchester’s cotton industry, he pointed out, had flourished after India’s own textile production had been weakened.

“The Indus Valley was one of the oldest civilizations,” he said.

Cash nodded. “Like Mesopotamia.”

“Yes, very good,” Ali said.

Then he added something else, almost as a side note.

“In many of our country names, stan means land. Pakistan is the land of the pure. Turkmenistan is the land of the Turkmen.”

Cash was enjoying the conversation and the fact that he was learning so much. Facts came differently when they came from someone who had lived them. It differed from conversations where people already knew what they thought before asking anything.

Cash and Lucy thanked Ali and stepped out of the car. As they walked toward the entrance, Cash though much did people like Bob miss when they were not ready for real conversations. Stories were everywhere. As a journalist, he should have known that. There was a difference between asking out of curiousity and asking to confirm something that the asker already believed. And some questions were not really questions at all. They came loaded, like asking someone whether they condoned terrorism just because of where they were from. It was the kind of question that felt impossible to answer without first accepting something false.

Lucy followed him inside.

“Good ride,” she said.

Cash nodded.

“Yeah,” he said. “It was.”

He wondered why conversations like that did not happen more often. Were Canadians taught that small talk was enough, and anything deeper with a stranger was just cringy? It felt like people carried shields that they were only ready to lower for close friends and family. Without those shields, they were exposed, and being vulnerable was something people only agreed to in controlled settings, like when listening to Brené Brown’s TED Talk or attending workshops where the space was already prepared for sharing.

Then again, maybe those conversations did happen. Maybe most of the time, he just moved through them too quickly to notice.

Or perhaps it was the opposite. Bob’s comments had irritated him enough, like being told not to think about a pink elephant, and then finding it impossible to think about anything else. That could have been all it took.

But then, were people like Bob necessary for change? How else would those in the middle recognize that action might be needed, if only to avoid being grouped with the extremes?

It was not that the world had suddenly become more interesting. He had just started paying attention to the pink elephant.

Liberal Party proposes temporary basic income

New proposal divides opinion in Parliament

Cash Haggerty and Lucy Maxwell | CBC | April 12

The Liberal Party has introduced an extraordinary measure to support Canada as it lives inside the time loop: a temporary fifty-dollar basic income for every citizen and permanent resident. The daily sum would need to be collected in person and would not be deposited automatically into anyone's account.

According to party leader Sofia Mendez, the proposal is not about supporting unwillingness to work, but about preventing crime and protecting basic needs in a situation where the traditional economic system no longer functions. She emphasizes that the measure is not a permanent solution, but a tool to maintain social stability for as long as the loop continues.

The Conservative Party has criticized the proposal, calling it a solution to a problem that does not exist. Opposition leader Daniel Reeves sees the initiative as a populist attempt to silence growing criticism of the government and argues that it would undermine motivation to work in a post-loop reality. He maintains that Canadians have already adapted independently to the new conditions through barter and skill-based service exchange.

Economists, however, have warned that adaptation is not evenly distributed. Professor Marcus O'Connell of the University of Toronto points out that the loop favours those with tradable skills or access to resources. Those who were already in vulnerable positions, such as caregivers, people with chronic illnesses, and single parents, are at risk of being left outside the new system.

The risk of inflation is frequently raised in discussions about basic income. Several experts, including O'Connell, doubt that a basic income would have any real long-term effect on inflation. Instead, prices would adjust quickly, meaning that fifty dollars would no longer provide the intended security, but would blend into a higher overall price level. According to O'Connell, the only real beneficiaries would be those living close to areas where the basic income is not distributed.

Mendez argues that the weight of these concerns is relative. According to the party's analysis, only a small fraction of citizens would be willing to line up every morning to collect a fifty-dollar payment. As a result, it would require effort and would not be sufficient to affect the value of money.

Public reactions have nevertheless been mixed. Some feel that the initiative would finally bring concrete security to a situation where livelihoods can no longer be built on traditional structures. Others worry that the model encourages passivity and shifts too much responsibility onto the state.

No final decision has been made. If the proposal moves forward to committee review, it may become one of the most politically significant legislative initiatives of the time loop.

Chapter 1.14

One morning, the news was about something completely different. Cash pressed the plunger of his French press down just as the news anchor said:

“A possible asteroid impact event has been predicted for the year 2032.”

Cash turned toward the screen. Kate was already reaching for the remote to turn the volume up.

“According to new simulations, the asteroid 2024 AG5 has a higher risk of impact than previously estimated,” the anchor continued. “The probability is still low, but its orbit and the lack of long-term observational data mean that researchers consider a collision with Earth in 2032 possible.”

Strangely, the possibility of an impact itself did not interest Cash as much as two words did. New simulations.

Kate asked exactly what Cash, and probably much of the world, was thinking.

“How can this be new?” There was a mix of frustration and fear in her voice. “How can we suddenly have new information?”

Cash had no answer. For nearly half a year, every study, observation, and calculation should have remained the same. If an astronomer had run these numbers one hundred and sixty loops ago, they should have woken up every morning to exactly the same results. Something had changed.

When Chris held the morning briefing for the domestic news team, it felt like a repeat of the very first day of the loop. Reports mentioned protests, end-of-the-world celebrations, and panicked, still largely irrational evacuation attempts. Scientists, journalists, and conspiracy theorists were once again trying to explain the unexplainable.

Theories spread like summer wildfires. One suggested this was proof that the loop was not permanent, because the time phenomenon had to be local. The asteroid continued to orbit the Sun at twenty kilometres per second, moving toward Earth, and would eventually come too close.

Of course, no one knew whether the asteroid would become trapped in the loop once it approached. Maybe it was also destined to get endlessly close to something instead of nothing, only to be just as far away again the next day.

The alternative was worse. If the gates of the loop were small enough, the asteroid might strike Earth, again and again, every single day. That was not just catastrophic. It was a dystopian nightmare.

Some believed the loop existed to prevent exactly that destruction in 2032. Perhaps someone, somewhere, had calculated that the climate crisis had not yet reached its peak, and that April 12 was the optimal point to freeze time. An eternity that would preserve the planet, while quietly saving hundreds of thousands of lives from the asteroid.

It could not be proven. Not one way or another.

Still, if this really was some kind of advanced technology resetting reality to a single repeating day, why was it only one day? Why not longer?

It had to be a limitation. Memory capacity, perhaps.

Cash suspected that whoever designed the loop did not live in Vancouver. Otherwise, why choose a rainy day for eternity instead of one of the city's rare, perfect sunny ones?

Eternity sounded impossibly long, yet it was something most people were strangely comfortable with. Entire religions had been built on that promise.

Kate moved through the day as if in a fog, feeding the girls, answering endless why questions, and taking them to the park.

If daily life were measured in units of energy, Kate had already used hers up before noon.

Cash tried to answer every question in order to preserve their curiosity, but understandably, Kate did not have the energy for Socratic dialogue that day. It had been a playful family competition to see how many follow-up questions one could answer reasonably without losing patience.

Today, Cash had made it to level six, one short of the family record. After that, he had to admit he did not know.

It went roughly like this:

"Why do asteroids exist?" Florence asked, her mouth full of porridge.

"Because they are leftovers from the formation of the solar system," Cash answered.

"Why were there leftovers?"

"Because not all matter became planets or stars, and some was left orbiting the Sun."

"Why didn't they crash into the planets back then?"

“Some did, but others kept going, and nothing forced them out of their orbits.”

“Why are they still orbiting?”

“Because motion continues unless something stops it, and the Sun’s gravity keeps them in place.”

“Why doesn’t gravity pull them into the Sun?”

“Because they are moving so fast sideways that they do not fall straight in.”

“Why are they moving so fast?”

Cash thought for a moment and gave in. “That one I actually need to check.”

A moment later, he read about how they gained their speed when the solar system formed about 4.6 billion years ago. Florence accepted the answer and was clearly proud of her question for making even Cash learn something new.

Kate’s posture showed that she was holding herself together through sheer willpower. She lingered by the girls’ beds longer than usual, stroked Florence’s hair, and kissed Arabella’s forehead as if afraid there was a limited number of kisses.

Cash waited for her in the bedroom, but she did not come. Instead, he found her standing by the window, staring at the sky.

“I was just starting to accept this,” Kate finally said. “And now what? The world starts moving forward again, but only for the worse?”

“It’s very unlikely that it will hit Earth,” Cash said, trying to put as much hope as possible into his voice. “And maybe the asteroid’s passing will end the loop.”

Kate shook her head, signalling that Cash could not possibly know that. She knew that the physics books he had been reading lately could not give him expert authority over something this unusual, and Cash knew it too.

All he had was faith in probabilities. If there was an eighty percent chance the asteroid would miss Earth, he chose to trust that, rather than the one-fifth chance of impact.

Kate sighed and leaned against him. They stared at the West End cityscape, which felt surreal, like a dream.

“How is the rest of the world not screaming that this is not normal? I need to know why this is happening. There has to be some purpose to all of this,” Kate said emotionally.

If the asteroid existed outside the loop, what did that mean? Was it the reset point of the time loop, or something worse?

“Dan said in the teachers’ lounge that he told his class the loop is protecting us from the asteroid.”

Dan was Kate’s colleague, an elementary school teacher who, according to Kate, was not always the easiest person to work with. Cash doubted the students would have accepted the explanation so easily without a series of why and how questions, but then again, Cash did not have a better answer than Dan either.

“Maybe it is,” he admitted.

If the loop really had been designed to prevent an asteroid impact, it raised the question of why and by whom. Cash had read that time travel was not theoretically possible. But what if altering history was, at some distant point in the future? Maybe we were never meant to move objects through time. But what if future generations had learned to move time itself around the objects?

For Cash, asking these questions felt empowering. Psychologists would have said he was good at sublimation, which, in simple terms, meant he could channel his anxieties into action. It created a sense of control and agency.

Kate experienced it differently. For her, the endless searching felt like a mental loop of its own, where information did not build anything, but only added more weight. She had described it as throwing more logs onto a fire that was already burning. She needed solutions, but at the moment, there was nothing but guesses, most of them leaning toward pseudoscience that her anxiety’s bullshit detector was terrifyingly good at spotting.

Cash tried to choose his words carefully, shifting the focus from individual struggle to something shared.

“There is strength in community,” he said. “Ordinary people make discoveries by accident, like archaeological finds that experts might never have found without them. And think about how many people around the world are thinking about this. It’s in everyone’s interest. We’re just not searching for something from the past like those archaeologists, but looking for clues about tomorrow.”

Kate nodded slowly, turning his words over in her mind. She seemed to realize that rumination alone was not moving her forward and was only keeping her stuck. She wanted to break away from the cycle and find a way that felt more active and constructive.

Cash realized how easily he had stepped into the role of a psychologist without any real competence or consent, as if he had been pathologizing Kate's thoughts and steering her away from overthinking. Who was Cash to advise on that? It was care, not manipulation, Cash hoped. But where, in the end, was the line between supporting someone he loved and changing their thinking?

For Cash, an active search was already in his job description. People had a right to information, and he felt a responsibility to find it. Before the loop, work had felt like work, but recently he had begun to experience it in a completely different way. In just a few months, he felt he had grown more as a journalist than during many previous years, when the job had felt routine and repetitive.

What a paradox it was that work had become more meaningful and different at the same time as everything else had become the same.

Chapter 1.15

Cash met Kate in front of her school, and they cycled together to the university to meet Langley. Kate had written her questions by hand in a notebook that looked like it had been taken straight from a teacher's supply room. Probably it was. Cash found himself wondering where the line between borrowing and stealing really was, when something was taken from a supply room after hours, knowing that it would refill itself the following morning with nothing missing.

"Where did you get all these?" he asked, as he flipped through the questions in Kate's notebook.

"From Quora," Kate said with a grin.

Cash realized how much he had underestimated the power of digital communities. He had seen them as marketplaces for passing impulses. Now they felt more like laboratories of shared thinking, where strangers built knowledge together without anyone owning the answers.

"You can ask literally anything there, and some expert somewhere in the world will answer." Kate continued.

It sounded perfect for an era where every question needed an answer before the next day arrived. Cash belonged to an older school of thought. The one who trusted the printed word more and still believed vinyl was the only proper way to listen to music.

Langley welcomed them in and waved them toward his cluttered office. The whiteboards were once again covered in diagrams and equations that meant nothing to Cash, even though Greek would have been a more accurate comparison than Hebrew. At least he recognised one Greek letter that looked like a mix between the letters u and y.

"Well," Langley began as he sat down, "the loop cannot be broken. We have to live through it until time resumes its normal flow."

Kate and Cash looked at each other.

"What do you mean?" Kate asked.

Langley gestured toward the window. "We have observations showing that changes have begun to occur farther out in space. That confirms the phenomenon only affects a limited area."

Cash took a moment to process the words. "That would explain the asteroid," he said finally. "It's outside all of this."

“Yes,” Langley nodded. “We have detected minor fluctuations in Earth’s magnetic field and air pressure. They are extremely subtle, but just enough to indicate the loop is not perfectly stable. It has begun to weaken.”

“That’s a massive news story,” Cash said. “How long until it weakens enough to break the loop?”

“No one knows yet. The effect of a cosmic string should have been immediate. If they even exist, such strings would move at nearly the speed of light. So, the loop should have lasted only a fraction of a second.”

“Could something have slowed it down?” Kate suggested. “Like how a prism bends light. Could something slow the string?”

Langley raised his eyebrows. “Good question. A cosmic string could theoretically interact with Earth’s gravity in unexpected ways. If it encountered a dense enough gravitational field, it might create a local distortion.”

“Well, when will we know how long the loop will last?” Cash asked.

“That depends on many factors. Physicists are running calculations, but the daily resets complicate everything. We have to rely on international collaboration, share data across time zones, and build systems that preserve progress across resets.”

“But what’s your estimate?” Cash asked. “When will we know more?”

Langley sighed in his familiar tone that had begun to irritate Cash. He was not sure why.

“If we are very lucky, perhaps in a few weeks. But that’s optimistic. It could take months. You have to understand that the resets slow down every step.”

“And if the asteroid hits,” Kate said, “the loop ends, and then we wake up in normal time.”

“Or not at all,” Cash added.

Langley shook his head. “We need to be clear about one thing. There’s absolutely no evidence linking the asteroid to the time loop. They appear to be entirely separate phenomena.”

The ride home passed in silence. Only their thoughts raced. If Langley was right, the boundary of the loop was tightening, like a shrinking dodgeball court. Even if the asteroid had nothing to do with the loop, it could still drift into its range, and what followed was anyone’s guess. The loop might shield Earth from impact, or trap it in an endless cycle of daily collisions. It was almost impossible to comprehend.

Time had always been an obsession for humans. Before mechanical clocks, time was measured by burning candles and the movement of shadows. The first fully mechanical clocks, invented in the early Middle Ages, did not show time with hands at all. They just rang a bell once an hour. Medieval monks divided their days into prayer hours without knowing exactly when morning ended and evening began. Did they ever grow bored of their loop, living by ora et labora, prayer and work? Or did devotion to God protect them from boredom the way sunscreen protects against ultraviolet radiation? Perhaps that was why prayer had to be repeated so often, like applying another layer to avoid burning.

The same pattern could be seen in places like the United States, where the national anthem was played constantly, as if to maintain citizens' memory of being American and to ensure they were treated as such when travelling abroad. Had a Canadian ever demanded better service by reminding a waiter of their Canadian identity? It did not sound quite as grand as declaring oneself American, which was always said with the same confidence as claiming to know the restaurant's manager.

Cash recalled how the Groundhoggers had begun telling stories of earlier times when humanity's goodness had been tested by stopping time. One interesting story, which had been included in their canon, was set in a German village near France and Switzerland. According to the tale, the cuckoo clock in the town hall began to stall and would not chime unless one villager had done something kind for another. When enough moral acts had accumulated, the cuckoo would appear, and the clock hand would move forward to the next hour. The village eventually transformed from a community of traders into an altruistic utopia, where the clock never stopped again.

Later, Cash had come across an article linking the story to Mary Louisa Molesworth's fairy tale The Cuckoo Clock from 1877. The story was just slightly varied. In the original, the clock's function was tied to the happiness of a family. If there was conflict in the home, the cuckoo fell silent. The Groundhoggers had woven it into their own narrative, and that was no coincidence, since the story fit their message perfectly. But Cash could not blame them too much, since almost everything was always based on something earlier, if someone chose to dig deep enough into history.

It made perfect sense that the movement needed older sources than a 1990s Hollywood film. Perhaps someone had pointed out that even the film's premise was not original but rooted in a German Quaker Candlemas tradition. In it, the start of spring was predicted by observing the behaviour of a badger. When the custom reached Pennsylvania, where there were no badgers, the role of foreteller was given to a groundhog instead. Just as Christianity might have taken on an entirely different name if Jesus had not died on a cross, Groundhoggers, too, might have been called something else if there had been badgers in Pennsylvania. Interesting thought.

That was how a local celebration was born, then a film, then an idea that gave rise to another idea, and from ideas to philosophy. Philosophy became belief, and belief slowly turned into religion. Cash wondered what had made him lose his temper so quickly and unnecessarily when Chris had called the movement a cult. It certainly looked like one, he admitted, and felt shame for getting upset over something so small.

Time Loop Shows Signs of Weakening

Researchers detect signs of change, but the timeline remains uncertain

Cash Haggerty | CBC | April 12

The scientific community has detected subtle but significant changes in Earth's magnetic field and air pressure. These observations suggest that the time loop is not permanent.

"The data indicates that the loop is gradually weakening," Professor of Physics Langley Atwood from the University of British Columbia says.

Determining an exact timeline remains difficult. In the new reality created by the loop, developing precise calculations is challenging, as data disappears into spacetime after each day. Many universities have recruited volunteers to act as rememberers. Rememberers were a well-known profession in ancient wars, when someone had to memorise the heroic deeds of rulers.

Research is progressing slowly but steadily, thanks to global academic cooperation. Dr Atwood estimates that within the next month, the scientific community will have an assessment of when the loop is likely to end.

At the same time, several media outlets have speculated that the flyby or possible impact of the approaching asteroid could trigger a chain of events that would break the time loop. Professor Langley Atwood remains sceptical of this theory.

"There is no scientific basis for it," he says. "The asteroid follows its own trajectory, and the loop appears to function completely independently of it."

Chapter 1.16

Kate had suggested inviting Langley, his spouse, Kevin, and Florence's classmate Harriet over for dinner. At first, Langley had politely declined because of all the chaos happening at work, but his spouse, Kevin, had eventually talked him into agreeing.

Kate prepared the pizza dough while Cash chopped and fried the toppings. The girls were tasked to design their own pizzas. They compared their creations as laughter filled the room.

Kevin had strong opinions about pizza. He explained that he had once travelled to Naples to understand what real pizza truly was. Kevin spoke about it like a man more Italian than the Italians themselves, his hands drawing wide arcs in the air.

Cash seized the opportunity.

"By the way, is it true that a Margherita is used to test the true quality of a pizzeria?"

Kevin nodded immediately. "Of course. Everything starts there. The dough, the tomato, the cheese. There is nothing to hide behind."

Harriet clearly agreed. She had obviously inherited, or at least learned, the same passion from Kevin. She examined her pizza with a seriousness that Cash found both impressive and amusing. Before taking her first bite, Harriet lifted the slice to her nose, smelled it, and nodded approvingly. The dough had clearly passed inspection. Then she looked at the three pizzas on the table and named them carefully.

"This is la classica perfetta."

Naturally, it was her own. The toppings were thoughtfully balanced, each ingredient placed with care, like a meticulous child's colouring book.

Florence and Arabella had taken a more spontaneous approach. Their pizzas were an explosion of colour and toppings. Maybe they had inherited that from him, Cash thought, recalling the gin and tonic he had made at a music festival after a half-hour workshop. When participants were asked to mix their own drink after everything they had learned, Cash's creation had resembled a fruit salad. If the workshop fee was the same regardless of how much alcohol or how many ingredients went into a single glass, anyone would have taken advantage of it. Well in reality, it

was only Cash, and that was why Kate had been so mortified and embarrassed to walk beside him as they left the workshop.

Harriet tilted her head sceptically as she looked at Arabella's pizza, which, admittedly, reminded Cash of his fruit salad–like drink.

"This must be una mosaico di Gaudí," Harriet said.

Cash glanced at Arabella, who clearly took it as a compliment. He knew mosaico was a masculine noun, but did not want to correct a child on their Italian, and point out that it should have been un instead of una.

"So we have Naples and Barcelona represented," Cash said instead.

Kevin snorted. "You could not pay me to eat in Barcelona."

"Why?" Kate asked, handing him a slice.

"Paella," Kevin replied, like the word itself had tasted bad. "It has rabbit bones. Who puts bones in food?"

Cash jumped in. "So all of Barcelona's food culture is ruined because of one dish?"

Kevin waved his hand. "Italy and Spain are like night and day. And so are southern and northern Italy. It is richer in the North, and safer, but the pizza is not as good."

"What about wine?" Kate suggested.

Kevin acted as if a light bulb had switched on in his mind and ran to the hallway to dig something out of his bag.

"That I will give them," he said as he returned, holding up a bottle of Amarone della Valpolicella. "And for you, too."

Cash whistled. "Oh, thank you."

"You shouldn't have", Kate said.

For the girls, Kevin had brought homemade lemonade. Kevin described how it had become a shared time loop hobby for Kevin and Harriet, and they had recently perfected the recipe. Harriet examined her drink like a trained sommelier, took a sip, and nodded.

"Needs a bit more carbonation."

Kevin clearly glowed with pride, even though someone else might have considered the critique impolite. Adopted or not, Kevin and Harriet were clearly cut from the same cloth.

During dinner, the conversation drifted to Cash's article, which Langley brought up with a cautious smile.

"I would have preferred the article to emphasize how hypothetical everything was. I did not want to give false hope or the impression that I would have all the answers."

"I don't think readers got that impression," Cash replied. He explained how journalism worked and how final versions were often edited to be more engaging and accessible.

"I wrote almost word-for-word what you said," he added. "But it was cut. Apparently too technical."

Langley was not surprised. He had expected it. In that regard, things were still better in Canada than in the United States, which had once been a global leader in science and research but had since begun losing top researchers to Canada and Europe. The idea of limiting academic freedom felt like an anti-science dystopia, and Canada had taken advantage of the situation by attracting scholars. Canada was good at that. Few Canadians realized that a points-based system had governed immigration since 1967. It ranked prospective immigrants based on education, skills, and work experience.

Cash had read that a similar development had begun in some Canadian provinces, where entire humanities courses had been shut down for being too subjective or labelled left-wing propaganda. He wondered what a university would look like if everything that failed to meet the strictest standards of objectivity were stripped away. Only measurable sciences would remain. But what would happen to society if its future builders were raised without the ability to interpret humanity, culture, or history?

As the evening progressed, Langley's tone grew more serious. He mentioned a troubling theory he could not get out of his mind. Kevin gently touched his hand and said quietly,

"Love, could we talk about this later?" gesturing toward the girls.

Langley nodded, and the conversation returned to lighter topics.

Once the house had grown quiet and the girls were asleep, Cash offered Langley and Kevin glasses of whisky. Both accepted. Langley swirled the golden liquid in his glass and began.

“Let us assume that I am wrong, and that the asteroid and the loop are connected. Completely hypothetical. Do not quote me on this.” He raised his glass toward Cash, who acknowledged the gesture with a smile.

“It is possible that, in the future, humanity prevented the asteroid impact, only for someone centuries later to calculate that the collision would have been the better outcome for humanity, or even for the planet. I have had strangely vivid dreams about this, almost as if someone were trying to send me a message. I know how unscientific that sounds, yet they made me wonder. What if that realization led them to try to undo the prevention itself? If you consider how we have treated the Earth and its life, the idea does not feel entirely impossible anymore.”

Cash and Kate looked at Langley, confused. Kevin, who had clearly heard this before, focused on tasting his whisky.

“If the loop was caused by a future civilization rather than a cosmic string, as I previously believed, then it is true that the loop must have a purpose. Would it not be logical to assume they do not want us to do anything about the asteroid, since we physically cannot within a single day?”

Cash thought about the destructive history of the human species. When our ancestors arrived in Australia fifty thousand years ago, they unknowingly wiped out much of the continent’s large animals. The same pattern repeated everywhere. Other human species and countless animals disappeared. We became too powerful for our environment.

“So if all of this has a purpose, there’s no way to know whether that purpose is benevolent or malicious,” Cash clarified. He loved these conversations, even though he knew they often made Kate anxious.

“That’s a good point. Why do we assume future generations would be morally better than us? This could just as easily be the largest terrorist attack in history, against either the country the asteroid hits or all of humanity,” Cash continued.

“So maybe we should act in a way that’s not expected of us,” Kate said. Cash was not sure whether Kate was genuinely interested in the rather wild topic or simply being a good host. Perhaps both. Lately, she had shown increasing interest in what Cash had learned through his

research and often knew more than he did, even though writing about the loop was Cash's day job.

"In that hypothetical futuristic timeline, for sure we would have used all our resources to stop the asteroid," Cash said thoughtfully. "But when every day resets everything, nothing can be built or launched far enough. I agree it's as if something is making sure we don't."

"So we are stuck here for a reason. See, I've said that from the beginning," Kate smiled.

Langley did not reject the idea. "All of this has taught humility in the face of an unbelievable reality. A thousand years from now, physicists may consider my understanding of reality as primitive as we see cavemen's ideas about the movement of the sky. Time loops might then be reduced to a single sentence in an introductory physics course. The teacher could say that time is a flexible line that can be bent into a loop under certain conditions, and with this equation, we understand how the direction of the line is controlled."

Kevin joined in. "What do you think happens when time continues? When we wake up on April thirteenth?"

"What do you mean?" Kate asked.

"Do we look at the date and say, hey, the loop is over, or do we forget this entire unreal period?"

"I don't think such massive, collective memory loss is possible," Cash said. "But then again, I never believed time loops existed outside films. If that's true, and we suddenly forget everything, it would mean we could have experienced loops before. We just don't remember them. Who knows, maybe even identical ones, and I've said this all before. What a disturbing thought. Imagine if we were like side characters in a Groundhog Day movie."

Langley nodded, appreciating Cash's reflection. "We have theories, but each has gaps. No one has come up with an explanation comparable to E equals mc squared. We are sitting in the passenger seat, waiting for the asteroid, and hoping for a Nobel-worthy breakthrough."

Cash had thought Langley believed firmly in the cosmic string theory, but his doubts kept him awake long into the night, until he finally woke up again to the sound of tapping raindrops.

Chapter 1.17

“Schools,” she said. “We have to revisit that. What does it look like after the news about the asteroid? Is it still school as usual? Are there resources for teachers to talk about it? It feels like we’ve already lived through this once, am I right?”

It was for Lucy and Bob.

Chris tapped his pen against the notebook.

“Food supply,” he added. “Are there stores that still grant customers’ requests for products? How does that work in practice when inventories reset every morning?”

Janet pointed at Dev and Peter, who both nodded.

“Hospitals,” Janet read from her own notes.

Hospitals had become one of the strangest institutions. Recovery never progressed. The outcome of surgeries disappeared overnight. Every patient woke up with the same diagnosis they had begun the morning with.

Chris looked across the table.

“Cash, I want you on the medical ethics angle. Janet will help you.”

Cash nodded.

“So the question is,” Chris said, “when the day resets anyway, why treat the patient. And why would someone want to go through surgery?”

“Have a good day, everybody,” Janet said.

The meeting dissolved quickly after that. Chairs rolled back, and the team members started scanning contacts and calling experts who might still have answers for a world that refused to move forward.

Cash walked over to Janet’s workstation overlooking Hamilton Street. Traffic moved below in a steady rhythm.

“As a doctor,” Cash said, “would you even recommend an invasive treatment if you know its effect disappears tomorrow? It sounds like something that would violate the Hippocratic Oath.”

Janet leaned back slightly in her chair.

“That’s a great frame. I like it,” she said.

She opened a blank document and began typing.

“I have a contact at St. Paul’s Hospital. A cardiac surgeon named Raseema Ansari. Could you call her? I’ll start the draft.”

Cash hesitated for a moment. It was Janet’s contact after all. But she was already writing the first sentence.

But that was good delegating, and to be fair, Cash could not have found a contact quickly. He had never been the biggest fan of cold calls, even though almost every article required that. He picked up the sometimes terrifying phone.

If doctors were still performing surgeries inside a day that would disappear tomorrow morning, he wanted to understand why.

Someone answered.

“Hi,” Cash said. “This is Cash Haggerty from CBC News. My colleague Janet Maguire shared your contact. I’m working on a story about hospitals and wondered if you might have a few minutes.”

“Yes, of course,” the voice said. It was surprisingly calm and warm. “I’m at work, but I can talk.”

“So you’re a surgeon, right?”

“I am,” she said. “A cardiac surgeon.”

Cash paused for a moment.

“And you’re still operating even though the day repeats. How is that possible?”

There was a brief pause.

“Well,” she said, “first of all, heart surgery isn’t just me in a room with a patient.”

Cash glanced at Janet. She was already typing.

“In a complex cardiac operation, there can be more than thirty specialists involved. Surgeons, anesthesiologists, perfusionists running the heart-lung machine, nurses, technicians. The whole team.”

Cash imagined it for a moment. Thirty people standing around an operating table performing a surgery that would vanish overnight.

“You can’t simply tell that many people to stop doing their job because tomorrow might reset,” she continued.

She paused for a moment.

“And secondly, every day is still different. If someone arrives today with a heart problem that needs surgery, they need treatment today. The possibility that tomorrow might be the same, doesn’t change our duty to treat.”

Cash listened carefully and heard Janet’s ten fingers typing.

“It isn’t my place to assume Wednesday will never come,” the surgeon said, like ending an inspirational TED talk.

When the call ended, they worked on the draft. Cash knew how to be efficient. Sometimes he saw his sentences appear before his thoughts. It was what people described flow experience.

Cash kept typing until Janet pointed at the screen and said.

“Read that paragraph.”

Cash read it aloud and saw Janet nodding.

“It’s good thinking,” she said. “But you start to philosophize a little.”

Cash smiled. It felt like a compliment, but Cash knew it was the meat of the sandwich model.

“Sometimes the reader just needs the point,” she continued.

She pointed at the screen.

“The question is simple. Should doctors operate if the outcome disappears tomorrow. Everything else supports that question. Don’t wander too far away from it.”

Cash appreciated the clarity. Janet had a way of correcting things without making anyone feel small.

“You know what helps with this,” she continued. “Structure.”

She rearranged a few lines in the article.

“Journalism under time pressure is not about inspiration. It’s about process.”

Inspiration sounded like a synonym of flow experience Cash was good at finding while writing. So the opposite of flow must have been the process, the procedural writing. That did not sound inspiring.

“Most stories follow the same rhythm,” she said. “Lead, context, expert voice, counterpoint, then a closing idea. If you already know that structure, half the work is done before you start writing.”

She pointed again at the screen.

“The lead sets the dilemma. The expert quote grounds it. Then we expand the ethical question.”

Cash nodded and found it amusing how it sounded like something his badminton coach would have said.

“It also builds trust with readers,” she said. “Consistency matters. People like knowing how a story unfolds. If every article is a different maze, they stop following you.”

She highlighted a sentence he had suggested earlier.

“This part here,” she said. “It’s thoughtful, but we need to tighten it.”

She condensed the last three sentences into one.

“That’s better.”

Cash did not mind the edits. He found Janet’s corrections precise and purposeful. And to be honest, this was not the first time Cash had heard the feedback. Kind of like how every badminton coach had said the same tips about a certain part of his technique, but he never took the time to improve it. It was something he already knew.

“Why did Chris put you one with me?” Cash asked, not entirely sure if this was an invisible professional development that was disguised as collaborative teamwork.

Janet looked at him.

“You don’t know?”

Cash shook his head.

Janet rested her elbows on the desk.

“Before journalism, I was a registered nurse.”

Cash blinked.

“You were?”

“For seven years,” she said. “Emergency department mostly.”

Cash looked at her with new curiosity. For someone who asked questions for a living, he was surprisingly bad at asking them at the right moments. Journalists were a bit like shoemakers whose children went barefoot. The shoes were saved for strangers, not colleagues.

Then his imagination pictured Janet moving through an emergency room surrounded by thirty specialists. Maybe that kind of staffing was only typical in heart surgery. Cash had no idea what an ER looked like behind the scenes.

“That must have been intense,” Cash said.

Janet nodded slowly.

“One night we had a teenager come in after a highway crash,” she said. “The trauma team worked on him for almost two hours.”

She paused.

“He died about twenty minutes later.”

Cash said nothing except nonverbally as he grinned.

“But for those two hours,” Janet continued, “everyone in that room acted like he was absolutely going to make it. Doctors, nurses, everyone.”

She looked back at the screen.

“No one said it out loud, but we all knew the odds were terrible.”

She tapped the keyboard lightly.

“You treat the patient in front of you, not the statistics. I always got along with Raseema.”

Cash connected the pieces. They must have worked in the same emergency room. After that kind of experience, you do not just hang up when someone mentions your name on the phone. Cash remembered the surgeon’s words that it was not her place to assume Wednesday would never come. That was powerful.

“So why journalism?” Cash asked Janet.

“In the ER, you see a lot of things,” she answered. “There are things that affect thousands of patients but are made far too far away from the hospital.”

She pointed at the article.

“I realized I wanted to explain that to the public and not just treat whatever the consequence is.”

Cash was impressed. All people were interesting when the right questions were asked.

“That makes sense.” Cash answered.

“Also the hours are better for someone with kids.” Janet laughed.

Cash understood he did not even know that Janet had children, but he had somehow assumed it. Some people he knew would have said the assumption was stereotypical and insensitive.

She turned back to the article.

“Doctors aren’t just thinking about outcomes. They’re thinking about what their responsibility is. That’s the key.” Janet explained, shaking her right index finger like realizing something profound.

Cash’s mind drifted to something he had read about Walter Freeman. By the late nineteen forties, tens of thousands of lobotomies had been performed across North America. Freeman alone had carried out or supervised thousands of them, travelling from hospital to hospital like a salesman of certainty.

A quick procedure, He had called it a quick procedure. Which it was. An ice pick through the eye socket and a small movement of the wrist. With that single move, Walter altered a life faster than a doctor could have written a prescription.

Doctors believed they were helping, and their families were desperate. Even though they had probably had good intentions, history judged them differently.

Accidents that happened during the day still mattered. A crushed leg would still have hurt and maybe even killed. If someone arrived at the hospital after a collision, the ethical response did not change just because the next day might undo the damage.

Doctors could not gamble on something like that. No, no one knew when the loop would end. And when it did, whatever condition the patient happened to be in at that moment would suddenly become permanent.

Janet stopped typing and read the paragraph aloud.

Cash realized she had quietly folded some of his thinking into the article.

“That works,” she nodded, took back the laptop, and saved the document.

Hospitals continue to treat patients despite resetting days, doctors say

Medical staff continue surgeries even as each day appears to start over

Janet Maguire and Cash Haggerty | CBC | April 12

Medical professionals say hospitals continue to provide care and perform surgeries. Emergency rooms and surgical units remain open, with staff attending to injuries as they arise day by day, despite the fact that aspects of recovery and long-term progress disappear when the calendar resets each morning.

Dr. Raseema Ansari, a surgeon at St. Paul's Hospital, told CBC that providing care remains critical, regardless of the unusual circumstances.

"Every day is still different," Ansari said. "If someone is seriously injured today, they need treatment today. The fact that tomorrow might reset doesn't change our duty to treat."

Ansari said the unpredictability of the situation makes it impossible for medical professionals to assume that the current pattern of repeating days will continue indefinitely.

"Medicine is about responding to the needs in front of you," she said. "We cannot make assumptions about what comes next."

Acute injuries, such as those from accidents or sudden illness, continue to require immediate surgical and emergency intervention. Delaying treatment in these cases can increase suffering or risk to patients, even if the physical condition resets the following morning.

However, the practice of ongoing care raises complex questions about elective and scheduled procedures. Some patients want to have the same procedures done each day, as the surgery lines are long and the end of the loop is believed to be near.

"In every case, our focus is on the present need," Ansari said.

Health care administrators say they maintain normal staffing and procedural schedules in the interest of patient safety.

Chapter 1.18

The staff appreciation party was one of those occasions where teachers' partners were invited to participate. The event was held in the school gymnasium that had its floor painted with basketball and volleyball court lines. Cash remembered his own elementary school gym classes. He was probably something of a rarity these days, in that he could remember his childhood PE lessons with warmth. He had only later learned that sports was such a traumatizing subject for so many of his generation.

Each table was set with plates of catered food, bottles of wine, and the now legendary bingo cards.

The school principal, Pete, walked up to the microphone.

"Alright, alright, how are we doing?" he grinned.

The audience laughed. Not because anything was particularly funny yet, but because they knew what was coming.

Pete was a good principal. He supported his teachers, handled difficult parents, and fought for the school when it mattered. But he also loved stand-up comedy. Every year, he used his speech as an opportunity to perform his own set, which no one had specifically asked for. It was simply part of the package.

Pete gestured toward the bingo cards on the tables.

"Big thanks to the event team for these. If you have a square that says 'Principal performs an unsolicited stand up set,' congratulations, you can tick it off. And yes, I know some of you have been betting on how long this will take. That is completely allowed, don't you worry. I placed a bet too, so I have some skin in the game, too."

Laughter followed. Some genuine, some carefully polite.

"What would be a good topic? Feel free to shout one out."

Cash wondered whether the silence pressed hardest at the table closest to Pete, the one they were sitting at. Probably. Or maybe the threshold to speak just felt lower there. It could be the same phenomenon as heckling at a stand up show. He remembered reading somewhere that the word heckling came from loud textile workers in Scotland.

“The loop.” A teacher at their table called out, waking Cash from thinking about the origin of heckling.

Pete looked directly at the person who suggested it.

“You said that yesterday, too.”

The teachers who had drunk the most wine burst into laughter. They must have started well before the event, because it was not very funny.

“Why did the school clocks never switch to daylight saving time? They were afraid of having to repeat Gordon’s human biology lesson.”

The audience laughed and turned to look at Gordon, who was supposed to retire at the end of the school year. Gordon gave the principal a thumbs down and pulled a theatrical grimace.

The joke had been made before. It was an inside joke at the school. Earlier in the year, Gordon had been asked to substitute for a fifth-grade teacher and had walked into the classroom following the door handle principle, meaning he did not know what he would be teaching until he entered. He had been confronted by a topic he would not have wished on himself, even in his worst nightmare: puberty, menstruation, body hair, and other bodily changes. The teacher for whom he subbed had prepared a slideshow with pedagogically sound discussion questions meant to engage the students.

Because Gordon was old school and had not grown up talking openly about such things, he tried to remain scientifically neutral, which only highlighted his discomfort. His voice took on the tone usually reserved for geological layers.

What Gordon had failed to account for was children’s ability to either know far too much or far too little. One student announced from the middle of the class that her mother was currently on her period. Another explained that babies could only be made when a woman was menstruating. Gordon raised his eyebrows, attempted to correct the statements, but then nodded calmly, like a teacher who had accidentally validated what was said.

“Yes, good that you are thinking about these things. Your teacher will return to this later.”

Then a boy raised his hand and announced triumphantly,

“My big brother once blew up a condom like a balloon.”

“Thank you for sharing,” Gordon had replied, and spent the rest of the day wandering the staff room like a man who had seen a ghost. He had sighed deeply and told the others about the lesson, causing the break room to erupt in laughter.

After that, “Gordon’s human biology lesson” found its way onto the school bingo cards. The teacher training did not prepare for everything. Cash checked it off his own card. Three in a row already. If winning had been the point, he could have asked Kate to take off her bra and called bingo.

“Another topic? Something less predictable,” Pete asked the audience.

“Asteroid,” Dan shouted from the same table.

Pete chuckled. “I knew what to expect from the table of joy bringers, always suggesting the most uplifting topics.”

The audience laughed. It was true that people needed to talk about things other than the time loop and the asteroid, but it was also comforting to realize that others were just as stuck on them.

It resembled a collective obsession slowly sliding toward mass hysteria. What, in the end, was the difference between the two?

History offered examples where emotion did not remain a private experience, but spread from person to person like a virus. In the 1960s, in what was now known as Tanzania, schools were forced to close due to a laughter epidemic. In medieval Central Europe, people fell into dancing manias and danced themselves to death.

These were collective responses to situations where despair exceeded what any individual could process. At their core was the human need to give shape to chaos.

The same phenomenon had appeared more recently, when pandemics led people to obsessively follow global infection numbers on real-time websites, or when, during wars, advancing arrows on maps and rising casualty counts became part of a daily routine, as if they were claiming, in a grim echo of Lebensraum, space within the mind.

It was about turning the uncontrollable into something manageable. When the unknown took the form of a number, a map, or a story, it created order out of chaos. That was why rituals and repetition were so powerful. What could not be understood became emotion, and emotion had to be spoken and released. Otherwise, it would continue looping endlessly, as the time loop itself.

“What do a teacher and an asteroid have in common? They both burn out,” Pete snapped Cash back to the present.

The audience laughed, somewhat awkwardly. Burnout was a serious issue. And, strictly speaking, asteroids did not burn out. Pete was probably thinking of meteors.

Well, if the joke was improvised, it was not all that bad. And Cash had to hand it to Pete. It was brave to joke about something as taboo as mental health, especially as a principal.

There was something genuinely human about improvisation. But maybe Pete had prepared for predictable topics, and this joke was one of them. Stand up comedians rarely walked on stage without a rehearsed set.

That kind of thinking dulled the set, suggesting calculation and memorization rather than someone who was genuinely funny, even off stage. Cash had seen many stand up comedians in smaller venues openly break the fourth wall, admitting they were there to test new material. It felt as demystifying as watching a magician while already knowing how the trick worked.

But a performance was not built on surprise alone. People did not come to see magic tricks, but the human skill of performing them. How could even a non-living camera count as observation, causing the microscopic world to behave differently? It made no sense and gave just more ammunition to those who believed the world might be a simulation.

Cash guessed that, similar to magic, stand up was not just written content. It was also timing, rhythm, connection with the audience, and the performer’s burning desire to entertain. A person could know every punchline in advance and still laugh. Something was comforting, even safe, in repetition. Jokes were like songs.

“Who would survive a time loop better than teachers? Think about it. First and second-grade teachers. You teach the same things over and over, year after year. It is your own personal loop. Same age group, same curriculum, same letters, sounds, syllables, and words.”

The audience waited for the punchline until they realised none was coming.

“One student asked me last week, completely seriously, ‘Why does it feel like I have heard this before?’ And I had to look them in the eye and say, ‘Because you have. Because you have.’”

Cash understood the idea of repetition, but also understood why the audience chuckled instead of laughing. Pete recognized it as a cue to wrap up.

“The loop is just a normal workday for us. No matter how long we are here, we teach, we learn, and we always do our best. So let us raise a glass to ourselves, the true heroes of society. See you at work tomorrow, or well, later today.”

He waved his thanks and returned to his table to applause.

Kate raised her wine glass.

“That was more of a speech than a stand up set,” she said to their table.

Dan nodded. “Yeah. Better than last year. And shorter.”

“Maybe those two things are connected,” Kate said with a friendly grin.

Cash took a sip of wine. It was the only drink available. Red and white wine were scattered across the tables without much logic. For some reason, teacher events were always like this. Cash would have paid anything for a cold beer.

Dan leaned closer. “One student said something strange to me last week.”

Cash signalled he was listening with a nod and eye contact.

“They said we are all in heaven. That all previous days are just implanted memories, and this loop is a reflection of how we lived before. Like karma. If your loop is good, you were a good person. If it is bad, well, you really messed up.”

Kate frowned. “That is pretty cruel.”

Dan nodded. “Yeah. Not in those exact words, but basically. And it caused a real argument in class. Everyone knows someone who is doing badly in the loop. Someone who is sick, or someone who, well, you know.”

Cash swirled his wine.

“That’s a horrible thing to say to a child whose mother got stuck in the loop in the middle of cancer treatment.”

Dan sighed. “I know, right?”

Silence settled over the table for a moment.

Kate broke it first. “You know what? Pete could have joked about that.”

Cash glanced at her, raising his eyebrows. “Cancer?”

Kate rolled her eyes. “No. About no one drinking water between glasses of wine.”

“Guilt-free wine,” Cash said and nodded a few times. This much wine would hardly have been consumed on a normal Tuesday evening if people had to work with children the next day. Or maybe it had, many times before, but this at least made it easier on the conscience to use the words alcohol and children in the same sentence, which clashed like dissonant chords.

Dan laughed. “Yep. Pete is too correct for wine jokes.”

Kate replied, “So human biology jokes are correct?”

Dan chuckled. “By Pete’s standards, that was almost a roast.”

Kate nodded playfully. “Pete is lucky people like him here. Otherwise, he would probably have been fired over that. And that burnout joke, imagine if people didn’t know he was talking about himself.”

The table laughed. At the neighbouring table, one teacher turned to look at them, clearly wondering what they had missed.

Cash took another sip of wine and noticed an Iron Maiden shirt peeking out from under Dan’s blazer. The last time Cash had seen Dan, he had been wearing a Metallica shirt. Cash remembered from his own school days how liking both bands at once would have been social suicide. It was mandatory to choose a side. Maiden or Metallica. Those who chose wrong were still better off than those who liked both, who in the logic of teenage life practically deserved a beating. Cash laughed at how ridiculous it had been, and then realized his generation had never fully grown out of it. It was not allowed to change a favourite team. That would have been a sacrilege.

Dan’s wife was drinking wine faster than anyone else at the table.

“Do you know what Pete should have joked about?” she asked, clearly drunk.

Dan sighed in a way Cash had learned to recognize. In body language, it meant things were about to get a bit more uncomfortable.

She continued. “All this asteroid nonsense. I mean, really, it can’t be true. It’s a complete joke.”

Dan tensed. “It is not a joke, and I have said it a thousand times. We are not talking about this now.”

Cash did not know Dan's wife well, but had learned to classify her as a QAnon type, someone who years earlier had probably called 5G and wind turbines secret weapons systems. She had a way of presenting false claims with such confidence that they almost sounded believable.

Dan looked like he regretted opening his mouth. Now the entire table had turned to follow the exchange.

She tried to bring others to her side. "Use your brain. If such a huge asteroid was really coming, would we not see it already? Just think about it. Where is it?"

Cash glanced at Kate. She followed the conversation with interest, almost admiration. Kate had always said she respected Dan and his wife's relationship precisely because they argued so often and so openly.

"They love each other," she had once told Cash. "Everyone knows it. Who cares if they fight sometimes?"

Kate might have been right. They could wake up every night in the loop, resuming the same argument as the day before. But what if one day they went to sleep in the middle of a fight and woke up in the early morning engaged in reconciliation sex? That thought already felt intrusive and wrong.

Cash and his family were always asleep at the moment of reset. They never noticed the transition. But statistically, there had to be many people starting their day doing all sorts of things.

Dan looked at Cash without saying a word, his expression saying, here we go again.

"We just don't understand everything yet," Kate said. "About why this all happened. Maybe the universe had a reason for it."

She did not raise her voice or take sides. But the way she said it was like balm, calming both of them.

Kate had a way of making everyone feel at least a little right. It was probably not intentional or socially calculated. It was just how she saw the world. She believed in Langley's theories, but also believed they were only notes and chords in some larger composition that was playing in the background. Kate believed the universe had sent the cosmic string and slowed it down on purpose.

Dan’s wife looked at Kate, took another sip of wine, and said nothing more, which for her was almost an agreement.

The party continued around them. At some point, someone picked up a guitar. That was what happened when partying with teachers. Cash and Kate joined in singing “Save Tonight.”

Somewhere in the room, a countdown from ten to zero began, like on New Year’s Eve. They were not usually awake at this hour, but tonight they stayed up just long enough to feel the moment when the world folded back into its beginning.

A few hours later, they woke up in their own bed.

As always.

Chapter 1.19

Cash listened to a talk radio show as he biked toward the prison. What a strange coincidence that station 94.6 was airing a program on the same topic he was on his way to discuss with the warden of Vancouver Correctional Centre. CBC had already returned to a kind of normal life, where a journalist's work meant mostly solitary grinding. That was how more content was produced, and competition for people's attention was always fierce.

Three guests were speaking in the studio.

"This is not just about individuals," a Conservative Party representative said. "This is about how we protect society. If we release criminals before their sentences are served, we undermine public trust in justice."

"This isn't about pardons but reality," a firm female voice replied. "Time doesn't pass, so sentences don't expire. The punishment no longer matches what was originally imposed."

The third voice agreed with her. "True, punishment is based on its limits. When time stops, punishment turns into nothing more than storage. And storage without purpose isn't justice."

Vancouver Prison was located by the sea, but it was the opposite of Alcatraz. While the famous prison island isolated criminals away from society, this prison was placed right in the city centre. Cash was not sure what message that was meant to send. Was the idea that prisoners were still symbolically part of the community? Or was the punishment meant to be as visible as possible, a reminder to others of what happens when society's rules are broken?

Inside, pipes clanged, and metal doors slammed shut. From the gym came the sound of a weight hitting the floor. Cash saw prisoners nodding their heads in the music studio, as if approving whatever they had just recorded. He wondered if recording violin music in a place like this would have been social suicide. Probably.

Cash toured the facility with guard Bruce Markkula, a wide-shouldered man in his forties who told him he was a father of three.

"This has become a prison within a prison," Bruce said, "for both inmates and staff."

Bruce explained that there had been two alerts last night. One overdose and one case of self-harm with a razor blade. Knives were made from almost anything inside the prison. A former

employee had received a permanent shoulder injury from a plastic knife. Cash thought Bruce might be one of those people for whom horror had become so normal that he no longer knew how to filter his words for children.

“But still,” Bruce said, stopping on the stairs, “there are a lot of good people here. People who made bad choices at the wrong time. The kind who could be your neighbour and you would never guess they had been here. And then some do not belong in society. Maybe never.”

Bruce did not resemble the cruel guards from the Stanford prison experiment at all. That 1971 study had shown how quickly roles could change people. When students were assigned as guards and prisoners, the situation escalated so fast that the experiment had to be stopped after six days. The guards had begun to control the prisoners sadistically, even though they had never been instructed to do so.

Bruce was nothing like that. He was more like an older brother than a commanding ruler. He tried to preserve humanity on both sides of the bars.

“If you take a despotic attitude here, you will get yourself killed,” Bruce said. “The inmates will not tolerate it. I have seen it. Too close.”

Cash wondered in what kind of timeline he himself might have ended up in prison. Many of his choices had depended on the groups he had spent time with. If he had had different people around him, one mistake could have led to another. It was a frightening thought how unrecognizable that other version of himself might be, and yet in the end, it could still have been him.

Florence and Arabella were not yet at an age where Kate and he worried about their friends. But that time would come. On some level, Cash was already preparing for it because he had seen a nightmare about a prison visiting room, where the door opened and Arabella, as a young adult, walked in, escorted by a guard. He had never told Kate about the dream because she believed in prophetic dreams so firmly.

The walls of Warden Roger Heatley’s office were covered with photos of his family members. Cash wondered whether prisoners were ever summoned there like students called in to the principal’s office after breaking the rules. That happened often in films. But it seemed risky to

display personal photos to criminals who, after release, might fall into psychosis and see the warden as the root of all evil and remember those faces from the pictures.

Heatley explained the terms of the new model. Those convicted of non-violent crimes would be released every morning. For more serious offences, the cycle would be two days free every five days. Life sentence prisoners would remain outside the system.

“For some, it is a relief,” he said. “For others, it is torture. It reminds them of what they cannot have. This is not a perfect system, and one probably does not exist.”

The cell corridor brought up a surprisingly familiar image. It reminded Cash of school hallways and classrooms. He had heard school compared to prison from Florence’s classmates and had even seen the same opinion in the school’s Google reviews. It sounded ridiculous as an adult. But in all honesty, there were some similarities. Both systems had fixed schedules, pre-built routines, and supervised spaces. Meals and outdoor breaks were decided in advance. Breaking rules led to sanctions.

Historically, children were more right than they knew. The modern school system, compulsory education, and clock-regulated school days were originally designed for the needs of industrial society. Schools were places where children could be safely stored while parents worked. They became like an onboarding phase for factories, where job-specific skills were practised.

Over time, schools began to be described more beautifully as child-centred spaces of growth and learning. That was also true. A good teacher could change the direction of a life, and many teachers did their work with full hearts, as they had experienced with Florence.

Cash had always dismissed the prison comparison as a childish, generational mantra. But then again, a prisoner could just as well leave a Google review of a prison and write that the place was basically a school.

The most important difference between school and prison was direction. In school, people moved forward and prepared for freedom. In prison, punishment was the result of having used freedom in the wrong way. Both systems were designed to contain, create safety, and shape people who could function in society.

Cash promised himself that the next time a child called school a prison, he would not laugh. He would instead turn the Socratic questioning game he played with his daughters, but he would take the roles upside down, and take the child's role.

"School is just like prison."

"Why is school a prison?"

"Because you can't decide anything yourself."

"What would you want to decide?"

"When I get to go home."

"Why would you want to go home in the middle of the day?"

"Because there I can watch TV and just be."

"Why can't you do that at school?"

"Because there are lessons."

"Why are there lessons?"

"Because you have to learn things."

"Why do you have to learn things?"

"So you can get a job as an adult."

"Why do you need a job?"

"So you get paid."

"Why do you need to get paid?"

"So you can pay bills."

"Why do you have to pay bills?"

"So you don't go to prison."

Cash smiled to himself. The whole chain had returned to its starting point, from school back to prison. It captured how circular human thinking could be. Sometimes a wrong idea knocked over dominoes along one path, only to loop back around, like an ouroboros eating its own tail. It was hard to escape when the horizon showed only the next falling piece.

Sometimes, it took someone willing to step in and kick the next domino aside to break the chain entirely. The horizon did not reveal the whole pattern. Cash remembered his brother once explaining to a flat earther how horizons existed because the Earth was a globe. It was something

people could see, even if they did not recognise what they were looking at. Perhaps it was no different with the systems they built around themselves.

Every choice felt like another domino set in motion. Some paths were clearly easier to follow than others. There was something deeply sad about the prison system, yet Cash could not think of another way to uphold social order and safety than by punishing serious violations.

The alternative was unsafe anarchy. If ticket inspectors never appeared on trains, how many people would have still paid for their tickets out of pure moral duty? No, tickets were paid for because social shame had been made more expensive than the inspection fine.

Cash hoped he would remember never to dismiss a child's experience of boredom again, but instead help them find a domino path where boredom could be channelled into creativity.

Perhaps it was an evolutionary remnant that humans could not enjoy boredom. It had once been useful to stay constantly alert and in motion. But what kind of psychology would a human have developed if the species had lived in a loop for hundreds of thousands of years?

Instead of dismissing the prison comparison, Cash would ask the child what kind of prison they meant. Was it a Norwegian or Danish prison, or perhaps an American or Mexican one?

He came up with a new article idea, where prisoners would design their dream schools and students their dream prisons. Schools increasingly resembled corporate offices, and prisons resembled schools, with portfolios, course choices, and recess breaks. At the same time, offices had returned to eight-hour workdays and closed spaces instead of open plans, much like traditional schools. Each had experimented with openness, but people still needed a space of their own.

When Cash returned to the office, he began writing an article on a topic so sensitive that even forest fires would have avoided its dry tinder.

British Columbia Implements New Prison Release Model

Balancing Punishment and Humanity in a Time-Looped Prison System

Cash Haggerty | CBC | April 12

As the world grapples with the implications of the ongoing time loop, British Columbia has introduced a new policy aimed at addressing the unique challenges faced by incarcerated individuals. Under the new model, those convicted of non-violent offences are released every morning, reflecting the time already served outside the loop. For more serious offences, the cycle operates on a two-day release after every five days inside.

To improve public safety, releases are staggered in groups to prevent the simultaneous release of higher-risk offenders.

"This is not just about letting people out," said David Brenner, warden of Vancouver Correctional Centre. "It is not justice to pause lives indefinitely. We have a responsibility to recognize when sentences have already been served in the new reality."

The policy has received mixed reactions. Human rights advocates praise it as a necessary step toward fairness, while some members of the public express concern over potential safety risks.

Chapter 1.20

Arabella gave a crumpled sheet of paper pulled from the depths of her backpack, folded between clothes and a half-eaten granola bar.

On it was a cut-out image of a cruise ship, sailing through the bluest ocean. Beneath it, assembled from what must have been several newspapers, were the words:

I am a bark boat
I do not know whether the storm made me
or if I was pulled from a tree

It was absurdly profound. Cash got goosebumps and started almost crying. That did not happen often.

Creativity is deliberate imitation, Voltaire had said. A collage like this required synthesis. Selection. Arrangement. An eye for resonance. How had Arabella found words that leaned so perfectly into one another?

And yet she clearly did not consider it a masterpiece. The paper had been crumpled without hesitation and stuffed into her bag.

“How did you choose these words?” Cash asked.

“With scissors,” Arabella replied.

It was technically very accurate, but it made him think of the role the teacher had played. Perhaps you had to choose one paper from each box, and those would eventually match with each other. Smart idea. Or maybe Arabella had chosen the words she liked, and the teacher had guided the layout.

Arabella knew how to read and write, mostly her own name, which was already impressive for her age. The aphorism would have been striking even if it was written by one of the adults at the kindergarten.

She then announced that her friend Lottie was going to have a baby brother.

Cash hesitated. He did not know how to explain that time did not work the same anymore. He had not given it too much time to think that some women experienced the first trimester nausea every single day without ever starting the second trimester. That felt cruel.

It was an interesting decision for a parent to tell a child something like that so early. The pregnancy must have been well along. Who knows, maybe Lottie had become worried about her Mom, and they had explained that oh sweetie, this is the best thing in the world, nothing to worry about.

In an ordinary year, there were around 105 to 106 boys born for every 100 girls. The ratio shifted. When times are hard, the proportion of girls rose. It appeared that male embryos did not survive as well in times of crisis. A good example was the study suggesting that the election of an extreme conservative president in the United States had coincided with a drop in male births in liberal neighbourhoods in Canada, but not in conservative ones.

And what if conception itself unfolded within a kind of time loop, as probably it always did somewhere? The thought of an embryo that existed for a moment and then vanished would have posed difficult questions for theologians and philosophers.

Cash wasn't sure whether it would even have been called an embryo or whether the correct term was zygote. What he mostly remembered was how, with every week of pregnancy, they had tracked the comparisons to fruits and vegetables, just like everyone else. You didn't even have to ask how far along someone was. It was enough to ask which fruit or vegetable their baby was.

"Lottie will become a great sister," Cash said lightly.

"She's only four. Silly Daddy."

Perhaps Arabella was thinking of her great-grandmother, whom she had only seen in photographs. Or perhaps she believed four was too young to become an older sibling, even though Florence had been even younger when she became one. It was all too funny to correct her.

"That's amazing, Arabella!" Florence arrived at the table, examined Arabella's work, and hugged her little sister with theatrical pride.

"Can I make one too?" she asked.

"Of course. Wait. Do we even have magazines?"

The No Flyers sticker on the front door, a small moral stance against waste and unsolicited capitalism, now complicated the creative process. Cash searched through their drawers and shelves until he found an old newspaper. It happened to contain the first article he had ever written, so it had sentimental value.

But old newspapers, unlike bark boat art pieces, were meant to last in the time loop reality. By tomorrow, it would likely return to its original form. And if it did not and it remained torn because the world had entered the following day, well, that seemed like a fair trade.

Florence worked with fierce concentration, tongue slightly out, carefully selecting words.

Her finished piece read:

I am open bottle
I hiss
hey why did you drink me empty

It was strange but very coherent. A hamburger meal advertisement was glued beside the text. The result looked like the most avant-garde fast food campaign Cash had ever seen.

In an art museum, some confident interpreter might declare that the artist was dismantling late consumer culture, that the hiss signalled animalistic protest rather than carbonation.

“Deeply unsettling,” one visitor might say, holding a glass of champagne.

Cash studied the two collages on the table. One questioned whether it had been shaped by storm or intention. The other demanded to know why it had been emptied. Origins and appetite. Fate and consumption.

He had once heard that success was where hard work met opportunity. When the why outgrew the what, the how would follow. Perhaps success was simpler than that. Two sheets of cut paper and the smell of glue drying on the dining room table.

Arabella told, almost as an afterthought, that her friend Elvis had a diaper eating box at home. The way her mind jumped from one topic to the next seemed completely random, though maybe Cash was not much different.

“That’s not very realistic, or is it, Daddy?” Florence asked.

Cash smiled. Florence had an astonishing vocabulary. She read everything she could find. Once, after finishing her own stack of books, she had moved on to Kate's university text, *Educational Psychology* by Anita Woolfolk. They had never quite managed to spark the same hunger in Arabella.

"I think Elvis means they have a Diaper Genie," Cash said.

"An actual genie with a diaper? You have three wishes, and look, I have diapers." Florence burst out laughing.

Arabella followed, unable to stop herself.

The truth was that neither of them had ever seen a Diaper Genie. They had grown up with cloth diapers.

Cash had come to believe that every household with children carried its own private anxiety. In some homes, it was allergies. In others, it was blue light, pollen counts, air quality, or sugar. In theirs, it had been microplastics.

The decision had begun with an article he and Kate read one evening. Plastic had reached the Mariana Trench, nearly eleven kilometres down. Creatures had evolved there without sunlight, in pressure that would crush a submarine. And still, even there, there was a plastic grocery bag.

Many had heard the warning that, if trends continued, the oceans might contain more plastic than fish by 2050. It sounded like dystopian science fiction. But the unsettling part was not the headline. It was the fact that it was impossible to compare children with microplastics in their blood to a control group, because the control group no longer existed. No child was raised in a parallel, plastic-free environment. Everybody was already part of the experiment.

When Bakelite was introduced as the material of the future in the early twentieth century, it was praised for its indestructibility. Cash sometimes wondered whether anyone had asked the obvious follow-up question about how long.

During their recent holiday in France, he had noticed how fruit and vegetables were sold loose and never in plastic wrapping. In Canada, people felt virtuous for bringing canvas bags, even though they could not even have bought a plastic one from the cashier, even if they tried. Of course, he and Kate knew their choices did nothing to cleanse the Pacific. Still, it had felt like a moral decision with a slightly arrogant pride in doing things more righteously. But perhaps the

gesture had been symbolic from the beginning, like bringing a canvas bag to the supermarket while filling it with meat wrapped in plastic.

As the girls grew older, that anxiety had receded, and they had not talked about the whole topic in years. Young parenthood was good at distorting scale. Walking past someone smoking could feel like an irreversible mistake, even if the exposure was barely anything. The danger was real, but so was its magnification in an exhausted mind.

It was almost as if the Voyager spacecraft, launched in 1977 with whale songs, music, and greetings in different languages, should have included a warning for the aliens that it contained polyethylene. Well, maybe not quite like that, Cash chuckled to himself.

Chapter 1.21

On many mornings, Cash had wondered why people saw different dreams inside the loop, even though everything else repeated while awake. How could the dream world keep producing something new each night? It would have made more sense if Cash had woken up each morning remembering the same dream, but that was not the case for anybody.

Dreams were often described as a washing machine for the previous day's memories, separating what mattered from what did not. But by now, that washing machine should have finished running its April 11 program. Yet fragments of loop events still surfaced, as if memory was not sealed off from the dream state.

It made no sense. If the day repeated perfectly, then anything learned inside it should be locked to waking life and not bleed into sleep. But then again, there were hours each night when he was asleep while the loop had already reset. Who knows, maybe it was during those hours that experiences from previous loops were carried into the next, and dreams were where they surfaced.

Sleep could also simply be just an evolutionary leftover, something that had once been too useful in human history to disappear, and that now kept spinning like a record player without a record. But there had to be another reason. Why else would a species agree to spend a third of its life completely defenceless?

According to social simulation theory, dreams had originally been a way to practise social interactions, recognize threats, and process unexpected behaviour from others. But if that was true, someone could have similarly argued that the loop was a practice environment for these same things. Maybe.

While turning these thoughts over, Cash and Kate went to see a theatre performance called *Past Me* with Samantha and Clark. Cash's parents had come to Vancouver for the evening to look after the girls so the adults could enjoy a night of culture. The local newspaper had praised the play as a bold and honest interpretation of the present moment.

The performance began in an almost artificial everyday tone, but about forty-five minutes in, Cash realized he was completely invested in it.

A living room had been built on stage, where a couple was getting ready for a party held in honour of the main character's friend, who had just completed a successful company sale. In earlier scenes, it had been revealed that the main character had lost his memory in a car accident. His last clear memories were from when he had still been a psychology master's student. Since then, he had completed a doctorate that he remembered nothing about.

That was why he hated being called Doctor. It triggered impostor syndrome, but Cash was not convinced the term was used correctly in the play. Amnesia caused a legitimate knowledge gap. Then again, no one would have understood what the screenwriter meant if they had started inventing terms, and perhaps there was no better word for self-doubt.

The protagonist had written his dissertation at a neurotechnology start-up in Silicon Valley called Membery. The company developed methods to support memory activation for patients with trauma and memory disorders, using individual sensory cues to trigger memories. The method resembled how music brought back forgotten memories for people with dementia.

The car accident and the protagonist's past were never shown directly. Instead, clues were slowly revealed through dialogue with those close to him.

PROTAGONIST: People talk a lot these days about three-dimensional movies, 3D. But that doesn't really exist. 3D is always 4D, because time comes with it. A moving image without time would just be a photograph. I've lived in four dimensions, but without the first three. Only time has passed.

GIRLFRIEND: It's nice how we are once again talking about completely different things. What should I wear tonight? I'm seriously not going anywhere if you don't help me.

PROTAGONIST: You have tons of clothes. Wear the white dress.

GIRLFRIEND: Why? Explain.

PROTAGONIST: It just fits. But it's kind of ironic that.

GIRLFRIEND: You don't care at all what I wear. And I can't wear that one, I wore it two years ago.

PROTAGONIST: How would I have remembered that?

WOMAN: Don't be naive.

PROTAGONIST: Yeah, it's kind of ironic that all that work with memory, and then this happens to me. Someone else earned my qualifications. A blind person could study the retina just as well as I could.

WOMAN: Stop it. There are more important things to think about right now, and you are not helping at all. Honestly, I'm about to cry.

PROTAGONIST: What about the blue one?

WOMAN: Awful.

PROTAGONIST: The black one with the open back?

WOMAN: Now you're just throwing things out there. You're not thinking at all.

PROTAGONIST: Then let's not go at all.

WOMAN: Yeah, you probably wouldn't even want me to come.

Cash thought he heard irritation and awkward, recognition-based laughter in the audience. There were surely many couples among them.

Cash wondered what kind of communication they themselves were capable of, and what kind they sometimes fell into. It was probably normal that during arguments, the other person's style felt provoking. According to Kate, Cash sounded arrogant and all-knowing. In Cash's view, Kate sometimes became angry simply because Cash disagreed.

Soft music began to play on the stage, which was still set as an apartment. The party guests entered, exchanged polite glances, and moved toward the kitchen area built at the side of the stage.

Soon, two figures remained at the centre. The male protagonist and another man, who represented his friend hosting the party, stood by the kitchen island, red cups in their hands.

FRIEND: Have you ever thought that your idea of how much you have taken a step back, as you put it, might be distorted? To me, you are the same person I have known for years. When people tell stories, hardly anyone remembers things exactly as they happened. Truth in stories is an approximation, especially when we talk about events from years ago.

Cash heard the line as if someone had written it for him. He was impressed by the play's psychological approach, even though to some it would surely feel like unnecessary rambling.

PROTAGONIST: I get your point. But people only tell things that I could put on my CV. A kind of protective censorship. And the fact that it's all so good that I hear makes me even more bitter about who I was and what I lost. Maybe I should dig deeper into the time I can't remember. It feels like a lack of memory weighs more than a heavy memory. You squeeze your eyes shut and try to remember, but the mind gives you nothing.

FRIEND: Not everything needs to be remembered. I would love to forget certain things.

PROTAGONIST: That is easy to say, but if I gave you a pill that made you forget something specific, would you take it? Would it not bother you not knowing what you decided to forget afterwards? The past defines us more than what we are to become.

The man left the party with the woman from the opening scene. The characters disappeared into the curtains, and the lights dimmed. A white screen rolled down. The man's voice was still heard, but now through a small recorder, clearly suggesting the audience was listening to a phone call. Live footage appeared on the screen of someone typing a number sequence into a phone from memory. The line rang, and someone answered.

PROTAGONIST: If a tree falls in a forest with no witnesses, did it really fall? If things happened to me who no longer exists, did they really happen to me?

Then the girlfriend from the first scene emerged from the curtain, with the protagonist following her. Slowly, the distance between them grew. The man's steps were slower, the woman's determined and fast.

It was an artistic but beautifully simple illustration of how people drifted apart. They found new priorities and less time for each other. It felt theatrical, but natural.

UNKNOWN FEMALE VOICE: Um, I think you might have called the wrong number.

PROTAGONIST: I know, but don't hang up yet. I'm not selling anything. I'm just asking, how do I know people are telling the truth when they describe who I have been in recent years? How do I know they aren't consciously trying to fix something in me now that they have a chance? They might say 'oh you used to do this so well' and think that I somehow want to act the same way as the me, who they lost and who they've put on a pedestal. They say they want to help, but really, they want to change me.

There was a long pause, but the audience could still see the seconds ticking on the call, showing the line had not been disconnected.

PROTAGONIST: I have started to fear that my entire life is just a series of other people's versions of who I supposedly am. If I don't remember something and someone else does, my self-image depends on someone else's idea of who I was. If I want to believe I was a good person, but someone else claims otherwise, who do I believe?

Another pause followed, which felt like at least ten seconds. Perhaps this was a way for the director to stretch the length of the performance, like a student trying to reach a minimum word count by writing long like David Foster Wallace. Well, that did not make any sense, Cash admitted. First of all, silence created pressure and, in its own way, resembled the saying that a picture is worth more than a thousand words. Similarly, silence could be more powerful than the words that might have filled that time. And secondly, it was not long ago that Cash had read Wallace's brick-thick novel *Infinite Jest*. It had felt like a trip abroad.

Writers everywhere liked to repeat that old commandment about killing your darlings. It was expected to cut what the writer was personally attached to. But in Wallace's case, he seemed excellent at instead loving his darlings, letting them stay in his house, grow old, and demand more space. That kind of writing was hard, but when done right and consciously, it was what separated a genius from a copywriter.

The call continued.

PROTAGONIST: A lie takes root in the mind. Over time, it grows into truth. The whole world is built on narratives, and I'm afraid my narrative isn't in my hands anymore. I'm going to collect the memories I have lost. I'm going to relearn the things I forgot. Experience the things I experienced. Maybe I can build my new self from those pieces.

UNKNOWN FEMALE VOICE: I don't know what else to say except that you should dare to seek help from someone who knows what to say.

The two characters disappeared into the curtains, and the lights in the audience came up for intermission. People stood from their seats quietly and confused. Many said nothing at all. In the hallways, conversation slowly returned.

Then Cash heard Samantha say out loud that she would not have listened to a stranger's monologue for even a second and would have hung up immediately. Kate agreed.

"I really don't get how this play relates to the time loop," Clark said.

"It probably doesn't. At least not directly," Kate smiled.

Cash thought he might be the only one in the group who had truly enjoyed the play's layered and deep interpretation.

"Maybe it asks who we are if we don't remember ourselves. A lot of people have probably lost themselves in the loop. To me, this is mostly about mental health, and how the rest of society tends to dismiss it," he said aloud.

Everyone nodded in agreement. Mental health was still a word that sounded out of place in a man's mouth.

The play was not just about memory loss and identity, but about how difficult it was for men to express pain. When emotions other than happiness or anger began to leak through, they made a person vulnerable in a way that frightened not only others but the man himself.

Cash realized he had drifted into his thoughts while the others had already moved on to a completely different topic. He would have been in trouble if he had noticed voices rising and eyes turning toward him. Luckily, no one tested his listening skills, and he managed to rejoin the conversation.

In the second half, the protagonist realized he had become so fixated on a past he could not remember that he could no longer see what he still had. The first half had explored the first four stages of grief, and the second half focused hard on acceptance.

In the final scene, the protagonist sat on a therapy couch, facing a therapist whose face was replaced by a mirror. He turned his gaze toward the audience and openly broke the fourth wall. It was not a side glance in any way. No, it was deliberate and intense. He stood up and stepped toward the front row. He said he had understood that perfect recollection of things was no longer something he aimed for. If his memory returned, that would be great, but if not, that was enough too.

He asked the audience how many memories a person ultimately kept from a single year once decades had passed. No one answered, and the uncomfortably long silence was clearly meant to

allow time for thought.

The mirror-faced therapist sitting still on a chair reminded Cash of a quote by theatre director Bertolt Brecht, who had fled Nazi Germany:

“Art is not a mirror to reflect reality, but a hammer with which to shape it.”

That was exactly it. But fewer people recognized the hammers used on them. The most effective propaganda did not look like propaganda at all. Everyone recognized ridiculous caricatures, like Russian state news showing the president fishing with his bare hands or riding a white horse shirtless, or North Korean stories about a perfect round of golf.

But fewer people stopped to ask why they did not see similar things in their own country. Or why the suffering of another nation did not provoke the same reaction as that of their own population. That meant the hammer might already have done its work.

The protagonist on stage continued.

A person’s past was like history. It was nice to study, but it did not carry beyond today. Today defined tomorrow. A mistake made in a fraction of a second could collapse a house of cards built over years. Even in a time loop, the present did not forgive yesterday’s sins.

The thought was both empowering and crushing. Right now was everything, and right now could destroy what you had built your entire life.

The protagonist said that even if something was not remembered, it did not make it worthless. That was very true. Children did not remember their first years of life either, yet parents still created experiences for them, built safety and comfort. Love was not given so that it would be remembered, but because it was unconditionally true.

Cash thought of Florence and Arabella. They would probably not remember most of what was shared now. They would not remember comforting words at night or how many times their cheeks had been kissed before sleep. That did not make those moments any less meaningful. Still, Cash could not help wishing they would remember as much of their childhood as possible, and that he himself could bottle completely ordinary, joyful evenings into permanent memory.

The ending of the play was thought-provoking, but Cash found himself thinking it was a little too hopeful. A more realistic solution would have felt more believable. He imagined an alternative ending where the protagonist would have stored a memory implant of himself during his student

years in the company's warehouse and now faced an ethical dilemma. Would he commit suicide of the self and let his former version take over again? Or what if the car accident had been intentional, and two versions of the self had begun negotiating over who would continue living the life? Well, that would have been an original plot.

But the repetition of the same answers from everyone around the protagonist made Cash think about the power of repetition. It worked like a mantra. At some point, the protagonist began to believe it. It was like how much money had to be spent on marketing before someone chose oat milk over cow's milk. Cow's milk had long felt safe because it was familiar. But that had not always been true. There had been a moment in history when people decided to try milk from another animal. Yet if someone suggested drinking pig's milk or horse's milk, the idea would have felt disgusting. Familiarity mattered more than reason or taste. If that was true for milk, why not for identity?

Performing the Same Night Again

What Theatre Actors Can Teach a World Stuck on April 12

Cash Haggerty | CBC | April 12

CBC News attended a recent performance of *Past Me* at Vancouver's Scotiabank Theatre, where a contemporary production about memory loss and identity is drawing an unexpectedly broad audience.

The play follows a man who loses his memory in a car accident and struggles to reconcile who he was with who others say he has become. Through fragmented conversations and shifting perspectives, the story explores how memory shapes identity and how much of the self depends on other people's versions of the past.

Director Carla Mendes said she did not expect the production to reach beyond a typical contemporary theatre audience.

"Usually, plays like this attract a fairly specific crowd. But we are seeing people of all ages and backgrounds. Social media has played a role in that." Mendes explained.

Mendes pointed to the growing influence of #PlayTok, where users share theatre recommendations on platforms like TikTok, helping productions reach new audiences.

Mendes described how the recent surge in attendance is a new development, noting the theatre stands apart from many professions because its reliance on repetition has left it largely unchanged since the start of the time loop.

Before opening night, performers rehearse scenes dozens of times, refining timing and delivery. That repetition, she said, creates the conditions for variation.

Actor Constantin Popescu, who plays the lead role, said that while the script remains the same, each performance evolves in response to the audience.

"Sometimes you emphasize one word differently, and it changes completely how the audience responds," he said.

Even when the story is similar each night, the experience is never identical.

Chapter 1.22

Cash walked through Gastown, weaving past tourists gathered around the steam clock. Despite the loop, they still showed up, as always, waiting for the familiar burst of steam and the mechanical chime of Westminster Quarters that rang every hour. Cash wondered how many of them were stuck in the city because of the loop, and how many had just arrived. The latter seemed more likely. Who would want to be a tourist in a world where being a tourist was not a choice?

He slowed his pace as the clock hissed, releasing white steam into the air like the Vatican's white smoke after the election of a new pope. People raised their phones almost instinctively to capture the moment. Cash did not understand that. Then again, he had never understood Snapchat either, which had grown into a billion-dollar business built on the idea that disposable content would not last more than a day.

In the same way that Cash wondered at tourists with their cameras, they might have wondered why Cash was lining up for lunch at a brewery restaurant just to get a free beer. When money no longer carried the same meaning as before, the price of a pint was, of course, only symbolic.

The idea of limited supply triggered something primal. It was not about price, but about availability. When people lined up for a free beer, that beer gained more value than one you paid for.

The phenomenon was not new. Even before the loop, people had waited for hours outside stores just to get something for free. The herd animal waited patiently, knowing it made no sense. The waiting itself made the reward feel more desirable.

First, the customer needed to order lunch. It could have been a clever marketing trick. Cash had once bought a new leather jacket for one dollar after buying leather gloves for sixty. Creative ways of getting the masses moving were worth appreciating. That was why he was here now. One of the sheep in his own flock, a more negative critic might have said.

There were few seats, so guests sat down next to strangers as places became available. No one seemed to mind not being able to choose their seat. It created a sense of shared experience, as if everyone was in the same uncertain boat, like on the first day of school.

Cash found himself sitting next to a bearded, broad shouldered man. The bartender poured him a beer without asking, and the citrus scent of a strong IPA rose with the foam. Judging by its deep amber colour, it was exactly the kind of beer lager lovers would never understand.

The man raised his glass to Cash. “You should have come earlier. The best ones usually run out before noon.”

Cash took a sip. It had to be a triple IPA, the kind that would normally be far too strong to enjoy, especially during a workday.

“I used to build houses. Apartment buildings. Entire blocks. I spent twenty years believing I was creating something permanent.” He turned the glass slowly in his fingers. “Now? No one needs a new house when they wake up in the same bed every morning.”

“Do you still work?” Cash asked.

The man shrugged. “Small repairs. Roofs. Faucets. But it’s not the same. No foundations. No blueprints.” He drank slowly, clearly not enjoying the beer he had come for.

“What will you do when the loop ends?”

The man stared at his drink, as if searching for the answer inside it.

“I’ll start building again,” he said finally. “And start living a life that means something. I won’t fix things that will be broken again tomorrow.”

The food arrived. It was toast fried in egg and butter, filled with cheese and Korean kimchi. The lack of choice and customer service was uncharacteristically Canadian, but refreshing. It reminded Cash more of Eastern European restaurants, where the customer was not always right, and certainly not above the staff.

Cash wondered if the place was popular precisely because customers did not have to make choices, like in childhood, when he had asked what was for dinner and the answer had simply been “good.” There was something deeply maternal or paternal about the restaurant. Those who wanted something fancy ate elsewhere. There were plenty of people in line ready to fill an empty seat.

The daily lunch changed every day. It was simple food, the kind Cash used to make when he was younger, before passing out after a long night at the bar, already dreading the pounding head and desert dry mouth of the morning. Now the loop had wiped that away completely, unless drinking

was started way too early, like now, already at lunch. Of course, if someone woke up with acetaldehyde twisting their stomach at the start of the loop, they would also wake up with them like that every morning. Did alcohol induced regret fade when you knew the hangover was not deserved at all?

Cash realized his thoughts had wandered down branching paths that someone else would have pruned long ago. His thinking was like old family trees, back when they did not grow only straight upward, but curved downward and sideways as well.

The construction worker tore off a piece of toast and examined it. “Everything has a beginning and an end. This bread. This time phenomenon. It has to have a foundation that sinks millimetre by millimetre, until one day it just collapses.”

Cash nodded. He was not sure whether the man was talking about the loop because of his work or because of his mental health. Men probably had things to learn in both areas.

“Physicists agree with that completely. Studies are showing that the loop’s area of influence has been slowly but steadily shrinking, which likely means it will end.”

The man nodded with satisfaction. “You read the same article I did. That’s very good news.”

The bartender rang a bell to signal that the last keg was empty. Those waiting outside sighed and drifted away. Some of them would probably try their luck again tomorrow.

Cash wiped his mouth with a napkin and stood up. “Thanks for the company. I need to get back to work.”

“Maybe we’ll see each other tomorrow,” the man said, raising his glass.

Outside, the steam clock hissed again. In the clock’s reality, nothing had changed, as its hour and minute hands kept moving forward like waves endlessly crashing against a rocky shore.

Cash’s phone vibrated in his pocket. It was Langley. He answered while walking. “Hi, Langley. How’s it going?”

Langley did not waste time on pleasantries.

“We’ve timed the rate at which the loop is breaking down. We have an estimate.”

Cash stopped mid-step, like a man whose working memory could not handle movement and conversation at the same time. “Are you serious?”

“We’re publishing it now. If the calculations hold, the loop will end in the year 2032.”

Cash felt a wave of relief. A measured timeline was easier to wait for when you roughly knew when it would arrive. Langley talked about data points and observation models, but Cash's thoughts drifted again to the year 2032, and how it was the same year as the predicted asteroid flyby.

Cash walked straight into Chris's office, feeling slightly guilty about the faint trace of alcohol in his speech and movements. Chris was typing when he looked up at Cash and silently gestured for him to come in.

"Spit it out," Chris said.

Cash sat down across from Chris's desk. "Langley Atwood's team released their results. The loop is predicted to end in 2032."

Chris leaned back and let out a low whistle. "Couldn't have landed better."

Cash looked at him. "It could have. It could have been tomorrow."

"Or a hundred years from now. Or never. But this?" Chris spread his hands. "This is a headline. The asteroid year. This will get all the clicks."

He stood up and patted Cash on the shoulder. "We publish immediately. No existential fluff. Just facts. We need to be first."

Cash nodded and pulled out his phone. He sent Langley a message with last-minute details. A headline formed on the screen:

The Countdown to the End of Infinity Begins.

Someone might change it. Or not. It was no longer in his hands.

Researchers Predict the Loop Will End in 2032

University of British Columbia physicists publish data based estimate of the end of the time loop

Cash Haggerty | CBC | April 12

Physicists at the University of British Columbia have published a groundbreaking report suggesting that the global time loop, which has kept the world stuck on April 12, is likely to end in the second half of the year 2032.

The prediction is based on subtle irregularities observed in Earth's magnetic fields and atmospheric pressure, which have been monitored for several years. The research was led by Dr Langley Atwood, a professor of physics, who says the signals indicate that the structure of the loop has already begun to weaken.

"This is not a single hypothesis, but the result of extensive measurements and analysis," Atwood told CBC. "There are signs that the boundary structures of the loop are changing, which points to a possible collapse in the near future."

The report has sparked hope around the world. It has offered the possibility of a future where time once again moves forward.

Chapter 1.23

Cash listened to a popular social affairs podcast about how the message of the neo-saviour anarchist movement had changed.

At first, their message had been vague or at least extremely abstract, blaming the time loop on a conscious universe. Now their youthful anger had turned toward something far more concrete and traditional, the government.

Cash recognized the interviewee as the same person he had spoken to for his first article about the loop. Back then, they had called themselves peaceful protesters. Now their actions had taken on more violent traits. Had endless partying started to lose its meaning, leaving behind only frustration that needed an outlet in the destruction of government buildings? Or perhaps the idea of the best day of your life had come to mean exactly that.

As he cycled past an Orthodox church, Cash's thoughts drifted to faith. Religions had maintained a strong position in the midst of chaos. The asteroid had only strengthened it. Before the loop, around 80 percent of the world's population identified as religious. Now the number was closer to 90 percent. Faith thrived in uncertainty, and the loop was uncertainty itself.

Not all states had collapsed into chaos. Some saw the loop as an opportunity. The Netherlands was the first country to create a new social contract that did not try to break the loop, but instead aimed to live within its limits. If nothing could be built for tomorrow, meaning had to be found in today.

Cash pictured Jari in Amsterdam collecting his daily loop income with the calm efficiency of a man who had fully embraced Dutch administrative philosophy. Jari probably followed the same routine every morning. Cycle to the municipal office, collect the payment, and eat a sandwich for lunch by the canal. If time insisted on repeating itself, the least a person could do was to repeat it properly.

To an outsider, building a society without a tomorrow might have seemed strange. But the results spoke for themselves. The absence of a future only strengthened the value of today.

The Netherlands was one of the countries most threatened by rising sea levels. Someone may have said that the time loop had extended its lifespan. Cash knew that was a terrible way to frame it. Saying the loop had saved the Dutch felt about as insensitive as claiming the climate crisis was good for some places because the weather had become nicer.

Universal loop day rights were built around the idea that work was a choice, but not an obligation as long as the day kept repeating. To an outsider, building a society without a tomorrow might have seemed absurd. But the results spoke for themselves. The absence of a future did not reduce the value of the day. It strengthened it.

Why had the Neo saviours not embraced such a vision? Why did they prefer to accuse decision makers of secrecy and keeping people in the dark?

Totalitarian regimes had chosen another path. In them, efficiency was the highest value. Every new morning offered a chance to refine data and processes further. Material production only a tool, never the goal. Before the loop, an hour-long production halt could cost millions. Now it did not matter. When time always reset to the same point, factories could test, fail, and try again. The real goal was optimisation, now possible without economic risk. Entire production systems were being prepared for the time after the loop, when states planned to launch ahead of others like rockets.

According to unconfirmed reports, so called disruptive individuals were removed from surveillance societies before they could cause trouble. Since every day reset, no lasting consequences remained. During states of emergency, the accused were not heard and no trials were held. Human rights organisations tried to make violations visible, but every new morning wiped away the evidence like chalk from a board. How could oppression be resisted when actions disappeared the moment they happened, and the state controlled what evidence could even be published?

In countries where survival had always been uncertain, the loop was just one crisis among others. Daily redistribution of resources ensured that food, medicine, and clean water were reassigned every morning. Some governments were democratic, others corrupt, but they shared the same reality. For their people, tomorrow had never been guaranteed.

In Canada, Bill C 104 was moving through Parliament. Its aim was to bring order for those who believed crimes had lost their punishability. They asked how murder could still be murder if the victim woke up alive the next morning. The law ended in a compromise, classifying murders committed during the loop as attempted murder.

Canada was also trading its white gloves for hockey gloves, raising its elbows toward criminals. Crimes committed in previous loops were recorded again each day, so that justice could happen eventually, even if delayed.

Bill C 104 was proof that people still believed in consequences and life after the loop. But what if Langley was wrong, and there was nothing after it?

Cash thought of Nietzsche, who wrote that if a person had to live their life over and over again, they should live it in a way they would gladly repeat forever. Even if the loop were endless, every choice still mattered. If this was his eternity, was he living a life he would choose again?

He snapped back to the present while cycling, realising he had not listened at all to the exchange between the New Saviour youth and the podcast host. He dismounted in front of the Stanley Park brewery restaurant. Nearby stood a group of Groundhoggers wearing matching clothes. It was an interesting detail. Where had they printed them before arriving at the park? A message was taken more seriously when its carrier looked like they belonged to something. You might give your personal details to a promotional worker wearing a company logo. Without it, the act felt like criminal data harvesting.

One of them called out to passers by.

“We must become worthy of tomorrow.”

Cash stopped. The moment was too good to ignore. He started recording on his phone, introduced himself, and asked if he could do a short interview. A charismatic man in his early thirties named Elias stepped forward.

“Let’s start with the core question,” Cash said. “Your movement claims the loop is a moral test. You say time continues only when we are collectively ready. But who defines readiness?”

“No one,” Elias replied. “Morality cannot be outsourced. Not to institutions, not to leaders. Everyone has an inner measure no one else can read. When people stop acting against

themselves, when they live out their true purpose, the loop ends. No single person decides it. It requires a collective shift in moral frequency."

"That sounds beautiful," Cash said. "But how do you define that frequency? How do you measure who is living their purpose and who is not?"

"It shows in the state of society," Elias answered. "War, exploitation, loneliness, inequality. These are symptoms of not yet facing ourselves honestly. The loop gives us a chance to relearn. It is merciful because it gives us unlimited repetitions."

"Merciful?" Cash raised his eyebrows. "Is it merciful that the same people's hearts fail every day, and their children watch their parents die again and again? How is that mercy?"

"The journey indeed tests us," Elias said. "Otherwise, this would be easy. But we should not see this as punishment. This is an opportunity for humanity to wake up to a better world."

"Or is this just a new story that divides the world into the awakened and the unawakened?" Cash asked. "What if someone does not believe there is any test at all?"

Elias took a breath. "This is not about belief. From birth, we all have a moral compass. Neuropsychology is only beginning to understand it. When a person acts in line with their ethical core, they can feel it in their body."

Cash watched him for a moment.

"I'm not familiar with that research," he said. "I'm sure you have the receipts."

"Always." Elias answered.

Cash unlocked his phone and held it out.

"Go on."

Elias took it. A few seconds passed.

"Here," he said. "The ventromedial prefrontal cortex. The vmPFC."

He looked up.

"I remember reading about this. When this area is impaired, people make worse moral decisions. That suggests there is a centre for it. A place where we know what is right."

Cash took the phone and read the summary of the study.

"This does not say what you think it says." He spoke.

Elias frowned. "It explicitly shows moral behaviour breaks down."

“It shows decision making breaks down. This region blends emotion and reasoning. When it is damaged, that balance fails.” Cash said.

Elias crossed his arms. “You are reducing it.”

For a second Cash wondered if this issue was worth flattening something Elias cared about. Was there even a clean line between being precise and talking over someone for no real reason?

“I am separating what the study shows from what you want it to show,” he said.

“Wait,” Elias said, already reaching for the phone again. “I remember another one.”

Cash gave the phone back.

Elias typed again.

“Awareness of internal bodily signals. Heart rate, tension, that feeling. People who are more aware of these signals make more consistent moral decisions. That’s it. The alignment I was talking about. You feel in your body when something is right or wrong.”

Cash took back the phone to read the study.

“See,” Elias added. “Science is finally catching up.”

“But look at this next line,” Cash said after only a few seconds of reading the summary.

“Alignment with social norms and stronger conformity in moral judgement,” Elias read as asked.

“Yes, it says people who are more tuned into their bodies are more likely to align with what their group considers acceptable,” Cash said.

“That is precisely the moral compass I’ve been trying to explain to you. It may be expressed collectively, but it’s in here.” Elias brought his hand above his heart.

“If there was one moral truth, would it really shift with the group? Because that’s what this study is about.” Cash explained.

Elias said nothing.

“It would not lead to different answers depending on where you were born, who you grew up around, or what you were taught to value.” Cash continued.

“Sometimes people forget that even if the gift is packaged neatly, there’s still a gift inside. The society has made people cynical enough to believe that only the ugly in the world can be objectively real.” Elias said calmly.

Cash thought of Nietzsche again. Suspicion. The idea that what looked noble could hide

something else underneath. Morality itself could be dressed up.

The problem was that the beautiful had often been used as camouflage. Governments sold unity, companies belonging, religions certainty. It all came well-wrapped.

Doubting what seemed too good to be true might have been cynicism or just pattern recognition, a kind of learned instinct to ask why the gift was wrapped in the first place.

“Yes,” Cash said, “but that gift box can also trap people. When a story becomes too perfect, it starts excluding everything that doesn’t fit. And the more it is repeated, the more it begins to feel like objective reality.”

“Maybe you know Watchmaker and other symbolic figures from our movement. Most of us see them as metaphors that help people find the right frequency. A story is a door, but you still have to step through it yourself. We bring people to the threshold, yes, but the choice must always be theirs. True goodness is not doing good out of habit or fear of consequences.”

“On a verbal level, that is very beautiful and ideally, I agree. But the idea that human behaviour could change that radically feels quite utopian.”

“Look around you. Could a caveman ever have imagined this world? Human behaviour has changed dramatically in a very short time.”

“I see your point, but someone could just as easily claim that time continues when everyone starts acting purely in their own self-interest. That would have just as much evidence. We have decided that doing good is also good from the universe’s perspective. What if the universe is malicious and laughs when things go terribly wrong?”

Elias looked uncomfortable, as if Cash had said something completely inappropriate. Cash understood it was time to change direction.

“How does your movement deal with the fact that physicists believe time will continue according to physical laws, without any moral success required?” Cash asked.

“I see no contradiction there,” Elias replied. “The fact that physicists observe changes in the loop means people have already started acting according to their moral compass.”

“That’s textbook adaptivism.”

“On the contrary. We do not see science as an enemy, even if it sees us as one.”

“I see. And what’s your interpretation of the approaching asteroid?”

“It is a mirror,” Elias said. “Every crisis is a reflection of how separated we still are from each other.”

Elias spoke sincerely. Still, the more his words wrapped themselves in metaphors, the less they seemed to pin anything down. It was no wonder that political populists were often praised for sounding direct. Cash disagreed with their conclusions, but he understood the appeal. The difference was that Elias left everything open, while populists tended to close things too quickly. One risked meaning nothing, the other risked meaning too much. In both cases, the listener did most of the work, filling in the gaps with what they already believed.

“But feeling isn’t universal evidence,” Cash said. “If I feel differently, is my experience less true than yours?”

“There can be many truths, but only one can allow time to continue. When everyone lives out their shadow, collective karma dissolves,” Elias answered.

“That sounds like blaming people for their own suffering,” Cash said, slightly interrupting.

“We believe everyone is responsible for their own energy,” Elias said more quietly and slowly, like reminding Cash how civil conversation was meant to happen. “But that is why we are here. To help others look at their morality in the eye and choose to act better.”

“But that leap can’t be made for someone else,” Cash said. “If someone doesn’t believe your story, they are labelled morally incomplete and responsible for the loop continuing. They are the scapegoats.”

“Our movement has never blamed anyone.”

“But you just said that if people don’t live by their moral compass, the loop doesn’t end.”

“I am ready to continue as long as it takes, until you see what I already see. But maybe once you have had the time to reflect on what we discussed,” Elias responded.

He pulled a business card from his green cotton trousers. It was likely from his former life before the loop. It described him as a consultant at a company that did environmental impact assessments.

Cash promised to send him the article for proofreading before its publication. For the movement, accuracy mattered, and Cash promised to do so. He suspected another reason for sharing contact

details was continued persuasion. Elias likely saw him as a difficult but rewarding target. Converting a sceptic probably earned more points than convincing ten believers.

As Cash walked away, someone whispered excitedly to a friend.

“This went straight to TikTok.”

Cash knew that young people had become fascinated with debates. For Cash’s generation, debate belonged mostly in school. Now, young audiences followed debaters like sports stars or religious leaders. He hoped the viewers understood this had been an ordinary conversation and not any sort of rhetorical gladiator fight.

Cycling back to the office, he thought about how many moral systems the loop had created. Sometimes, metaphors felt more convincing to people than plain reality. The world was never enough on its own. It had to be layered with stories, like clothing, so its cold would not seep into the bones like a damp Vancouver winter.

Truth could be replaced by repetition, until repetition started to feel like reality. Everyone knew someone who embroidered their stories, and over time, the line between invention and memory quietly disappeared.

Cash thought of conversations at the office after the election of Caroline Hogan, down in the United States. His colleagues had at first half-jokingly, but then more seriously, started to speak about an idea to form British Columbia, Alaska, Yukon, Washington, Oregon, and California into one new country that would share more similar values than Canada as a whole, or especially the broken ideological mosaic of the United States. They had come to see this kind of liberal counterforce as unstoppable against a country that had drifted closer to Margaret Atwood’s dystopian books. It would have its northern minerals, the entertainment industries of Hollywood and Vancouver, Pacific fisheries, and the entire west coast shoreline.

At the time, Cash had shrugged and said that was not how countries were born, that they always grew out of a nationalist story. Later, he realized how quickly he had said something that was not entirely true. There were also many examples of countries that had emerged mainly from economic needs. The Netherlands was one of them. Cities and regions had united to defend themselves and to trade. They were not originally bound by a common language or a strong national narrative, but by ports and trade routes. The story came later.

Still, most states were fuelled by stories, not spreadsheets. Nationalism had turned scattered regions into nations and made people imagine themselves as one family, even though they had never met. Without humanity's ability to create intersubjective realities, there would be no reason to work toward a shared goal with people outside one's tribe.

Morality could not rest on stories or feelings alone. Avoiding suffering was the only shared measure, because everyone's experience of it was equally real. This should have been clearer in the Groundhoggers' message. If the loop was a moral test, its measure could not be an abstract frequency or a beautifully packaged story, but a simple question: was human suffering decreasing or not?

The difficulty was that even if violence, poverty, and hunger declined, that alone did not prove moral progress. It might only show that people chose peace, fairness, and stability because it served their own interests. What looked like moral progress could just as easily be self-preservation on a larger scale?

Back at the office, Cash was called into Chris's room. He expected a reprimand, but Chris leaned against his desk with a satisfied grin.

"Apparently, people love exactly what I find so annoying. Never getting to the point and fencing with academic language," Chris said.

He turned his computer screen so Cash could see a video circulating on social media. It showed Cash's interview with Elias. The original recording, just over ten minutes long, had nearly one hundred thousand views, with comments pouring in steadily.

"We need to use this," Chris continued. "We already published an article about our reporter talking to a Vancouver Groundhogger, and look at this spike."

Cash did not like what he was hearing, especially since he had promised Elias to send the article for review before publication. He felt a duty to explain what had happened to him and to the movement. Was he already becoming a Groundhogger now himself, Cash joked silently, as he sensed in his body that he had done something against his values, just like Elias had described.

"I see an opportunity here," Chris said. "You could have similar conversations with the neo-saviours, simulation theorists, hell, even the US president. What do you say?"

"What exactly would I be doing?" Cash asked, slightly confused.

The idea felt surprisingly personal. He enjoyed writing articles. Televised encounters were something else entirely. He had never imagined himself fitting into the viral machine Chris wanted to push him into.

“We go straight to the field. Where people live and talk. You ask questions, find contradictions, let the audience see what does not hold up.”

Cash read the top comments on the Groundhogger video. Someone called him an arrogant manipulator. It stung. He had tried to give Elias space and have a respectful conversation. He had not meant to ridicule anyone’s beliefs or suggest he knew more than others.

Chris sensed his hesitation and offered a compromise that many journalists would have leapt at. “But first, people need to get used to your face, so you do not come across as just a troublemaker. We put you on the morning show. If that feels good, we expand from there.”

Cash thought for a moment. He was not afraid of criticism. He could live with that. But distortion, quotes stripped of context, the breaking of journalistic integrity, he did not want to lend his face to that.

He looked once more at the paused frame of himself on the screen. That man seemed confident, someone Cash did not always recognize. He was not sure he could summon that same version of himself every time a sharp dialogue was expected.

Chapter 1.24

“Did you get them?” Kate asked.

“Yes.” Cash smiled.

It could have sounded like teenagers whispering about a pack of condoms, but in marriage, it meant books.

Cash had biked across town to buy two copies of the same novel. Social media was crowded with photos of coffee cups resting on the pale covers of *On the Calculation of Volume* by Solvej Balle. It had not been easy to find it as they were selling like water in the desert. They already subscribed to an audiobook service and could have downloaded the digital version in seconds, but that would not have been the same. There was something about a hard copy. Holding it felt like lowering a needle onto a vinyl record.

The trend was that everybody read books involving time loops at the same time. That made it logistically even worse. Why could there not have been some ladder system? Well, as herd animals, there was definitely something hard to describe when big masses acted the same way, like singing in a choir. Social cohesion was important.

When it came to fiction, Cash was more interested in time travel than time loops. Which was odd, considering they were living in one. But if time loops were real, why not time travel too?

Kate had once asked whether Cash would believe her if she said she was a time traveller. Cash had said not without evidence. Kate had been upset by that, saying she would believe Cash immediately and simply ask what she could do to help. Well, if Kate asked it again, it would have been easier to believe something impossible. Cash had realized he was defending a worldview that had not held when the world had gotten stuck in the time loop.

It was rare for them to read the same book. Their tastes were usually quite different. Kate had a habit of seeking out stories that were bad for her. She watched series, films, and read books that leaned deliberately toward the sad and horrifying. She knew this about herself. She did not want the dog or the dad to die, but the cheating, cruel husband almost always did.

Cash preferred entertainment that asked questions without drowning in emotion. Metalevel narratives, clever structures, with as little horror and despair as possible. Kate gravitated toward the darker corners because she found them more honest.

Still, it was nice to have a hobby together. It was not their first time. They had tried dancing, meditation, cooking classes, yoga, a bit of badminton, and squash, too.

Many people moved through the world without ever trying to expand their worldview. Cash was proud that they were not those people. No, being with someone whose favourite word was no would have been exhausting.

Solvej Balle's book mentioned small inconsistencies between loops. Items went missing. Written text carried over into the next day. It was, of course, fiction. Pure imagination. He did not want to be too harsh on the Norwegian author. After all, she had never lived in a time loop. In a way, it was precisely those inaccuracies, her guesses about what life in a loop might be like, that pushed him to write his own story, from his own perspective.

Because nothing went missing. Nothing ever changed its place at the start of a new loop. Every day began depressingly the same.

Cash might have joked that some physical phenomenon was stealing his socks and hats. That mystery had followed him his whole life. They vanished with a consistency that suggested a pattern, yet never revealed one. It would have been comforting if physics could have stepped in with an it wasn't you explanation. But deep down, Cash knew it had more to do with what happens when you become the parent of young children.

Other fathers seemed to recognize it instantly. The abandoned jacket, keys, an indoor shoe under a locker room bench, or a water bottle left on the roof of a car. With almost perfect accuracy, you could expect to find a baby car seat in the back of that car.

But once the boundaries of what was possible had been refined, another question followed.
In Balle's novel, the protagonist Tara Selter noticed small inconsistencies between loops. Objects disappeared. Writing carried over into the next day. The fabric of repetition was slightly porous.

Cash almost envied that.

In their loop, nothing shifted. Nothing migrated a centimetre from its starting position when the morning reset. Every day began with depressing fidelity.

What if spacetime itself had imperfections, and the loop just reset them? They would not be cinematic black holes swallowing stars, but modest glitches at the quantum scale, small enough to go unnoticed and large enough to steal a tired father's left sock.

That, too, felt like a good idea for a book. In it, a sock monster would be the friendliest micro black hole the universe had ever known. Always hungry, never malicious. It would eat socks, hats, and mittens, but never passports, wallets, or phones.

In reality, the sock monster could not have escaped physics for long. Even the smallest black hole would still have mass, and mass meant gravity. If it could take a sock, it would also unknowingly take dust, air, and eventually the floor beneath it. Perhaps that was just party pooper thinking, like pointing out the inaccuracies in children's books, the way lions and tigers politely went to sleep in Good Night stories.

Still, crossing quantum vacuums off the list of possible explanations made the losses feel lighter. They had once felt almost personal, at least unfair. Now it was easier to accept that nothing had been taken on purpose. There was no entity to blame, except his own carelessness, or perhaps a permanently reduced attention span where his children always occupied a portion of his focus.

Cash realized he could not remember anything he had read on the last few pages when Kate closed the book beside her and remarked on how kind Tomas had been in the story. Tomas had believed the protagonist immediately when she said she was reliving the same November day. It was clearly meant as a quiet dagger, a reference to an earlier conversation that Kate had framed as a fight.

If Kate had described travelling through a wormhole, explained how it had been stabilized and held open, Cash would have found it easy to say hello, time traveller Kate. He would have also asked where she had found exotic matter with negative energy, and how she had expanded the wormhole beyond its natural size, which was smaller than an atom.

Films and television loved to suggest that black holes were time machines. They were not. You would be crushed and die in a place without time. There was no reason to believe a black hole would send anyone into the past.

“I would believe you. I know you would not joke about something like that,” Cash said.

A place without time was absurd, yet black holes were real. Cash knew by now that black holes did not describe time loops at all. Wormholes did. Black holes represented an ending of time, while wormholes bent time back on itself without ending it.

Some scientists had suggested that our entire universe was a massive black hole inside a larger universe. It was difficult to grasp that before the universe appeared, there had been no time at all, much like at the core of a black hole. But it was also possible that the universe itself was a loop, stretched beyond human comprehension.

It was possible the universe itself was a loop. Not a daily repetition, but a cosmic one. Trillions of years expanding, cooling, collapsing, returning to a dense singular state. If it began in timelessness, perhaps it would end there too.

If that were true, then their April twelfth was not an anomaly but a miniature echo of something unimaginably vast.

He was not sure how to compress that into something Kate would find romantic.

But Balle had written something else that stayed with him longer than wormholes.

In the novel, Tara travelled north to Norway and Finland to experience Christmas. When the climate did not change, she made sure it did. It was quite inspirational for a fiction story.

Cash looked out at Vancouver’s blooming cherry trees. Spring was obediently always there.

They had skipped celebrations during the loop, but traditions set the year's rhythm. Like weekly habits, like buying a new IPA every Friday. Rituals were important.

Winter was not far. Two hours north would have been Whistler, where they could have still seen snow on the mountain peaks. If altitude could manufacture December, distance could do even more.

A two-and-a-half-hour flight could have taken them to Whitehorse, where most of the day, the temperature dropped below zero.

They could celebrate Christmas there. Invite both sets of parents and their siblings, and their partners, and eat food. Not a bad idea, even though probably they were not the only ones thinking this when everyone was reading the same book series, and probably felt as they did when thinking that hey let's fly north to experience winter.

A place without time might exist at the centre of a black hole. They definitely were not there. They actually had quite a lot to say on how they wanted to live their lives. That was his result in calculating the volume of reality. The time was not a factor in the equation, but the size of the object mattered. It was everyone's own choice did they want to compress their reality in the smallest volume or expand it and live.

Chapter 1.25

Cash sat on the stage of CBC's current affairs programme. The show had been part of his morning routine during the first weeks of the loop. Back then, he had often laughed from his living room, watching the same types of guests circle the same tired clichés, spreading the same illusion of everything being meaningful. Now he was in that very studio's dressing room, exactly the kind of face he had once criticized.

Cash looked into the mirror. The same thirty-five-year-old man stared back at him, as if his face were made of Teflon, untouched by the pressures and fears of the loop. The wrinkles that hinted at ageing had not deepened. He knew many people now went for Botox daily, since its effects did not last more than a day in the loop. Cash did not understand much about the treatments beyond the fact that injections had to be repeated regularly throughout the year. Others had had the procedure just before the loop began and had nothing to worry about.

Just as Cash had nothing to worry about with his hair. It waved like the current of a dark evening river, naturally and without products, growing under its own weight like a well-behaved child. His eyes carried both attentiveness and melancholy. The shadow of his beard had already grown back in a few hours, spreading across his jaw and cheeks.

Outside the door came the busy noise of the corridor, the footsteps of production assistants, and a muted one two three tested into a microphone. Cash took a deep breath and left the dressing room. Moments later, he sat under bright studio lights, in the same set he had once watched from home. Beside him sat Minister of Defence Élodie Marchand. Across from him was Rajiv Sharma, a professor of international politics from the University of Toronto. On the fourth chair sat the host, Lena Chow, whose presence felt strangely familiar, like meeting someone you had heard about many times through a friend.

The discussion opened with a tight montage from the Global Emergency Response Summit, GERS, broadcast live around the world. Viewers had seen suspicion, tension, and outright threats on the faces of leaders.

"We have all seen what happened at GERS," Chow began. "Minister Marchand, why did the meeting end without decisions?"

Marchand answered calmly and confidently. “This is not the moment for hasty solutions. We are talking about the future of humanity. If even one country acts alone, without coordination, the results could be catastrophic.”

“But right now, is not inaction the greatest risk?” Chow continued. “President Hogan directly threatened Germany. That did not sound like everyone playing on the same team.”

“The United States’ position reflects its own security assessment,” the minister said diplomatically. “Canada continues to support shared, measured action. Our duty is not to inflame fear, but to build bridges.”

“Have situations like this ever been resolved through cooperation?” Chow asked.

“How much time do we have?” Sharma laughed. “Well, at least, after the Second World War, there was the Marshall Plan, and more recently, the 2015 Paris Climate Agreement.”

It was true that 2015 had started something. The Paris Agreement did not solve the problem, but it made it impossible to ignore. After that, regular reports from the IPCC were no longer distant scientific documents but checkpoints against reality, often showing how far targets were missed. The debate had shifted. It was no longer about whether climate change was real or human-caused. The evidence had settled that. What remained contested was responsibility, pace, and cost.

“Can I push back on that comparison?” Cash said, turning toward Sharma. “The Marshall Plan worked because the war had already ended. What we’re facing now is closer to the late 1930s, when the threat was already there, but countries interpreted it differently, and some chose not to act at all.”

Sharma raised an eyebrow. Cash was not sure what that meant. Being intrigued or questioning who Cash was to challenge him on history.

“And even the Paris Agreement, as important as it was, countries signed the same document but understood their responsibilities very differently. That’s more agreeing on a vision statement than cooperating.”

“So you’re saying what we saw at GERS is not unusual?” Chow asked.

“It might be more honest. How can there be consensus about the importance of climate action while emissions keep rising?” Cash replied.

Sharma nodded slowly, as if weighing the argument.

“Those are fair distinctions,” he said. “The Marshall Plan was not purely altruistic. It was a political move to contain Soviet influence in Europe.”

He leaned slightly forward.

“But I would challenge your point about the Paris Agreement being just a vision statement. Vision can be more powerful than coordination, at least in the long run. Coordination can be forced. Vision cannot.”

Cash did not interrupt. He liked Sharma.

“History gives us plenty of examples where strong countries forced cooperation. It often looked effective in the short term, but it created deeper instability. The Treaty of Versailles imposed order, but without shared legitimacy, it helped set the stage for the Second World War”.

He paused just long enough for Cash to think if they were having a bromance moment while going terribly off-topic from GERS. Was it weird that Sharma was only talking to Cash with his intense eyes and not others? How would that look on TV?

“In the Soviet Union after the war, there was coordination without consent. And without consent, systems eventually will fail.”

“So you argue that disagreement might actually be necessary?” Chow asked.

“Maybe not disagreement but a shared goal. It creates a direction that countries can move toward voluntarily. Forced coordination without that foundation can hold for a while, but it tends to collapse under pressure.”

“But if everyone agrees in principle but defines responsibility differently, nothing really changes.” Cash thought out loud.

“The alternative is worse. Without those shared principles, what remains is power. And power rarely coordinates anything for long.”

Marchand folded her hands calmly.

“Cooperation has always taken time,” she said. “We’ve faced global challenges before. International frameworks were built, agreements were signed, and the world adapted. The process may seem slow, but it works.”

Cash glanced at her.

“With respect,” he said, “that sounds a bit like saying umbrellas have been around for thousands of years, and yet it still rains.”

“What do you mean by that?” Marchand answered extremely calmly.

“I mean, having a framework is not the same as it working at the scale we need. We are not asking whether umbrellas exist. We are asking whether anyone is staying dry.” Cash said.

“These systems are the reason we have any stability at all,” she replied. “Without them, we would be dealing with unilateral actions and far greater risks.”

“Maybe,” Cash said. “But from the outside, it can also look like we are pointing to the existence of solutions rather than their outcomes.”

Chow let the exchange settle before turning back to the camera.

“People are afraid of being left alone. They are used to trusting that the state will take care of things, but many watched television today and wondered what would happen if the United States made its own decision. Does that scare any of you?” Chow asked.

“When one major country acts without regard for others, the rest are forced to react quickly, and that is when mistakes are made. History is full of examples of single decisions triggering chain reactions no one wanted. So yes, I would say the fear is somewhat justified.” Cash answered.

“Minister Marchand, your response?” Chow asked.

“Canada does not believe in preemptive strikes without international approval. We are signatories to the Outer Space Treaty. That is why we hope any solution will come through consensus, not the decision of a single superpower.” Sharma stepped in. “The problem is that this is an example of a treaty that does not clearly apply

inside the loop. At the moment, the International Criminal Court in The Hague is considering how definitions of war crimes should be interpreted under these new conditions.”

“Someone I met recently asked whether ordinary people have the right to know if Canada knows something that directly affects their own and their family’s safety,” Cash said. “It made me realise that people are not only afraid of the asteroid, but also of losing even a symbolic sense of influence when decisions are made behind closed doors.”

Chow picked up on that and turned to the Liberal minister. “So are Canadians safe if another country acts alone?”

Marchand swallowed. “We are doing everything we can to prepare for all scenarios. Cooperation with our defence allies continues. Canada is not alone.”

Cash raised his eyebrows slightly. “But neither is it independent in its decision making.”

Sharma added, “That is exactly the danger. When decisions are made behind the scenes, citizens lose trust. Society cannot sustain that for long.”

To close the programme, clips from street interviews were shown. A young woman in Toronto said, in Cash’s view, exactly what many felt.

“I think we should know more. I am not a rocket scientist, but if someone is pressing a button somewhere, should we not know in advance?”

At the end of the discussion, Chow asked Cash one final question.

“If you could deliver one message to decision makers, what would it be?”

Cash looked into the camera. “That people are no longer waiting passively. They are listening, watching, and they will remember the choices leaders make now.”

The programme ended with quiet music. In the background, a still image showed leaders in the GERS meeting room, each face tense, arms crossed, eyes turned away.

Later that evening, at home, Cash watched the rerun. He felt neither pride nor disappointment. But something had shifted. The programme he had once dismissed as a stage for platitudes now appeared in a different light. Sometimes a person needed a change in perspective, and for Cash, it had been literal, from the sofa to the studio chair, where he had felt the heat of the lights, seen the cameraman’s nod, and noticed the host balancing time and pressure. A sense of meaninglessness often came simply from being outside. Nietzsche wrote that there was no such thing as an objective viewpoint, only perspectives. Truth was never a single spotlight. It was overlapping lights.

Cash remembered that the root of journalism came from the French word *jour*, which in English meant a day. Even though time no longer moved forward, the daily record continued. Each journal, no matter the medium, was both a rebellion and a reminder that something real and different always happened in repetition.

When leaders withdrew into the shadows and left people on the front line of uncertainty, journalists were the ones who watched, listened, and recorded. That had become the mission for Cash, something that might have made even the groundhoggers proud.

Or was that just another vision statement?

Chapter 1.26

Kate's brother called from Australia and filled the screen of Kate's iPhone. Behind him, Sydney was bright and sunlit, a completely different day, which felt extremely strange. It was late evening on April 12th in Vancouver, while it was late afternoon where her brother lived, but already April 13th. He had moved there three years before the loop, with his wife, chasing high-paying careers that mirrored the path Cash and Kate had not taken. It was difficult to build wealth on a teacher's and a journalist's salaries. That is why Cash always paid attention when his brother-in-law talked about passive income.

The loop was predicted to end soon. Each repeated morning felt like a narrowing window. If there was ever a time to invest, it was now. That was what responsible parents did. They thought long-term.

Arabella and Florence already had Registered Education Savings Plans, quietly compounding toward campuses neither of them could yet imagine. The sensible boxes were checked. Perhaps they would study in one of the Nordic countries, where university was free, and societies ranked among the happiest in the world. The savings could go toward rent abroad instead.

Sensible, however, was not the same as comfortable.

Cash had once been part of the early cryptocurrency community. He had used it for small online purchases that later became, in retrospect, the most expensive purchases of his life. Calculating what might have been was a particular kind of torture. Regret like that was a first-world luxury, he reminded himself.

This time, he would not miss the rocket.

Cash leaned forward. "You said you had a strategy."

"First rule," his brother-in-law said. "Diversify. Second, in a loop, capital does not compound. Knowledge does. So you invest in optimization."

"Smart factories?" Cash asked.

"That depends on your moral compass. If you want high returns, look at industrial robotics and process AI. Factories in countries without Canada's labour rules have been running the same day

hundreds of times. Look into countries where there are no mandatory requirements for employers to provide employees with two days off every fifth day."

"But that is built on exploitation," Kate said, her voice rising.

"I did say it depends on what you are comfortable with. And plenty of other industries did not start ethically either. How much were the workers paid who trained ChatGPT?"

He leaned closer to the camera.

"You have seen the asteroid simulations."

Cash was definitely very aware of them.

"They have practised intercept trajectories hundreds of times. Targeting systems. Satellite coordination. The asteroid is most likely not even coming, but the precision remains."

"So you're praising military tech," Kate said. "No. Cash, do not listen to this. We're not putting our money there."

"They have optimized ballistic systems to a level that would have taken decades. When time resumes, those defence contractors will be light years ahead."

It sounded exaggerated. Yet Cash knew it was probably the safest bet, no matter how paradoxical it sounded. Military tech would rocket, no pun intended.

His brother-in-law read the silence.

"Next," he said. "Data."

"Everyone has been collecting it. When this ends, whoever holds the cleanest dataset owns the narrative."

As a journalist, Cash understood that well. Years ago, the political consulting firm Cambridge Analytica had harvested data from millions of Facebook users and used it to build psychological profiles for targeted political advertising. The scandal had briefly shocked the public before dissolving into the usual fog of outrage and forgetfulness.

Back then, it had seemed disturbing. Now it looked almost primitive. It was a well-known fact that companies had been gathering behavioural data even during the loop. What people bought when they thought consequences did not matter. What people said online when they believed tomorrow deleted any digital record of it. It was the closest thing to a controlled experiment society had ever produced.

“Distributed storage,” her brother continued. “Quantum computing firms. Memory infrastructure.”

“Well, those sound neutral,” Kate said.

Cash almost laughed, but Kate’s brother beat him to it.

“There is nothing neutral about it, Kate. That is the ultimate power,” her brother smiled.

Kate’s interest faded. Cash suspected it was still the least troubling of the troubling options.

“Actuaries have benefited from the loop, too. They can price risk with terrifying accuracy now. Reinsurance firms. Catastrophe modelling platforms. Boring, but steady long-term money.”

Cash thought of toilet paper during the pandemic. What had that revealed about human psychology? When people panicked, hygiene seemed more urgent than food.

“And finally,” his brother-in-law continued, “when the loop ends, reckless consumers who emptied their accounts on April twelfth will wake up to consequences. Overleveraged companies will collapse. Credit structures will snap.”

“So you short them?” Cash asked.

“No. You buy what survives. Farmland. Water rights. Distressed assets. Real assets with intrinsic value.”

“How do you even have time for all this?” Kate asked.

“There are twenty-four hours in a day,” he said, winking.

Cash immediately imagined the mechanics of real estate in a time loop. If someone signed a purchase agreement on April 12, what would happen when April 13 finally arrived? Most purchase contracts were conditional. They were contingent on financing and property inspection, often even more. They offered an easy escape from the sale if the buyer wanted. But sellers knew that too. No rational seller would sign an unconditional contract inside a time anomaly unless the price was high enough to erase their fear. It all sounded way too complicated. What if the seller claimed that the contract was not enforceable because it was signed during a time that economists might later have called a temporal irregularity? No property law would have protected a buyer from that.

Cash realized he had been silent too long. Kate was looking at him. They had already ended the call.

“Is that who you want to be?” Kate asked. “Someone who profits from perfected missiles and population control?”

She let her brother speak that way. With Cash, she was less forgiving. Or perhaps that was how he chose to hear it.

“I was thinking of us,” he said. “And he mentioned options that were more ethical.”

In the girls’ room, Florence was explaining her homemade calendar to Arabella.

Cash imagined the day time resumed. It would detonate headlines, louder even than the first reports of repetition. Back then, confusion had muffled the shock. Now anticipation had been compressing for months.

He opened his investment app. The interface looked almost embarrassed to see him again. He had not logged in for years. It required an update. Of course it did. And apparently, he would now need to update it every single day if he wanted to time this correctly. He imagined the absurdity of doing months of research only to forget the update on the one morning that finally became April 13.

He deleted old videos from his phone to make space, and the app finally opened. His account balance was not impressive.

He opened the list his brother-in-law had sent. A note said he did not have to tell anyone which companies he chose.

The list included military contractors, social media platforms, massive biotechnology firms, cloud infrastructure companies, insurance modelling platforms, and resilience assets.

It was true that he would not have to tell what he picked. But he would still know. The strategy was simple. Small amounts across many possibilities.

He began typing.

A robotics manufacturer, NorthForge Automation: Two hundred dollars.

A satellite defence contractor, Orion Shield Systems: One hundred and fifty.

A cloud storage firm, DeepLedger Infrastructure: Two hundred.

A catastrophe modelling company, Atlas Risk Analytics: One hundred.

An agriculture trust that owned farmland and water rights: One hundred and fifty.

He stared at the total. It was only eight hundred dollars. Definitely not a fortune. Was it even worth all the time and effort? No, he should have put more. He imagined explaining this portfolio to someone. Yes, I invested one hundred and fifty dollars in a company that builds targeting systems for missiles. But I also invested two hundred in cloud storage, so morally it balances out. No, it would not. It made no sense to put just a little bit of money into something that you did not even feel comfortable doing. These were not hedge fund positions. He would have made ethical compromises priced at the level of a monthly grocery bill. No way.

Diversify, his brother-in-law had said.

“Diversify my ass,” he laughed to himself, deleting the entire list, and the screen returned to zero.

He scrolled back to the agriculture trust. Farmland and water rights in Saskatchewan.

He was still not convinced real estate transactions made sense inside a time loop. The legal mechanics alone felt like science fiction. But land, at least in theory, did not care about the calendar, and people always needed food and water.

He typed three thousand dollars, which he knew was half of their entire bank account. The confirmation screen appeared, and he tapped confirm.

The portfolio page refreshed. Was it reckless? Should he have asked Kate first? Perhaps. Then again, other people had done far worse things during the loop. Compared to them, Cash had been almost conservative.

He imagined historians studying this moment centuries later. The day humanity had accidentally invented a rehearsal for the future. If that was true, it was probably better to bet on something that would still matter when the rehearsal ended.

Investing in a Day That Never Ends

What Happens When the Calendar Freezes and Traders Hope for the Big Win

Cash Haggerty | CBC | April 12

Stock markets open, banks process transactions, and trades are executed. Yet when the next day arrives, accounts reset. In a world stuck on the same date, conventional investing loses its old meaning.

With growing evidence that the loop may soon end, a new urgency has taken hold. People feel the pressure of lost time and the sense that they have not done enough or fulfilled their dreams. Daytraders and long-term investors alike are experimenting, making high-stakes bets on industries expected to benefit most when time resumes.

"There's a real fear of missing out," says Nate Smith, futurist at the Fraser Institute. "Years of the same day have created intense pressure to act before tomorrow finally arrives."

WealthNow, a popular trading application, has remained at the top of both the App Store and Google Play charts for the fourth consecutive week, signalling that the trend is clear. Even those new to investing are logging in daily and putting their money on something they believe will pay off when the time finally moves forward.

Have you recently become an investor? Tell CBC about your experience by filling out our online form, and our journalists may contact you.

Chapter 1.27

Nick had barely managed to sit down in their armchair before he started complaining about tipping culture.

“Explain this to me,” he said, waving his beer in the air. “Why should I pay fifteen percent extra for grabbing my own coffee from the counter?”

“You really do pick the most important battles,” Cash laughed, choosing not to mention that in his own case, the number was often twenty, simply because he could not be bothered to subtract the sales tax and tap smaller numbers than the preset options on the screen.

“Where does it end? Soon we will be tipping self-checkout machines, too.”

From the kitchen, where she was chopping vegetables, Kate said, “Finally, something I actually agree with you on.”

Nick grinned. He seemed sincere and admitted that the loop had tested him. He had realised how important the gym had been for his mental health. When the numbers no longer went up and his muscles stopped growing, he started wondering whether his time could be used for something else.

“You can’t do leg day forever,” he joked.

It felt so human that Cash experienced a brief moment of regret for having suspected the worst when inviting him over. Nick was one of those friends people stayed in touch with because of shared history, even though they had grown in completely different directions.

Nick was not stupid. He surely knew about Cash’s TV appearance and the topics he had been writing about lately. Even though he never said he had read any of it, the subjects he liked to bring up were always so closely aligned that someone might have thought Nick was responding directly to Cash’s articles.

Instead of saying, “Hey Cash, I liked your article,” Nick’s way was to attack the topic head-on, making it hard to tell whether he genuinely disagreed or was simply using an unusual way to show that he had read it.

“So, this basic income thing in the loop, what do you think? You support it?” Nick asked, as if hearing Cash’s thoughts.

Cash sighed. This could be a Pandora's box, especially when Nick and Kate were in the same room. Their interaction styles often felt like two identical poles of a magnet, pushing each other away, provoking and being provoked.

Kate often asked how Cash never remembered to ask his friends how their relationships were going, how their families were doing, or anything more personal than sports, new music, or world politics. Cash understood what she meant, even though by male standards, he considered himself quite an open book. But perhaps he did not know how to open another book if he knew the book too well.

Well, Cash had come a long way. Cash remembered how, in his later teenage years, he had started spending more time with his former teammate, someone he had genuinely enjoyed spending time with, until this friend had asked him over for coffee on his balcony. Cash had not been sure whether it sounded like a date or just a misunderstanding eased along by cultural differences, and it was supposed to mean in the language of straight men that the friend just wanted to hang out. No plans, nothing special to do, just being there, like back in childhood. Cash understood now how childish he had been back then. He had shown the message to his girlfriend at the time, who advised him to suggest having the meeting in some public place instead, to not give the wrong impression. How childish it had been to turn down the coffee invitation. Soon after that, the contact had quickly faded away.

Cash made a promise to himself to message the friend, or at least like one of his posts. No more than one. Otherwise, that former teammate would have shown the number of likes to one of his friends, asking whether this was normal behaviour. People lived inside a loop of performing normality.

"Fifty dollars a day for doing nothing? What a liberal wet dream. Instead of mobilizing everyone to figure out what the hell is going on, we pay them so they can get drunk," Nick laughed.

"It's meant to manage chaos at a time when it costs the government absolutely nothing. A win-win," Cash replied.

Nick shrugged. "Nonsense. The stores are full every day. You have to be at rock bottom if you cannot get food from a place like that. Everyone here can get their basic needs met. Some people are just jealous that others have more every day. Capitalism 101."

Cash understood what Nick was pointing at. Aristotle had already described humans as desiring beings. When the head of the British Oil Company, Rockefeller, was asked how much money was enough, he answered, “Just a little more.” It was the result of evolution. If humans had adapted to a fixed level of happiness, they would have gone extinct as happy but starving singles. Harari had written something like that.

Cash knew Kate was listening to his answer, and she would not have appreciated appeasement or philosophical name-dropping, even if the motive was to steer the conversation elsewhere.

“Not everyone has skills they can trade for services in the loop. Everyone should, at least in theory, have equal access to basic services,” Cash said. “Society has to take care of people with disabilities, caretakers, and those who were waiting for a payday that was only days away.”

Nick waved his hand dismissively. “Yeah, yeah, I’ve heard that mantra. So we just give them free money?”

“The money only becomes real once the loop ends. Which matters more to a conservative, social stability or preserving wealth gaps?”

“Conservatives believe people should not be underestimated. If you teach people that they can be lazy, they will stay that way also once the loop is over. But if you give them freedom and responsibility to sort out their own lives, they will do that too. It’s a self-fulfilling prophecy.”

Cash could have come up with many counterarguments, but they would hardly have ended the debate. “You sound like a speechwriter for the Conservative Party.”

Nick clearly took it as a compliment.

“And then there is releasing prisoners. What sense does it make to release inmates into already existing chaos when they have not even served their sentences? Last time I checked, the official date was still April twelfth,” Nick continued.

“Those prisoners who are released would have already been released without the loop. So they have already served their time,” Cash replied.

Nick shook his head. “That doesn’t matter. Lots of things would have happened without the loop. What message does this send to citizens? That rules no longer apply?”

“So what is the alternative? Keep them locked up forever?”

“Maybe. If you compare our streets to some other countries, here we have chaos and crime, and elsewhere there’s order. That shows that running a country is not the same as running an elementary school. Crisis decision-making is a completely different thing, and we should have declared wartime law a long time ago.”

Cash raised his eyebrows. He glanced at Kate, who was clearly pretending not to listen, though the way her knife drummed slightly too hard against the wooden cutting board told a different story.

The next topic came quickly, as if straight from Nick’s personal pharmacy shelf. “You know what? The asteroid.”

Cash tensed. Nick did not hesitate. “It’s the best damn thing that has happened to humanity in a long time.”

Cash felt his jaw tighten and his heart beat faster.

Nick went on, completely unaware of the reason for Cash’s silence. “Seriously. Are you not bored? The same day, over and over again. At least this brings some variety.”

Cash’s voice came out colder than he intended. “You are actually celebrating something that could kill hundreds of thousands of people?”

Nick thought for a moment, then shot back. “Better than being stuck in the same day forever.”

Cash felt his pulse rise even faster. It usually made him say the wrong things. There was something frighteningly indifferent in Nick’s thoughts and tone.

“I get that you do not have much to lose,” Cash said. “But some of us do.”

Nick raised his hands. “Relax. I didn’t say I want it to hit. I just said life has become boring and people need a bit of a wake-up call. I watched an interesting video today that mentioned this theory that the most likely option is that we live the same loop from beginning to end, over and over again. That means we have had this exact conversation infinite times before, just like now, and we will have it infinitely again in the future. They said time is not a sausage, but a mandala.” Nick said.

“That is interesting, but one at the same time one of those theories that you can’t really prove or disprove.” Cash replied.

“Sure, but that’s not the point. I don’t believe at all that this is heaven for some and hell for others. Neither is much of anything if you don’t even know which one you’d be living in.”

“Most people who believe in that theory are probably comfortable with their position in the loop and imagine that they are living in heaven right now,” Cash answered.

C.S. Lewis had written that heaven and hell were more like states of mind than separate places, and there was something deeply insightful about that. But as an explanation to the current reality, it sounded easily dismissive and unfair.

Nick returned to the previous topic. “If you tried to stop the asteroid, how would you do it?”

“I don’t know any solution for how that could be done within a single loop.”

Nick rolled his eyes. “Come on, you must have some idea after all these months.”

Cash thought for a moment. “If we were not in a loop? Then a kinetic impact would be the best option. A DART-type mission.”

Nick nodded. “Like a cosmic game of billiards.”

Cash liked the comparison, but did not smile yet.

“Except that it takes months of preparation. Right now we have one day.”

Nick grinned. “Then nuclear weapons.”

Kate could no longer stay silent. She turned around. “Of course you would say that.”

Nick laughed. “What?”

Kate crossed her arms. “Nuclear explosions do not work in space the way they do in movies. There is no shockwave, only radiation and waste that would still hit Earth.”

Nick raised his hands. “And does Katherine Johnson have a better idea?”

Kate looked confused, then shook her head. “I do not know who you are talking about, but I do know that mansplaining planetary defence strategies is not my idea of a fun afternoon.”

Nick was clearly provoked by Kate’s choice of words. “You probably also teach your students woke vocabulary.”

Cash knew the topic was sensitive for both of them.

Nick continued. “So now all philosophers and inventors who don’t have an immediate solution are mansplainers? Should they just stay quiet until they have the right answers that fit the left’s

prescribed DEI values? And what about you, Cash? Should you have given up your new seat on CBC's morning show because you probably took it from a woman?"

Cash gave an awkward grin. The cut was sharp and clever, but the discussion had now spiralled out of control.

"I don't think diversity goals mean quite that. They are meant to address systemic discrimination," Cash said, knowing that if he stayed silent, Kate would later direct her anger at him instead of Nick.

Nick grinned. "I can tell you I have talked to many xenofeminists who genuinely think men should just step aside in fields where they are overrepresented. But yeah, I can see it is hard for you to talk about this when the government is in the room."

Nick drained his drink. "Alright. This was fun."

Cash walked Nick to the door.

Nick patted him on the back. "Hope I still get invited."

Cash let out an uncomfortable laugh. "Of course. Take care."

When Cash returned to Kate, she had already cleared the kitchen and the living room table of the four beer bottles. Cash expected Kate to speak first. He could see her carefully sharpening the words in her mind, choosing ones that would cut deeply but leave no fingerprints. Conversation in a relationship was a martial art. Kate was several belt levels ahead of Cash, who, in his self-reflection, was still earning the first red stripe on his white belt.

Kate knew how to form sentences that left nothing to grab onto. They were not quotable attacks that could later be turned against her. Cash guessed it was a skill teachers learned when dealing with students' parents.

"I don't hate Nick," Kate said, glancing toward the children's room to make sure they could not hear a word that was not allowed at home.

Cash was surprised by how much heavier he had expected her opening line to be.

Kate met his gaze. "But I hate how much space you give him in your life."

Cash had no answer, or at least none he could put into words out loud. Deep down, he knew he could not abandon Nick at a time like this. But maybe Nick was someone best tolerated in small, five-centimetre, nickel-sized doses. The thought made him smile. He knew Kate might have

appreciated the metaphor at another time, but right now, even five centimetres of Nick would have been too much.

Chapter 1.28

Langley slowly rotated his whisky glass. He had just returned from the White House to Kate's warm hospitality. Nick had left only a few hours earlier.

Kevin and Harriet were already asleep by the time Langley had been brought back to Vancouver. He had to tell someone about what had happened today, even though he had signed a non-disclosure agreement.

"Can you really tell me this?" Cash asked.

Langley appreciated Cash's caution, but replied with surprising ease. "I figured that as long as you do not write about it or talk about it on TV, I can avoid daily trips to Guantanamo."

Cash gave a short laugh. "That bad?"

Langley sighed. "Worse."

He had been flown on a military aircraft to the capital of their southern neighbour and led straight into the White House Situation Room.

Langley had already told the soldiers who picked him up in Vancouver that trusting probabilities was the best defence strategy against the asteroid, and that he did not want to support planning a military intervention. They had replied that they were not the right people to discuss it with. The United States agenda was to examine all possible strategies and act before more irresponsible countries did the same, but worse.

"General Carter did not hesitate," Langley said. "His position was clear from the start, and he did not want it changed. He said China and Russia were already ahead, and that it was crucial to strike first. Classic military logic. If something threatens you, throw something bigger at it."

Cash pictured the Situation Room in his mind. According to Langley, the loudest voice had not been Carter's, but that of a technology billionaire who had grown rich through a boyish obsession with space.

"If God gave us infinite chances," the man had said, "He did it so we could succeed at something this difficult. The loop makes the impossible possible. I have done this before under constant investor pressure. Now there are no financial limits."

President Hogan had liked the idea. The most important thing was readiness to act if the asteroid came too close.

“The loop is like a sandbox before launch,” the billionaire had continued. “It gives us a chance to refine the perfect defence plan.”

As Langley described the dialogue in the Situation Room, Cash could see it like a Hollywood film playing in his head.

“NASA has been instructed to stay quiet about certain findings,” Langley said softly.

Cash raised his eyebrows. “Such as?”

Langley set his glass down. This was why he had come.

“It has to do with probabilities.”

“Go on.” Cash said.

“According to their latest modelling, the probability of impact is lower than previously estimated. Still classified as serious, but nowhere near as likely as first feared.”

Cash blinked. “And they are hiding it?”

Langley answered calmly. “Not exactly hiding it. The White House has not been pleased with NASA questioning the official threat picture. Ironically, a reduced risk is not politically good news. You cannot justify daily military exercises in the sky if there is no threat. I suspect Russia and China already know the same, and are now preparing to optimise systems for something other than the asteroid.”

“And the public is kept in uncertainty instead,” Cash muttered.

“Exactly,” Langley said. “Carter was not interested in NASA’s calculations. He only cared about how far launch vehicles would need to travel before the loop’s effect stops.”

Cash swallowed. “Do we know that?”

“The best estimate is around two hundred thousand kilometres,” Langley said.

Cash’s expression darkened. “So, almost halfway to the Moon.”

Langley nodded. “Anything launched from Earth resets unless it gets far enough before the day ends. In theory, a fast, multi-stage launch vehicle with a nuclear warhead could escape the loop if launched at exactly the right time.”

Cash hesitated. “But in practice?”

Langley let out a dry laugh. “In practice, it would be a suicide mission. The logistics alone are nightmarish. Everything would have to happen to the second, at exactly the right speed. And even then, there is no guarantee the physics of the loop would not affect it in some unexpected way.”

Cash rubbed his face. “So your big scientific contribution was suggesting we do nothing.”

“Do you remember when we talked about the cosmic string theory?” Langley asked, pulling out his phone. He showed an image of a gravitational model. “This is what we were missing before.”

Cash was not sure what he was looking at.

“In theory, they are one-dimensional structures in the fabric of spacetime. Infinitely thin, but extremely dense. If one passed close to Earth, it could have caused a local time loop.”

Cash swallowed. “And how does that relate to the asteroid?”

Langley’s voice was almost clinical now. “If we interfere, we might destabilise the entire system.”

Cash straightened. “You mean we could end the loop?”

Langley’s expression was far too relaxed for something so serious when he said, “No. I mean, we could collapse it in the worst possible way.”

Cash’s throat went dry. “Worse than the asteroid hitting?”

Langley nodded slowly. “Much worse.”

“How?”

Langley sighed. “The collapse of the loop would not just end repetition.”

He looked Cash directly in the eyes. In some way, Langley seemed to enjoy that purely theoretical physics had become relevant and that he was now an expert in the field.

“It could tear the structure of time completely around Earth.”

“That sounds rather abstract. You might want to explain that a bit more,” Cash said.

“If a nuclear bomb explodes in space, it probably would not affect the loop in any way. But if an enormous amount of energy were released at the boundary of the loop, the structure of time could tear. I am not speaking metaphorically. I am talking about a rupture in the gravitational field, a topological disturbance that cannot be closed.”

Cash listened in horror to Langley's dystopian monologue. Of course, no one knew the threshold at which nuclear detonations near the loop boundary might begin to affect time. Everything was deeply theoretical, just like cosmic strings. But the risk might simply be too great. When the loop's effect was already weakening and humanity was close to seeing tomorrow, humanity could also erase yesterday and today. It was a terrifying thought.

Langley was convinced that every new explosion near the loop boundary increased instability. The missiles of major powers might not reach the boundary today, but according to projections, they could later this year. The danger inherent in the loop was that when nothing was final, missile strike optimisation could be practised daily, without concern for the durability of nuclear arsenals.

"Ballistic missiles do not run out in timelessness, but time might," Langley said, as if rehearsing a line for future memoirs.

"So a poorly timed series of nuclear detonations outside Earth could create some kind of black hole?" Cash asked slowly.

Langley shook his head. "No. A black hole is a stable instability. This would be chaotic, non-linear discharge. If the string-induced loop is a local stable state, like a knot in time, then the energy of a nuclear explosion released at the edge of the loop could cut it. The entire structure could unravel. The entire fabric of spacetime around Earth."

"What would happen then?" Cash asked, struggling to follow the complex discussion.

Langley took a sip of whisky. His voice was quieter now.

"If the direction of time collapses, there is nothing. Our daily loop would not simply end. It would cease to exist, along with everything else inside the affected region. We would be nothing."

For a moment, the room was completely silent.

"Dark energy?" Cash tried.

"Not even that," Langley replied, again far too calmly.

When Langley left, Cash remained by the door for a moment, listening to the quiet settle back into the apartment. He wondered why Langley had come at all if none of it was meant to be shared. Telling something like that to a journalist was like putting a glass of whisky in front of

someone and asking them not to drink. It felt deliberate, which made it worse. Langley was not a man who did things without reason.

Cash walked back to the living room and sat down, staring at the glass Langley had left behind. It struck him how easily a person could hold two incompatible ideas at once. Langley could calmly describe the possible collapse of time, and still enjoy a glass of whisky as if tomorrow were guaranteed.

Maybe that was not unusual. Cash had seen it in himself. The version of him that lived alone felt almost like a different person from the one who now shared his life. One was impulsive and self-contained, the other careful, responsible. Both felt real.

The contradiction went deeper than behaviour. He could dismiss superstition in theory, then catch himself performing small rituals anyway, just in case.

Even the greatest minds had lived with that tension. Isaac Newton had described the laws that governed the motion of planets, and he still spent years searching for hidden codes and impossible transformations. If certainty and doubt could coexist in him, perhaps it was not surprising that the world now rested on both.

Chapter 1.29

Cash had developed a new hourly habit. He kept returning to NASA's official channels, hoping for new information about the asteroid and its much more unlikely impact, but without success. The obsession reminded him of the early days of the pandemic, when he had obsessively followed country-by-country infection numbers.

NASA published only brief reports about explosions in space. Member states of the asteroid defence coalition had begun large-scale missile exercises. It was strange how they caused no public concern. People saw them as sensible preparations and as firm proof of defence. And when was the last time the world had seen coordinated cooperation between major powers against a common threat?

The first significant explosion was detected in low orbit, about one hundred and ninety thousand kilometres from Earth. It looked like nothing. There was no fireball or mushroom cloud. Just a brief, pale flash of light that someone managed to capture on video. Spectrometers detected radiation, but it caused no panic in a reality that reset every morning.

Langley had tried to warn them.

"If the loop is a stable state in spacetime caused by a string," he had said, "a large enough nuclear explosion right at its boundary could break time."

Cash could not find words for the warning in a way that sounded believable. It felt more like speculative science fiction than a real threat. But the fact that something sounded absurd did not necessarily make it nonsense. Would people in ancient times not have denied the existence of atoms if someone had claimed that everything was made of invisible particles that could not be seen or touched? Human reason often rejected what exceeded the limits of its time.

"You can't make people believe something they don't want to," Kate had said gently.

Kate was right. People needed to feel they were in control. Collective, confident rhetoric provided that feeling, which crisis psychologists kept repeating to CBC's journalists. Messaging was expected to remain hopeful. Cash disliked the quiet narrowing of what could be said. It felt like a constraint on journalism, even if it came dressed as responsibility. Still, CBC was

government-funded. There were limits to how far anyone could push before the structure pushed back.

That same need for control shaped more than the news.

People often said the loop was a mirror for humanity, reflecting its image. But the reflections did not match. Some societies remained calm and cooperative, while others collapsed into disorder. It began to look less like a mirror of humanity itself and more like a reflection of the environments people inhabited. Whatever the explanation, it seemed clear that people could not outsource their limits to a portrait like Dorian Gray, even in a time loop.

And the same pattern appeared in the data people chose to trust.

The modelling suggesting the asteroid would pass close to Earth but almost certainly miss it did not come from NASA, but from Namibia. Physicists in Windhoek published their forecast openly, without political pressure to shape the results. The risk of impact was estimated at zero point three percent, and even that was based purely on a theoretical scenario in which the gravity at the loop's boundary might unexpectedly deflect the asteroid from its predicted path. If that did not happen, Earth could breathe a sigh of relief.

The oddity of the coalition was that a shared enemy had united former enemies. Peace had emerged, paradoxically, around nuclear missiles. It had been predicted before, though not in this sense, but rather as the idea that nuclear weapons would never be used against other nuclear powers.

Langley had spoken about a topological disturbance, whatever that meant. No one spoke about it publicly. Even the risks of fragmenting the asteroid were brushed aside.

A week earlier, something had happened that would have stopped everything in a normal world. Al Jazeera published a leaked recording of a closed meeting between Israeli military leadership and aerospace physicists. The recording revealed uncertainty and distress that were always absent from official statements.

In the recording, Prime Minister Lavi opened the discussion. "Our people need to see that we are protected. Iron Dome and Iron Beam are our shields."

Dr Yael Shafir, Israel's leading aerospace physicist, replied calmly but firmly.

“Prime Minister, these systems were not designed to defend against objects from space. They cannot stop targets hundreds of metres wide moving at over twenty kilometres per second.”
When the defence minister suggested the asteroid could be broken apart, Shafir answered without hesitation.
“Kinetic energy does not disappear when you fragment an object. It only spreads. A fragment moving fast enough can destroy an entire residential area.”
Silence.
“So you disagree with the Americans and NASA?”
“If we act incorrectly, we will make the situation worse,” Shafir said. “A badly fragmented asteroid could cause global destruction. No system is prepared for that.”
The leak spread quickly. Hashtags like #AsteroidGate began trending. Shafir was either praised as a truth teller or accused of spreading fear.
Israel initially denied everything, then moments later admitted the recording was real but claimed it had been taken wildly out of context. NASA quickly released a statement acknowledging the technical facts, but emphasizing that the plan was part of a broader strategy aimed at minimizing fragment size so they would burn up in the atmosphere.
The public calmed down. Facts did not matter when the story was believable enough.
The coalition continued its preparations. Missiles were tested against smaller space objects, and official reports assured the results were promising. Skeptics existed, but they were dismissed.
Cash wondered whether humanity had ever truly fought anything other than itself. This was the greatest moment for collective survival, and perhaps at the same time its greatest step toward destruction.
Meanwhile, emergency preparations began to seep into everyday life. Also, CBC organized regular evacuation drills. The entire newsroom was led underground and told to wait for permission to return. Cash believed most employees knew deep down how symbolic the drills actually were. They created a false sense of safety, like passengers putting their heads between their legs in an airplane crash.
“Alright. Same as last time. Take what matters, leave what doesn’t. Try to be consistent about it.” Chris instructed.

They moved.

“Is this scheduled?” Lucy asked Chris.

“Does it change your behaviour?” he replied.

“It changes the interpretation.”

Behind them, Peter and Dev lifted an office couch.

“If this is the real one,” Peter said, adjusting his grip, “I regret not having proper seating.”

“Damn you guys,” Chris said, without telling them to put it down.

Cash jogged ahead and pulled the stairwell door open like it was ceremonial.

“You know,” he said, “this is very much a pivot situation.”

Lucy glanced at him. “A what?”

Cash blinked. “Pivot. From Friends. The couch, the stairs.”

“Carrying a couch during an emergency is exactly the right energy.” Peter agreed.

“That reference only works if someone’s actively making things worse.” Dev knew.

He glanced back.

“Like Bob blaming immigrants for the asteroid.”

Bob, a few steps behind with his coffee, grinned.

“Well, I figured you’d know better than me.”

Dev didn’t miss a beat. “About immigrants?”

“About where they come from,” Bob answered.

Dev let that hang for a few seconds.

“I was born in Calgary,” he said. “So were my parents.”

Bob took a sip of his coffee. “So you’re a third-generation immigrant.”

”Or not an immigrant at all. And Bob, I didn’t know you were indigenous yourself. Thanks for letting us be in your land.” Dev said playfully.

“Pivot! Pivot!” Peter shouted, asking them to talk about something else.

Chris pushed the lower door open.

“Exactly, Ross Geller,” he said dryly. “Let’s try to concentrate during evacuation.”

It sounded slightly absurd while two of his employees were carrying a couch.

They stepped into the parkade.

“Which one is this?” Peter asked. “Are we in Seinfeld, where nothing happens, or How I Met Your Mother, where something happens but we don’t understand it until later?”

“Seinfeld,” Cash said. “This is clearly about nothing.”

They moved into the open space where Dev and Peter placed their couch.

A nearby team watched them approach.

“Are you serious?” a woman from the team said. “You brought furniture?”

“It’s about long-term thinking,” Peter said.

Cash dropped onto it immediately. “Impact absorption.”

Dev sat beside him. “We’re increasing survival odds.”

The woman did not laugh.

“That’s not funny,” she said. “You’re blocking space.”

“It’s a small couch,” Cash said. “We’re not exactly a sectional.”

“You know,” she said to Cash, “I’ve never liked you.”

Cash felt something in his stomach tighten and then spread upward into his chest. He was insulted.

“I’m sorry, do we know each other?” He asked as politely as he possibly could.

“That’s exactly it,” she said. “You don’t notice people unless they’re useful to you.”

Cash blinked. “What? Have we ever even talked?”

“You’re always on,” she continued. “Always everywhere. It’s so calculated.”

Cash let out a small breath. “Or it’s my job.”

Peter leaned back and grinned. He had been following the entire exchange, while Dev had been too busy to explain to Lucy that watching the right TV shows probably mattered more for understanding Canada than memorizing facts about voting procedures, history, or democratic institutions. Bob was surprisingly paying closer attention to Cash’s conversation.

The woman shook her head. “No. It’s you. This couch stunt now too. Jesus. We see you enough, okay.”

She turned and walked back to her team. Communications, Cash noticed. Of course.

“What a communicator,” he muttered.

Peter looked at Cash. “That escalated faster than the couch. Was that someone you dated and ghosted?”

“No,” Cash said. “I don’t think so.”

The adrenaline was still there, buzzing now, less like a drop and more like a hum under his skin.

Peter nodded. “Well,” he said, glancing around, “at least we’re not in Seinfeld anymore.”

“Yeah, that definitely wasn’t nothing.” Cash answered.

“New theory,” Dev said, returning to the conversation. “There’s this episode in The Office where they do a fire drill.”

“That sounds normal,” Lucy answered.

“It starts normal, but then it really isn’t. That’s a hectic episode,” Peter laughed.

“Yes. People panic. Someone breaks a window. Someone throws a cat.” Dev explained excitedly.

Lucy frowned. “They what?”

“Through the ceiling,” Peter clarified. “To save it.”

“That’s worse,” she said.

Dev nodded. “Everyone completely overreacts. That’s what this is. That’s why we’re sitting here.”

“Hundred percent.” Peter agreed.

“Same setup, same behaviours. That means we’re in a simulation. You just need to swap out the details.” Bob said.

Lucy crossed her arms. “No, it just means people can’t handle uncertainty very well.”

“So either people are predictable or whoever’s running this thing has a limited imagination,” Peter laughed.

“Or limited time.” Cash joined the guessing game.

Dev shook his head. “Yeah, maybe the simulation coder had a cold and just watched TV all week.”

“That would explain the writing,” Cash said.

“So what happens in the episode?” Lucy asked.

Dev thought for a second. “Nothing useful.”

“Maybe Bob is right, then, because we’re on track,” Cash joked.

Later, after the strange day at work, Florence and Arabella sensed that something was not quite right.

“Daddy, are we safe?” Arabella asked during the nighttime routine.

Cash pulled her close and said as calmly as he could, “Of course we are, sweetheart.”

But he knew that in many scenarios, that answer would have been a lie. And no drill could prepare them for what might be coming if Langley’s fears were valid.

When the house had fallen silent and the world outside seemed to hold its breath, Cash opened his old notebook. It contained sentences he had written down over the years while listening to the world around him. They were ordinary observations from ordinary people that felt deeper once they were carefully written down.

Maybe that was the meaning of it. Not discovering meaning, but choosing to notice it.

A sentence that meant nothing on its own could become significant when it was attached to the right name. But why could someone unknown not say something wiser? Of course, they could.

One line read:

“Subjective certainty is not proof of objective reality.”

Today, it felt less like a thought and more like a diagnosis.

He thought of the woman in the parkade. The certainty in her voice. How quickly she had assembled a version of him that felt complete to her. Calculated. Always on. Everywhere. As if intention had to exist simply because the pattern did. She had not seen Chris suggesting the morning show spot. She had not seen Peter and Dev deciding to carry the couch while he held the door. None of that mattered. The story worked without it.

And once it worked, it became true.

He wrote what had stayed with him.

“You’re always on. Always everywhere. It’s so calculated.”

He looked at the sentence. Now it was his.

He thought about the beliefs forming around the loop. Old ones reshaped and new ones emerging. Each was carried by people who sounded just as certain as the woman from Communications.

But had he done the same? Had he taken Langley's theory and given it weight simply by returning to it, writing it down, letting it sit beside everything else that once felt worth keeping? If meaning came from choosing what to write down, then belief was not so different.

Sometimes, days felt so absurd that it was difficult to feel fully attached to them.

He found himself thinking he was living like a cosplay character, performing himself rather than simply being. In moments like that, reading what his earlier self had once considered important felt like an antidote to detachment, so he kept scrolling through his notebook.

One entry stood out, a quote from Nikolai Gogol:

"Human obsession with finding meaning is a way to escape the absurdity of existence."

Life was never a finished script. In the middle of repetition, it still demanded creation. When words were chosen to write out in careful handwriting, thoughts seemed to gain weight, like wearing designer clothes.

Nikolai Gogol had written about a man who lost his mirror. The mirror was a way of seeing the self. Without it, his image started to blur. It felt like a warning of what Cash might see in his own reflection if he went too far in what he was becoming. Or in what others had already decided he was, like the woman from Communications.

Langley, on the other hand, had threatened about a world where the mirror would show absolutely nothing. A complete erasure from spacetime. It sounded worse than death. Yet what was the difference between death and nothingness? The latter echoed what Kitaro Nishida had described a century earlier. For Nishida, emptiness was the ground of everything because it was a possibility for a new beginning. Langley's warning and that idea of emptiness felt surprisingly close. Perhaps there was something Zen Buddhist in astrophysics.

Then he realized what he had just done. He had softened a terrifying, apocalyptic theory and given the cold physics an almost comforting human face, as if reality followed the logic of a Disney film, where everything had a happy ending. But reality could have been closer to an old VHS tape that snapped before the last scene, too.

Kate was in bed watching her shows on her laptop. The rule in the house was simple. No phones in bed. The same philosophy did not apply to laptops. Phones meant scrolling, notifications,

endless little hooks designed to steal attention. Laptops felt different. Watching a show on a laptop did not trigger the same kind of guilt as staring at a small blue screen.

Cash suspected it had something to do with the way people talked about phone radiation, and how phones near heads damaged sleep and attention spans. But no one ever wrote headlines about laptops on laps.

In the end, it probably had little to do with radiation or blue light. It was more about narrative consistency. Like the way people focused on the environmental harm of lithium batteries when criticizing electric cars, while carrying the same batteries in their phones and laptops without question. The problem was never the object itself. It was where attention was allowed to land.

Cash himself was on the couch, using his phone to scroll through social media and the latest news. A video appeared of a young woman speaking directly to the camera, dismantling the recent trend of young people suddenly discovering philosophers online. That annoyed him as Cash had liked philosophers long before it had become fashionable. Now, people probably assumed he belonged to the same category of twenty-year-olds posting quotes over sunset photos.

Philosophers had helped him during his early adulthood in the same way that music helped some people during difficult years. They had felt like consultants for life before lifestyle influencers existed. Intelligent people who had wrestled with existential questions.

Still, the woman made some interesting points.

The video began with Aristotle, whom Cash had always admired. He was one of the founders of rational philosophy and someone who had shaped the way science itself developed.

According to the woman, Aristotle should be cancelled because he openly believed that women were naturally inferior to men. He described women as essentially incomplete versions of men. This is why Aristotle came to the conclusion that ruling was the natural role of men.

Cash frowned slightly. He had never heard that before. He opened the woman's profile. The account name was provocatively chosen: philosuckers.

She claimed to be a philosophy PhD. Based on the profile picture, she must have been one of those who had graduated before the age of thirty. There was a term for that which Cash did not remember.

The quotes she showed from Aristotle were not flattering. Cash felt a strange mix of surprise and mild embarrassment. How had he never come across this before?

He kept scrolling, hoping the list would end quickly.

Heidegger appeared next. That one was not surprising. Cash already knew Heidegger had been a Nazi.

Then John Locke. The philosopher of liberty. The thinker who had influenced ideas about freedom and human rights. Apparently, Locke had also invested in companies connected to the slave trade.

Next came Nietzsche. That one did not even require opening the video. Nietzsche was probably the most misunderstood philosopher on the internet. People loved quoting him about strength and overcoming weakness. Usually, without reading the books the quotes came from.

And every time a mass shooter turned out to admire Nietzsche, his work was suddenly treated like dangerous literature again.

The internet had turned him into a motivational speaker for people who had never finished a philosophy book.

Cash kept scrolling. He saw Sartre. But not Camus. That brought a strange sense of relief. Which was ridiculous. He had never met Camus. Yet part of him felt protective of the man's reputation, as if someone attacking Camus would somehow damage something personal inside him. He wondered briefly whether he was protecting Camus or just protecting the version of himself who admired him.

Next came René Descartes. The father of modern rationalism.

"I think, therefore I am."

Cash had always loved that sentence. It felt clean and elegant like Einstein's famous equation.

The woman in the video explained that Descartes believed animals were essentially machines. Complex biological mechanisms without consciousness or the ability for real suffering.

The video described scientists performing operations on animals without anaesthesia because they believed the screams were only mechanical reactions. Noise without pain. That was difficult to hear. Cash liked French philosophers. But he liked animals more.

He thought about the cattle industry and how future generations might look back at modern farming the way people now looked back at older moral blind spots. Millions of animals living entire lives without space to move.

Perhaps every era had its own version of John Locke. People who spoke eloquently about morality while carrying enormous blind spots at the same time.

Cash opened another video even though he already suspected the pattern would continue.

It was Jean Jacques Rousseau. Kate had spoken about Rousseau multiple times during her education studies. Rousseau's ideas about childhood had influenced democratic schooling and the idea that learning should happen through curiosity instead of strict authority.

Kate had once said Rousseau changed the way the world understood childhood. Cash had believed that. But the video explained that Rousseau had sent all five of his own children to an orphanage. Maybe Cash would keep that discovery to himself, because Kate would have never admired that kind of parent.

Cash looked down the hallway toward the girls' bedroom. The idea felt almost impossible to imagine. Florence or Arabella growing up somewhere else. Without them. The thought made his chest tighten.

Rousseau had written passionately about the importance of childhood. Just not his own children's childhood.

It seemed philosophers were sometimes better parents to ideas than to people. Ideas did not cry in the night. They did not need comfort or patience or presence. That was the danger of loving ideas too much.

Cash put the phone down and went to bed. He did not want to become a philosucker. He wanted to be the kind of person who remembered that people came before ideas.

Chapter 1.30

During the loop, CBC's morning studio had become a kind of national psychological routine. The expert guests were carefully chosen. They had to be clear-spoken and, above all, hopeful. That was why it had been an easy sell to the producer when Cash had suggested bringing Langley as a guest. He had been invited to discuss the practical, real-life implications of the end of the loop. How it would likely happen, whether the final loops might be different in length, and whether their end would be visible to the human eye. But Cash's real motive was different. He wanted to warn the public about the dangers of relying on nuclear weapons for asteroid defence, because that solution had a risk of creating outcomes worse than the one it was meant to prevent. Even though Canada was not part of the coalition, the walls of Vancouver were filled with graffiti and posters supporting interception. BLAST THE AST was written everywhere. People wanted action and a sense of control. Often, those meant the same.

Physicists in Namibia had released new calculations showing a 99.7 percent probability that the asteroid would pass Earth without impact. The remaining 0.3 percent was linked to possible gravitational disturbances at the edge of the loop, which could not be fully predicted.

Despite the positive forecast, world leaders had not stepped back. On the contrary, they had only increased the number of drills.

Langley sat seriously under the bright lights of the CBC studio. Beside Cash sat a regular panelist, Julie Navarro, who was a crisis psychologist. The morning show host, Lena Chow, looked first into the camera, then at the panel.

"Now we are talking about something that surely concerns everyone. What happens if the loop ends? And will we be able to notice before it happens? Welcome to the program, Professor of Physics at the University of British Columbia, Dr. Langley Atwood."

Langley nodded politely and answered.

"You notice prediction failure."

The host looked surprised. He had not yet even asked a question. Still, he was experienced enough to move past the moment and continue where the conversation had naturally gone.

"Could you elaborate on that?"

“There are many predictable things despite the changes we cause ourselves. But the start for everyone has been identical. Now people might start to notice that not everything lines up the same way.”

“So the same script, but with typos,” Cash jumped in.

“That is a good way to put it. Except, typos compound and become changed sentences and eventually scenes, if you will. For a while, April 12th still looks like April 12th. But it is drifting.”

“Okay, so we don’t get a clean moment where we realize it’s our last cycle before tomorrow?” Chow asked. “No clear shift into April 13th?”

“That is the cinematic version. Sudden, neat, and easily comprehensible. But in reality, evidence points to the direction that the change will be gradual. As the loop degrades, entropy starts sneaking back in. Heat, motion, tiny quantum fluctuations, they all accumulate. People will notice slow and small transitions until the loop has completely faded.”

“So instead of a perfect loop, what do we have now?” Chow asked.

Langley took a piece of paper and a pen in front of him.

“Imagine drawing a circle freehand,” he said. “Up until now, the end always meets the beginning. Perfect closure. But now.” He sketched a rough loop. “Your hand shakes because of the turbulence, and the line wobbles. On each attempt, the gap gets a little bigger.”

He held it up. The ends did not quite meet.

“Eventually,” he said, “it does not close at all. It just keeps going.”

Julie studied the page and smiled. “That’s a beautiful image.”

“Yes, that part makes sense. But just so that I’m understanding this correctly, is there turbulence where the loop physically ends? That must complicate air traffic.”

“I did not mean turbulence literally. In physics, stable systems rarely fail all at once. As they approach a boundary, small fluctuations start to grow. They are irregularities small enough to go unnoticed. Until they are not. This is precisely how we were able to calculate the end of the loop. When a stable system moves into a state of near instability, these irregularities amplify.

In fluid dynamics, smooth flow becomes turbulent. In phase transitions, matter starts to flicker between states. The same principle would apply here if this is a physical process.

I must admit I may not have been awake enough in physics class during my school years. Sorry, Mrs. Livingston, wherever you are. But I am sure many people at home understood what you just told and can find comfort in it," Chow said warmly.

"So, kind of like how turbulence means disturbance of air flow, Langley means we might have some disturbance of time flow." Cash explained.

Langley shook his right hand and grinned, indicating that at least some of it was correct, even though the terms and concepts may have been described slightly incorrectly.

"Some people think we'll just wake up tomorrow and forget all of this." Cash said.

Langley shook his head. "From a physics standpoint, that is unlikely. That implies a theory that we would return to an earlier time in history, whereas it is more likely that we will keep on going as we are here, without the presence of the time loop."

"So the end of the loop isn't some explosion or cosmic event," Chow said, as if repeating learned knowledge to store it in her hippocampus.

Langley gave a small smile. "No fireworks."

"Then what is it?" Chow asked.

"Just the quiet return of the rules that were always supposed to apply."

"Speaking of fireworks," Chow said. "Welcome to the studio, also Julie Navarro, a psychologist from the Crisis Centre, and Cash Haggerty, a domestic affairs journalist from CBC, and sorry for the late introduction. This just got so interesting so quickly." She said and rubbed her hands together in excitement.

"No, no, Lena, I quite enjoyed that."

"Dr Atwood, what a start for our show," the host, Lena Chow, said with a smile.

"You and your research group deserve credit for helping us understand that the loop will end this year. That has surely brought hope and relief to many people around the world." She said, talking directly to Langley, and then glanced at Julie.

"Julie, how has this information about the tail end of the loop affected your work in the field?"

"It has brought both relief and a new kind of anxiety. Now that time will move forward again, many people are afraid of losing it. They remember again how fleeting time is and how important moments are."

The host nodded quietly and looked at Langley, as if asking for a broader perspective.
“That depends on what humanity does just before the end. I am talking about the asteroid,” Langley said more seriously than expected.
“Yes, of course. A serious concern. Could you share what we know about it?” the host asked.
“Well, as you may know, the asteroid is still officially considered a threat, but the probability is purely theoretical. They have left a small margin because no one knows if the loop’s boundary region can alter the asteroid’s trajectory. The estimated size of this asteroid is between 600 and 800 metres. The impact energy would be thousands of megatons of TNT. For comparison, the largest nuclear bomb ever detonated, the Soviet Tsar Bomba, was 50 megatons,” Langley said.
Julie raised her arm to ask for her turn to speak, but Langley was too deep in his explanation to pause.
“Thousands of kilometres would be vaporized in seconds. If it struck the ocean, tsunamis would sweep across continents. But the worst outcome would be fragmentation.”
Julie finally found an opening to speak. “Fortunately, major powers can strike it with missiles and break it into pieces small enough to burn up in the atmosphere.” She said with an all-knowing smirk.
Langley replied immediately. “Yes, after that kind of cosmic shotgun blast, some fragments would burn up. But most would not. In 2013, a 20-metre meteor exploded over Chelyabinsk. That was equivalent to 500 kilotons of TNT. Windows shattered. Fifteen hundred people were injured.”
The host swallowed. “And now we are talking about an asteroid that is.”
“At least thirty times larger,” Langley said. “If it fragments, we could see hundreds or even thousands of impacts worldwide. Each one like Chelyabinsk.”
“But air defence missiles,” Julie tried.
“No chance. Objects of this size pass straight through. Even Israeli physicists admitted in the leaked recording that Iron Dome would not help,” Cash added.
Langley nodded, showing he agreed with Cash. “They tried to explain the physics, but the political decision had already been made.”

“It seems you have your own coalition here,” Julie said. “Perhaps the host could bring us back to the topic.”

“That leaves nuclear weapons. Ballistic missiles are not enough. Only nuclear weapons might be able to break the asteroid apart. But then we are gambling again,” Langley said.

“What risks do nuclear weapons bring?” the host asked. “An electromagnetic pulse. If the explosion happens too close to the atmosphere, it could disable global satellites and power grids. And if it happens too low, the fragments would be radioactive.”

“Radioactive fallout across the world,” The host repeated slowly.

“Exactly, basic physics,” Langley responded.

Cash thought it was now or never, as there may not be a better chance to inform the public about all the risks they deserved to know. “So are there any other risks nuclear explosions may cause?” He asked Langley, who did not hesitate.

“It depends on where the explosion occurs. The loop’s boundary is already shown to be unstable. If enough energy is released there, time could tear, creating a local region of absolute nothing.”

“That sounds a bit wild,” the host said, frowning.

Silence filled the panel. Julie Navarro leaned forward, her voice calm but firm.

“I understand that people need the truth, but how it is said matters. We shouldn’t frighten people with hypothetical scenarios that can’t even be verified. Billions have found hope in the idea that the loop will end. That life will continue. And now the same man who gave them hope is recklessly trying to take that away. I must say I’m very disappointed.” She paused and looked into the camera. “If what you just heard was actually true, you would not hear it at first from here.”

“Julie, we also have a responsibility to inform people about things that are hard to hear,” Cash said.

“So now responsibility means fear mongering,” Julie replied quickly.

“It means not filtering science based on how it feels.” Cash insisted.

Julie forced a smile. “Langley talked about time tearing. Time. And could not even explain what that means. That is just science fiction jargon.”

Cash felt his body calming and his concentration increasing. “Climate change also sounded speculative, until houses started burning every summer. Langley wasn’t speaking metaphorically.”

Julie looked at the host, silently asking him to stop this.

But Cash continued. “We don't know what a series of nuclear detonations will do at the loop’s boundary. And that means if we have even one chance to avoid tearing time apart, we should at least consider it.”

Langley lifted his gaze and nodded. Gratitude crossed his face.

“If we avoid these risks because they don't fit morning television, that is censorship. That's not what Canada stands for, and I'm sure Canadians now watching want to know what people in power already have known,” Cash said.

Then, slightly unexpectedly, Langley started a monologue that felt prepared.

“Aristotle believed the world was eternal. According to the Bible, it began in 4004 BCE. Today, we know the Earth is 4.5 billion years old, and the universe is 13.8 billion years old. There are many things we are still completely wrong about. Where we once relied on religion, we now rely on science. But the human mind craves certainty. It clings to familiar stories because chaos feels frightening. Copernicus made people doubt that Earth was the centre of the universe. Bruno was burned alive, and Galileo was forced to stay quiet about his findings. Newton predicted the end of the world. It did not happen. And now. Now we are once again avoiding facts. We have clear data showing the asteroid will pass Earth without our involvement, yet we trust the simple power of missiles more than the harder language of natural science.”

When the cameras shut off, the sound engineer gave a thumbs-up. Cash did not feel victorious. Surely more people now knew about the possibility, and many of them may have been frightened. Cash would not have wanted to take hope away from those for whom hope had been the only thing still holding them together. People were not to blame. In the end, everything rested on theories, models, and mathematical uncertainty. Cash had naively thought the broadcast would explode across the internet. It did not. For most people, it only reinforced what they already believed. Those who were already critical of launching nuclear missiles might now be more open to hearing what other risks existed beyond the possibility of radioactive fragments

being sent toward Earth in a situation where the asteroid would otherwise pass by harmlessly. But if missiles felt like the only safe solution, Langley's theories could easily sound like conspiracy thinking and a waste of public money.

Cash thought about how long people had argued over whether climate change was real or a myth, while doing nothing about it. Now the situation might be reversed. It was like the leaders of the coalition wanted to add one more bullet to a Russian roulette revolver because that was how the rules were played, without understanding that they could just as well play with no bullets, or choose not to play at all. At the same time, maybe Cash himself had placed all his chips on a single number that belonged to Langley's theories. And the roulette wheel had thirty-seven slots. The chance of being right was under three percent. There was something paradoxical about preaching probabilities while personally betting only on the smallest odds.

Julie was right about science having to be verified. Science could not rely solely on being right. One person could make a revolutionary observation, but without peer review, without others refining and repeating it, it remained only a claim. Knowledge did not emerge in a vacuum. It always layered itself on top of what came before like an old cathedral. Sometimes the earlier layers were pure nonsense, bad design. In the nineteenth century, experts had recommended arsenic to brighten the face and cocaine to treat children's coughs. Some of it was honest ignorance and cultural blind spots of the time. That was precisely why the scientific method existed. People were often wrong. One example was Ignaz Semmelweis, a Hungarian doctor, who was the first to connect doctors' dirty hands to the deaths of women in childbirth. He demanded hand washing in delivery rooms and was met only with ridicule and laughter. He was not believed because he spoke of invisible pathogens that science had not yet identified. Based on what people knew about the past, it was inevitable that the current knowledge would be red-penned in the future. Would Langley be seen as a pioneer ahead of his time, like Galileo or Bruno, or would he remain in history as a cautionary example of a pseudoscientist who drowned in his own vision?

Chapter 1.31

Kate slept beside Cash, her breathing steady like a quiet metronome. Cash listened to the rhythm and let it hold him in this moment. So many nights his mind had run through calculations, probabilities, and uncertainties, but not tonight. Tonight, he let the silence settle over him like a blanket.

He got up carefully so he would not wake Kate. The floor felt cool under his feet as he walked to the girls' room and tried to open the door as quietly as possible. The door let out a creak, a reminder that, like his bike chain, the hinges were just as lacking in oil every single day. Florence and Arabella were absorbed in their virtual simulations, which most people called dreams. There was something deeply real about their presence.

For the first time in months, he did not feel the need to check the news. The loop would end, or it would not. The asteroid would hit or it would not. He had done everything he could. None of it had truly been in his hands. He might have believed so, but the world was too large to be changed by one person at the grassroots level.

He was not sure what had changed. Maybe exhaustion, acceptance, or the fact that President Hogan had unexpectedly changed course and urged other countries to reconsider missile strikes, pointing to the same evidence Langley had presented on the morning show a week earlier.

Had someone in the White House listened? Had their voices reached through?

"No, it was just basic physics. Nothing they did not already know," Langley had said.

Not everyone was convinced. Some believed Hogan's change of direction had more to do with the estimated impact site than with logic. If the asteroid hit, it would not strike North America, but northwestern China, in Xinjiang.

Cash did not know whether China's silence was a sign of responsibility or strategic caution. History seemed to show that when the risk of failure was high, China did not draw its sword but moved pieces quietly in the background, ready to take credit if everything went well and to find a scapegoat if it did not.

There were rumours of Chinese satellites being moved along the asteroid's projected path, but because these reports were shared by individuals rather than larger institutions, Cash did not

believe them. He understood the paradox. Not long ago, he himself had been one of those individuals, urging others not to trust major expert institutions like NASA.

The next morning, Cash did not check the news or call Langley. Instead, he took Florence and Arabella to Stanley Park. The air was fresh from the rain that had just ended.

They walked the paths, stopping whenever the girls found something worth examining, a fallen leaf, a branch, a dog shaking off rain.

Near the golf course, Florence tilted her head and watched the players.

“They come here every day,” she said, more curious than judgmental.

“They must really love golf,” Cash replied.

“Maybe they love the loop,” Florence said. “Getting to do the same thing over and over again.”

Cash thought about how deep that idea was. Maybe it was not about the game, but about how the same rules repeated themselves while the outcome was always slightly different, even if the technique stayed exactly the same. No two shots were ever identical, even when aiming for perfection. And how many people would enjoy the sport if every shot and every round were flawless? No, it was a conscious choice to choose repetition that felt meaningful, even if from the outside it looked like nothing more than hitting a motionless ball forward with different clubs.

They heard music drifting from a small performance space at the edge of the park. The song was one of those that had spread around the world during the loop like a whale song, even though the original recording no longer existed. Cash had heard countless artists perform it, most recently a few weeks earlier at a stadium concert by an Icelandic rock band. It was remarkable how different artists still found their way to Vancouver stages. Bands toured cities using the sound and production systems already built into the venues. The arrangement benefited everyone. It reminded Cash of the pandemic, when musicians had played concerts in their living rooms to a camera, audiences watching from their couches. Artists were excellent at adapting.

By the shore, Florence shouted triumphantly.

“Dad, look.” She held up a smooth, round stone. “It looks like a tiny planet.”

Cash knelt beside her and took the stone in his hand. “It really does,” he said.

Arabella had already found flat stones. Florence had taken tennis lessons, but Cash suspected Arabella would have benefited from them more. Where Florence was fascinated by the air inside the ball, Arabella would have loved its bounce.

Cash understood both languages. It was astonishing how they had created two children who were so complete, yet so different.

“How far can we make them skip?” Cash asked, challenging them.

They spent the afternoon throwing stones and watching the patterns spread across the surface of the water.

Waiting for the end of the world had not felt this relaxed in a long time. Time was a strange thing. People spoke about it casually, as if existence itself were not already an impossibility. Just as people had happily normalized flying through a metal tube at twelve kilometres above the ground. It stopped being a wonder after the first five times of taking photos of airplane wings before takeoff.

Then again, not everyone even had the chance to fly. The whole train of thought sounded uncomfortably privileged. To treat incredible things as ordinary.

Cash had everything he needed to feel grateful to someone or something, even to himself. The loop had been, above all for them, a gift. Extra time with the children, free and priceless. Could extra healthy years even be quantified in money?

Perhaps a survey like that would be interesting to conduct with retired billionaires. Would one additional healthy year be worth a billion? Would they give away their entire fortune to have the body of a twenty-year-old again? That was something to pitch to Chris.

That evening, after the girls were asleep, Cash and Kate sat on the balcony.

“11:11,” Kate said, and closed her eyes. She was not remembering the fallen of the First World War, as she did on November 11 at eleven, but making a wish.

“I know you do not believe in it,” she continued, “but I have seen it for several days in a row now. It means we are on the right path.”

In the end, it did not matter whether the universe handed out free wishes like a genie when you happened to see the time eleven past eleven. Cash thought there was power in simply putting a wish into words.

Kate had once said that Cash, with his explanations, turned something beautiful and sparkling into a dull business lesson. Cash understood exactly what she meant. No one wanted to eat half a kilo of butter, sugar, and flour separately, but when you mixed them, baked them, and added icing, the whole became more than the sum of its parts. Reality did not need to be deconstructed.

Kate rested her head against Cash's chest. Sometimes marriage felt like being roommates, but tonight he remembered their first meeting at university and all the paths they had walked to build a shared life from which two new ones had grown.

"Are you happy?" Kate asked.

Cash thought.

Bertrand Russell had written that happiness was not found in certainty, but in the ability to live without it. Happiness had always felt like something you could not, or at least should not, feel during the loop.

He who fears suffering already suffers because he fears.

Montaigne.

Hello, anxiety. Hello, fear.

They existed, but they were not him.

They were visitors, not intruders.

You think you have memory, but memory has you.

John Irving.

People chased tomorrow their whole lives, believing it was theirs to shape, until they understood that it had been shaping them.

Time had always been a river, carrying them forward, even as the current repeated itself again and again.

Cash exhaled and ran his fingers lightly through Kate's hair. Kate leaned into him.

Kate had always believed that everything had to have a purpose. The loop was not a prison. What it was did not matter. He did not need answers. The loop could have been just an unfortunate coincidence. But even if it was, it had given him this. This life, exactly as he had chosen to live it today.

Florence, drawing a calendar that existed only in her mind.

Arabella, laughing at everything like the fourteenth Dalai Lama.

Kate, laughing at silly misunderstandings that meant nothing, and at the same time meant everything.

Cash knew the word for all of it.

Epilogue

Kate had once been crushed in a grocery store simply because she had to go there week after week. The cyclical nature of everyday life made her anxious, even though life itself was good. During their student years, things had been different. There had been no money and no responsibility for others, and therefore no need for systematic planning or mapping out every lunch and dinner in advance. Individual items were bought for the fridge as the need arose. There had been something about it that felt like freedom, or perhaps time had simply gilded the memories.

Eventually, Cash and Kate decided that a five-dollar delivery fee was a small investment compared to how much trouble grocery shopping had begun to cause. So Cash received a three-hundred-dollar grocery delivery and unpacked the arriving paper bags into the refrigerator together with the girls, preparing for a new week.

This arrangement was also easier than having to explain to Arabella at the grocery store why they did not buy everything that other children got. Cash had managed to avoid a four-year-old's tantrums a few times by suggesting that they take a photo of the desired product and send it to the grandparents as a gift idea. Many parenting tricks turned out to be single-use, and so did this one when Arabella announced that she did not want the item as a gift later because she wanted it now. Fair enough.

Adulthood meant that repetitive things could be arranged to be pleasant, or at least tolerable. That was adulthood's privilege, but also its curse. When no one said sweets could not be eaten before dinner, an adult could simply eat ice cream before the meal. And when no one limited screen time, a dopamine addiction could grow deeper and deeper without anyone saying stop.

Immanuel Kant had woken every morning at five, written for three hours, and walked to his university to lecture. According to legend, the people of Königsberg set their clocks by his walking rhythm. Cash was not as consistent, but he was fascinated by the idea that routines could give everyday life a rhythm that felt voluntary rather than imposed from the outside.

So Cash began holding on to small, recurring things he could influence. One of them was bicycle maintenance, which he knew many cycling enthusiasts did better than him.

He lifted his single-speed bike down from the rack and brought it onto the balcony. He bent down and pressed the tires with his thumb. They felt firm enough. He took out the oil bottle that belonged to his weekly routine and let oil drip onto the gears.

Then he turned the pedals by hand. He checked the brakes. Some cyclists claimed that riding without brakes made cycling safer. They said that when stopping was impossible, the rider had to ride more safely. Cash did not understand that. It sounded like climbing cliffs or skyscrapers without a rope, which had also become surprisingly popular, considering the life-threatening risks involved. Cash did not know any climber who used a rope and deliberately wanted to fall, or any cyclist who believed they were immortal simply because they had a helmet and brakes.

He squeezed the brake lever and checked the response. Finally, he slipped the oil bottle back into the pouch under the saddle. A serviced bike felt like a body after a nice massage. The weird comparison made him glance at his badminton racket. Its grip had to be replaced, too.

Changing the racket grip was a nice ritual once he had learned how to do it properly. At first, it had been something people would ask more advanced players to do for them, but learning new things only required a bit of cognitive effort. After the initial resistance, it became quite fun and rewarding.

Cash sat down, removed the old grip tape, and began wrapping the new one from bottom to top. Turn by turn, firm but not too tight. He secured it with a small strip of black tape at the end. The result felt like a small work of art, understood only by racket sport players. There was surprisingly much pride in it.

The games started on court 4, always at half past seven. Today, besides Cash, there were Ahmed, Roger, Declan, and Steve. Steve started on the bench because he had lost the most games the previous week. This system kept the games suitably intense and serious, since no one wanted to begin a ninety-minute session by sitting. The competitive spirit was like a silently agreed-upon rule that made the time meaningful. Kate had once said that sports were supposed to be fun, and Cash's descriptions of the games sounded as if he thought they were all professional athletes. Cash disagreed because he did not see competitive sports and the joy of sports as opposites. On the contrary, they went hand in hand.

After an hour and a half of pulsing play, Cash had the second-most won sets after Ahmed, so he avoided the first bench rotation once again. They walked together to the other wing of the hall, where a small but tidy electric sauna was located. Each of them carried two towels from the sports center reception, one for the sauna and one for washing afterward. It did not feel very ecological, but it was part of the membership benefits.

"In some countries, you could grab a beer from that restaurant fridge and bring it in here," Cash said, wondering how it was possible to have that much more relaxed alcohol policy in Europe.

"On the other hand, in European countries you're not allowed to bring beer into the stands," Roger knew.

Cash was surprised and said he had not known that. A good beer obviously belonged to watching sports, but perhaps Europeans followed sports even more fanatically, so regulations were needed. In the sauna, throwing water on the heater was forbidden. Next to the door hung a large sign that said:

Do not throw water on the electrical device!

Cash felt a strange déjà vu, as if he had already heard this exact conversation play out somewhere earlier. The heater in question had never been meant for a dry sauna. Its elements and pipes would rust without regular steam. Yet, nobody was willing to gamble their membership or risk the sauna getting closed over a little act of rebellion against the posted instructions.

Cash looked at the aspen-wood benches and heard Ahmed tell:

"I was on a work trip a couple of weeks ago, and when I came back, my kid had grown like crazy, man. It was amazing, but made me cry a little because time moves so fast."

Silence settled on the benches. Everyone knew what was being talked about. If not as a parent, then as a child or grandchild. Time was brutally limited.

As he left the hall, Cash looked at the court where another group was already starting their turn. The same serves, the same movements, the repeated strategy of the game. They were all like the marching children in a Pink Floyd music video, brought onto the court and sent away at the right time because they believed in the idea of the game. Sports were, in a way, like adults' play. That was something that, of course, could never be said out loud like that.

On the bike ride home, Cash's gaze caught a familiar shape. A five-leaf clover. He bent down and picked it up out of old habit. He did not even have time to ask himself why. He found dozens of four-leaf clovers every summer, but five-leaf ones were rarer. It wasn't a skill. It was a way of looking that recognized asymmetry. Some people said it was luck. Cash thought it was essentially based on being willing to see something unexpected when everything looked ordinary. A sensitivity to deviations also made him spot typos instantly. They bothered him unnecessarily every time, even though he did not describe himself as a perfectionist by nature. He simply felt he easily noticed what stood out as different within a series of similarities.

His sister had once said that a five-leaf clover was a sign of bad luck, something that broke the natural order. But Cash had never believed in prophetic dreams, horoscopes, or knocking on wood to protect oneself from fate. Still, he picked up the clover just to bring it home. Despite his rationality, Cash always did this, just in case. It followed much the same logic as when people chose to believe, because why not, when it did not cost anything. With disbelief, a place in the afterlife would be automatically lost, but by choosing to gamble, at least the individual stayed in the roulette of religions.

He continued on his way, the five-leaf clover in his hand. It felt wrong, somehow, like the green zero on the roulette table that nobody wanted, the outlier that broke the game and stole the win from everyone else.

When the girls were already asleep, Cash felt a stab of guilt for not having had time to say good night. Kate was visibly exhausted. Every day life with children was rewarding but draining. If parenthood was a tax, what kind would it be? Certainly not capital gains tax or income tax. Perhaps a tax not collected in money but in sleep debt and worry. That was why the tax authority's pages and processes were like melatonin, restoring what had been taken in excess during the previous year.

For some, children were perhaps an investment in the future, at least from society's point of view. Why else would it offer free education and healthcare? Society expected the investment to bear fruit, that the apples of the apple tree would fall to the ground and grow into new apple trees.

Cash and Kate let the girls grow as they wished. They owed them nothing. On the contrary. Cash and Kate had given them life, but the girls had given them another one.

Thank you

When you show an early draft to someone, it later feels like you placed your newborn in their hands. At the time, you did not think to ask whether they had washed their hands, or whether they even knew how to hold a baby. The one they held looked slightly surprised to exist, and gradually it lost its baby features as its face sharpened. It found its own voice and personality. At some point, it stopped feeling like something I had made and started feeling like something that had always been.

Looking back, it could not have been easy to read those early pages. They were raw and often confusingly abstract, closer to a series of thoughts placed one after another.

Still, no one took away my motivation. Instead, I was offered subtle parenting advice to help something fragile survive. Many books get started, but what percentage are completed?

Kind of like what a good parent does, I saw my work as something very early to play with the adults. It was not, but based on the feedback I received, I was able to be a hockey dad who told my child where to focus in their practice program before the draft year.

Thank you, my wife, Katija, for reading the final version and helping it sound at home in English without taking away its voice. She came up with the title and gave me the space to be creative and the hours to write, while we had our little one growing at the same time.

Lula, thank you for existing. You have given my life a kind of meaning and joy that no sentence can quite hold. Your birth and your presence sparked something creative in me. This new family life also taught me to value the hours I have for writing, and the discipline it requires. It reminded me of what Haruki Murakami writes in *What I Talk About When I Talk About Running*, where he reflects on how some people do not see him as a real writer because he is not completely exhausted or lost when he writes, but instead runs every day so he can keep writing.

I wanted to make something for you, something you might read when you are older and maybe laugh again, like you did so many times while I was writing this, or feel proud of your dad.

My brother Rasmus, this work would likely not exist without you. Reading your short stories during our trip to Paris made me think that I could write fiction too. Until then, I had only written nonfiction. The idea for the plot came to me on our flight back to Calgary, and you were

probably the first person I messaged about it. Your intrigued response was enough to get me started.
You read my drafts in two languages and were always willing to begin again when a new version appeared. You also helped confirm that the physics in the book made sense. You have a degree in physics, and I do not.
My sister Noora, thank you for showing me that publishing books, and most other things, becomes possible the moment you decide that you can do almost anything if you try and believe in yourself.
And my dad, who read my first draft in English and gave positive feedback, and my mom, who read the Finnish version after asking the English version to be translated. The translation, or more like the rewriting process, made me think more analytically. Writing in another language shifted the context. It felt like accessing a different memory bank. English drew from my life in Canada. Finnish reached further back, sometimes to places I had not intended to revisit. My Mom read the whole book and said it was great, even though very scientific. I took that feedback and made the language slightly lighter.
Simo, a journalist at Helsingin Sanomat, read one of the earliest drafts, when the story was little more than a skeleton of its journalistic side, loosely held together and slightly overconfident. He left comments, suggestions, and pointed out how extensive the resources I had given to the journalists were. He was right.
Becks, Jojo, and Wes, for stepping in early when the work was still taking shape, and for appreciating the work. Becks described how quickly he was able to read the book because it was engaging. Jojo found it philosophical and well-written, just too short. Wes said it was interesting and that there was a book in there somewhere, just not quite yet. That was all true. The book needed to mature. Many times, I let it move away from home a bit too early, and I needed someone to say, Esa, your child is less than two years old.
Thank you also to my colleagues for deep weekly conversations in the staff room, which expanded the world of this book by challenging my sceptical mind with different ways of seeing reality. Some of those conversations found their way into these pages.

Thanks, Dev, for encouraging me to use his name in the book. There had originally been a character named Dev Patel in the book before he joined the company. I changed the name to avoid suggesting that any of the characters would be based on real people.

Thank you, Timo, for always being ready to see my work, no matter the type of art. Our conversations made the process feel less mysterious because he had already done it. When I lived in Portugal, Timo came to visit me while he was travelling across Europe to write his book.

I know there are many names I have not mentioned. My close friends, relatives, and teachers who shaped me into the person and writer I am today. It sounds cliché, but you know who you are.

And to you, the reader who made it this far. Reaching the acknowledgements is a kind of commitment, and never the most exciting part, except when trying to find one's own name in them. These pages can feel like the final scene of a movie, when the lights are about to come back on, and everyone is deciding how they feel about what just happened. Feel free to write your name here unless you got the copy from a library: _____

And finally, thank you to myself. Many authors forget this. With a young child, writing happens late at night or early in the morning, when others are asleep. I began writing this for no reason other than that I enjoyed it, even when this child refused to sleep. I recognize that the child analogy no longer feels right, but I have already committed to it. So, unlike in the book, I will not loop back to the beginning. I move forward.